



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

CONTENTS

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT— [Col. 1]

BUSINESS OF THE HOUSE— [Col. 58]

PAPERS—

- (a) Report of the Finance Committee on the Virtual Asset Service Providers Bill, 2025 — [Col. 12]
- (b) Report of the Finance Committee on the National Health Insurance Amendment Bill, 2025 — [Col. 12]
- (c) Report of the Finance Committee on the Annual Budget Estimates for General Government Services for the year ending 31st December, 2025 — [Col. 12]
- (d) Report of the Committee on Energy on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition for the year ending 31st December, 2026 — [Col. 13]
- (e) Report of the Committee on Information and Communications on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations for the year ending 31st December, 2026 — [Col. 13]
- (f) Report of the Committee on Public Administration and State Interest on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Office of the Head of Civil Service for the year ending 31st December, 2026 — [Col. 13]
- (g) Report of the Committee on Public Administration and State Interest on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Public Service Commission for the year ending 31st December, 2026 — [Col. 13]
- (h) Report of the Joint Committee on Trade, Industry & Tourism and Chieftaincy, Culture & Religious Affairs on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of

Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts for the year ending 31st December, 2026 — [Col. 13]

- (i) Report of the Committee on Environment, Science and Technology on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Environment, Science and Technology for the year ending 31st December, 2026 — [Col. 14]
- (j) Report of the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Food and Agriculture for the year ending 31st December, 2026 — [Col. 14]
- (k) Report of the Committee on Education on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Education for the year ending 31st December, 2026 — [Col. 14]
- (l) Report of the Committee on Judiciary on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Judiciary and Judicial Service for the year ending 31st December, 2026 — [Col. 14]
- (m) Report of the Joint Committee on Defence & Interior, and Security and Intelligence on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of the Interior for the year ending 31st December, 2026 — [Col. 14]
- (n) Report of the Budget Committee on the Annual Budget Estimates for other Government Obligations for the year ending 31st December, 2026 — [Col. 14]
- (o) Report of the Committee on Defence and Interior on the Contract Agreement between GoG and Airbus Helicopter (SAS) for the supply of One (1) H160 and Three (3) H175 Helicopters for the Ghana Air Force — [Col. 244]
- (p) Report of the Committee on Defence and Interior on the Sale and Purchase Contract Agreement between GoG and Dassault Aviation for the acquisition of One (1) Falcon 6X for the Ghana Air Force — [Col. 244]

ANNUAL ESTIMATES—

- (a) Audit Service — [Col. 104]
- (b) Electoral Commission — [Col. 134]
- (c) Ministry of Education — [Col. 185]

MOTION

Contract Agreement between GoG and Airbus Helicopter for the supply of one H160 and three H175 Helicopters and Sale and Purchase Contract Agreement between GoG and Dassault Aviation for the acquisition of One (1) Falcon 6X for the Ghana Air Force — [248]

RESOLUTIONS—

- (a) Contract Agreement between GoG and Airbus Helicopter for the Supply of One H160 and Three H175 Helicopters for the Ghana Air Force— [Col. 268]
- (b) Contract Agreement between GoG and Dassault Aviation for the acquisition of One Falcon 6X for the Ghana Air Force— [Col. 269]

STATEMENTS—

- (a) Ghana's National Farmers' Day — [Col. 15]
- (b) Tribute to the Late Hon Ernest Kumi — [Col. 41]
- (c) Office of the Special Prosecutor — [Col. 99]

ADJOURNMENT— [Col. 272]

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

THIRD MEETING, 2025

Thursday, 4th December, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 12:25 p.m.*

[HON SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR ANDREW ASIAMAH AMOAKO,
IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let me implore you to turn to the item numbered 5 on today's *Order Paper*—Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We would start with the *Votes and Proceedings* of Wednesday, 3rd December, 2025.

Page 1...6. Is it because the Member of Parliament for Afadjato South is not here?

Page 7...25— Yes, Hon Member for Afadjato South?

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you so much.

The item numbered (xiv) which has the name "Albertha"—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Which page is that? Is it on the page numbered 25?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, the page numbered 25. If the Clerks can take a second look at the spelling, that version should be deleted and the name, properly spelled.

I came in a bit late, so please indulge me. Let me kindly walk you to the page numbered 6. Respectfully, if you look at the list of Members who attended Proceedings yesterday as against those who were absent with permission and without permission, if we add them up, it clearly shows that the total figure of the Members of the House stood at 275. Currently, the House is made up of 276 Members.

I checked and realised that the Hon Member for Adaklu, the Minister for Roads and Highways has inadvertently been omitted from the data of Parliament as at yesterday. So, if that could be corrected—

Mr Speaker, on the page numbered 7, the item numbered 5(a)(i), could we insert the word "by" after the word "led". I do not know if the Clerks are with me on this.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I did not get that.

Mr Afriyie: On the second line of the item numbered 5(a)(i), after the word "led", insert the word "by".

If that is not already corrected, let us move to the item numbered 7 on page 10, the second line. May we delete the word after “as” and insert the word “corrected”. Are we together?

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

12:35 p.m.

Mr Afriyie: Thank you for now.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So that explains why when you were not here, your Hon Brothers said Hon Frank Afriyie is not here.

Yes, Ms Patricia Appiagyei?

Ms Patricia Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, thank you. Making reference to page number 25, Hon Frank Afriyie talked about the spelling of the name “Albertha”. I think we have to make due search because people have a way of spelling their names. I know some people spell Agatha with an “r”; some spell with an “a”. So, we need to find out the correct spelling for that. So, Table should please take note.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, I think that is right. So, Table, just check with the list they presented and find out whether they put up that spelling themselves. But I direct that all the corrections that have been made be

acknowledged by the Table. We turn to page 26.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, if the Table may make this small correction on the item numbered (v) on page 24, the official name for the Ministry is Food and Agriculture. So, could they just indicate Food and Agriculture against the Deputy Minister’s name in the “Attendance at the Committee” labelling for the position of Mr John Setor Dumelo. They omitted the “Food”. All my official records and the Reports have “Food and Agriculture”.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, thank you. Hon Deputy Minister for Food and Agriculture, is the official name of the ministry now Food and Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs?

Deputy Minister for Food and Agriculture (Mr John Setor Dumelo) (MP): Mr Speaker, it is Ministry of Food and Agriculture. That is now the official name. Cocoa Board is no longer with the ministry; they have been moved to the Ministry of Finance.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I thought the name still remains as Ministry of Food and Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs.

Mr Dumelo: It is just the name of the Committee.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: All right. So, the Committee has Food and Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs?

Mr Dumelo: Yes, please.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: But when it comes to functioning, it is within the Ministry of Finance. All right.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, even as a House, we must also amend the name of the Committee to correspond with the change. Because when the Cocoa Board was brought back to the Ministry of Food and Agriculture, and in 2020 or so, it was brought back to the Ministry of Finance, they changed the Ministry's name before we entered 2021.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: It was with the Ministry of Finance, then in 2017 during the time of Hon Akoto Afriyie, it was brought to the Ministry of Food and Agriculture.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, it was brought back to the Ministry of Food and Agriculture. Later, it was brought back to the Ministry of Finance. But the Ministry took steps to amend its name and we could not. We allowed the name of the Committee to stay. So, if it is material, then we may have to but if it is not material, we would leave it.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Going forward, Parliament should be strong enough such that we would not allow the Executive to change the names just like that.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I agree with you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I think we should have a legislation on that, so that we have the names of the Ministries.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I agree that it is the Executive that by deliberate policy decisions decides where to place agencies in terms of their priorities. So, we are then obligated as a House to align with what the Executive intends to do with the agencies because we exercise oversight. As we speak, the Right to Information Commission (RTI) was inadvertently placed under Government Communications, but the oversight is exercised by the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice. So, yesterday, we were compelled to make those changes. So, we need to ensure that the agencies over which we exercise oversight are properly aligned with the Committees' mandates because the mandates of the Committees vary.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I think we have to sit down and look at this holistically.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, and adjust.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Page 26...33 —

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, the page under review, item 3, (iv).

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Which page?

Mr Afriyie: On page 33, the name of the Hon Member, "Eric Afful", the spelling of the "Eric" is wrong. Could we delete that and insert the proper version.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Table, kindly acknowledge that correction.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, item number (lv), on page 31, the position of Dr Cyracus at the time was acting Judicial Secretary. He was the deputy but he was elevated as the acting until a substantive Judicial Secretary was appointed. I am well versed in this matter.

So, the record should reflect that the time that he appeared before the Committee, he was the acting Judicial Secretary.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hold on. So now we have a substantive Judicial Secretary?

Mr Dafeamekpor: We have a substantive Judicial Secretary which is different from this name. The new Judicial Secretary is Senior Musa Ahmed. But at the time Justice Cyracus even appeared, he had been elevated. So, he is now a substantive High Court Judge.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Substantive High Court Judge? So, when he appeared, what was his designation?

Mr Dafeamekpor: He was acting Judicial Secretary.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: When was that?

Mr Dafeamekpor: This was 27th October, 2025. I was in that meeting briefly.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Table, kindly acknowledge that. So, we turn to page 34...36.

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Wednesday, 3rd December, 2025, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

We will turn to the Business Statement, the item numbered 6.

12:45 p.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I plead with you that we lay some Papers before we take the Business Statement?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I think we agreed that the Business Statement would be taken in the afternoon.

Mr Dafeamekpor: So, Mr Speaker, with your leave, we may take the item numbered 9(b), (c), (d) to (k), then after, we may want to take Motions in respect to those that are ready.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Before then, allow me to acknowledge our guests at the Public Gallery.

We have four schools, and the first school is Sabronum Nana Appiadu D/A Junior High School. They are led by their head teacher, Mr Simon Asante. The school is located in the Ahafo Ano South East Constituency.

Yes, the Member of Parliament for Ahafo Ano South East is my Friend. I hope you have seen your students? So, after proceedings, find a way of making them happy. *[Laughter]*

You may resume your seat.

[Pupils of Sabronum Nana Appiadu D/A Junior High School were acknowledged.]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The second school is Kokomlemle 1 Basic School, and they are led by Rev Joseph Yeboah, who is the assistant headmaster of the school. The school is located in the Ayawaso Central Constituency.

The Member of Parliament is here. Indeed, you have your guest school; kindly make them feel at home.

[Pupils of Kokomlemle 1 Basic School were acknowledged.]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The third school is Odoben T.I. Ahamadiyya School, and they are also led by Mr Malik Hammond, who is the head teacher. The school is located in the Asikuma Odoben Brakwa Constituency.

The Member of Parliament is around, and he will attend to you.

[Pupils of Odoben T.I Ahamadiyya School were acknowledged.]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The last school is Dan Attain Christian International School, and they are led to this august House by Mr Julius Eklon, who is the head teacher. The school is located in Ketu North Constituency.

The Hon Member is not around.

[Pupils of Dan Attain Christian International School were acknowledged.]

So, you are all welcome. We wish you a pleasant stay, and we hope you monitor what goes on here. It should energise you to go and study hard so that tomorrow you may also replace us when we are not here.

You are once again welcome.

Yes, Hon Leader?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I, with the concurrence of my Brother across the ocean, pray that we take the item numbered 9 and lay all the Papers there.

Mr Speaker, with your leave, the Chairpersons of the Finance and Budget Committees are considering some referrals this morning; they started very early, and I went to join them briefly. So, I pray for leave to do this on his behalf.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, it is early days yet. We will support our Colleague, except that he should give us the movement plan. We want to know the Motions. As for the laying of Papers, we are not opposed; he should do it. We want to know how the Motions will be taken.

Mr Speaker, once we have the movement plan, then there will be no surprises. Also, to add that, yesterday, if he recalls, his Side had the whole day and presented three unanswered Statements, and I prayed that we at least have two on our Side, maybe to respect the ratio.

So, Mr Speaker, this is a reminder that my Colleagues are on their way here

and when the time is right, we will take two Statements on our Side.

Mr Speaker, he can go ahead to do the laying.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, we can proceed. The prayer is heard.

Mr Dafeamekpor: So, Mr Speaker, we will do the laying, then we will intervene with the Statements, then after the Statements, we will take the Reports.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, apart from the two Statements that you gladly admitted, there is a commemorative Statement because of the Farmers' Day. So, we will have to take that one too; I have a number of them. We can take two on their Side, and one on our Side.

So, Mr Speaker, with your discretion, since it is a commemorative Statement and tomorrow is a holiday —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, can we do it this way? I do not know the owners of the Statements. So, we can take a commemorative Statement, and for the other Statements, we can hold on. If it is not even taken today, the next day we will give that a priority. So, we would take the commemorative Statement and then one other Statement.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I have relayed the roadmap of how events will take place. When we finish with the laying of the Papers, then we can take the

Statements. Honestly, I think that we can still take the three Statements. The two Statements that we agreed on are commemorative. We can limit the contributions to one on each Side. The Deputy Minister is here; luckily, he will add his voice, and then we will nail it there. Then, we can take the two Statements as agreed yesterday, and then, we take the Motions.

Mr Speaker, does he see that we are collaborating?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, let us move on

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, Mr Speaker, the item numbered 9(a)(i)(ii) and (iii)

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I did not see you bowing. The application has already been granted.

PAPERS

By the Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor) on behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee—

- i. Report of the Finance Committee on the Virtual Asset Service Providers Bill, 2025.
- ii. Report of the Finance Committee on the National Health Insurance Amendment Bill, 2025.
- iii. Report of the Finance Committee on the Annual Budget Estimates for General Government Services for the year ending 31st December, 2025.

12:55 p.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the item numbered 9(b).

By the Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor) on behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee —

- i. Report of the Committee on Energy on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition for the year ending 31st December, 2026.
- ii. Report of the Committee on Information and Communications on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations for the year ending 31st December, 2026.
- iii. Report of the Committee on Public Administration and State Interest on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Office of the Head of Civil Service for the year ending 31st December, 2026.
- iv. Report of the Committee on Public Administration and State Interest on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Public Service Commission for the year ending 31st December, 2026.
- v. Report of the Joint Committee on Trade, Industry & Tourism and Chieftaincy, Culture & Religious Affairs on the Annual Budget

Estimates of the Ministry of Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

- vi. Report of the Committee on Environment, Science and Technology on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Environment, Science and Technology for the year ending 31st December, 2026.
- vii. Report of the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Food and Agriculture for the year ending 31st December, 2026.
- viii. Report of the Committee on Education on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Education for the year ending 31st December, 2026.
- ix. Report of the Committee on Judiciary on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Judiciary and Judicial Service for the year ending 31st December, 2026.
- x. Report of the Joint Committee on Defence & Interior, and Security and Intelligence on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of the Interior for the year ending 31st December, 2026.
- xi. Report of the Budget Committee on the Annual Budget Estimates for other Government Obligations for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, as agreed, may we vary the Business to take you back to item numbered 8—Statements. We also agreed on the sequence, so we will take the commemorative one first, then we will take the other two, and then we can proceed with Government Business.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, it is so.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, who is taking the commemorative Statement?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Hon Osei-Akoto.

STATEMENTS

Ghana's National Farmers' Day

Mr Seth Osei-Akoto (NPP—Atwima Mponua): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for giving me this opportunity to read a Statement on behalf of the farmers of the country and the celebration that is going to take place tomorrow.

Mr Speaker, I rise today to make a Statement on the floor of this honourable House as we reflect on the history, significance and evolution of Ghana's National Farmers' Day, a national celebration that recognises the men and women whose hands feed our nation and sustain our economy. National Farmers' Day was instituted in 1985 by the Provisional National Defence Council (PNDC) Government to honour our industrial farmers, fishermen and herdsmen.

This decision followed a turnaround from a period of severe hardships in our nation, which included the devastating 1983 bushfires and the arrival of one million Ghanaians deported from Nigeria.

During this period, our nation experienced extreme food shortages to the extent that we were forced to go door to door with a cup in hand, begging for food from the goodwill of benevolent countries. It is our farmers and fishermen who saved us from the national crisis. The PNDC Government rightly instituted National Farmers' Day to say *ayekoo* to them for their resilience and contribution. The first celebration was held at Osino in the Eastern Region in 1985, with prizes that included two pairs of Wellington boots and cutlasses. In 1986, these prizes were augmented to include radios, full pieces of cloth and agrochemicals. By 1987, the National Best Farmer Award was formally instituted, with the winner receiving a single carbin pick-up, while other award winners received sewing machines, radios, spraying machines, agrochemicals and cloth, with the Ghana Cocoa Board sponsoring awards for cocoa, coffee and shea nut farmers.

In 1988, the first and second runners-up were introduced alongside the National Best Farmer Award. The winner now received a double cabin pick-up, while the runners-up received corn mills and all items given to single-commodity award winners. This year also saw the introduction of regional award winners and special awards

recognising institutions that have contributed to agricultural development in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, in 1991, His Excellency the late Flt Lt J.J. Rawlings declared the first Friday of December each year as a national holiday to honour our farmers and fishermen.

1:05 p.m.

By 1994, the District Best Farmer Awards were instituted, funded by the Ministry of Food and Agriculture and local donations. Between 1998 and 2000, the National Best Farmer continued to receive a double cabin pickup. From 2001, winners were presented with three-bedroom households, funded by the Agricultural Development Bank, with the first runner-up receiving a tractor and implements, and the second runner-up receiving a double cabin pickup. Since 2017, the National Best Farmer receives cash prizes to allow flexibility in using the funds to improve agriculture inputs.

Mr Speaker, the selection process for the National Best Farmer is painstaking, rigorous, involving preliminary selections at the district and regional levels. Farmers' activities are closely monitored by extension officers throughout the farming season. A committee composed of experts from the University of Ghana, University of Cape Coast, Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology, University of Development Studies and research institutions together with extension officers tour farms to assess the candidates. This ensures that the final award decisions are fair, impartial, and merit-based.

Mr Speaker, the celebration highlights several key national values and significance. Firstly, national recognition and appreciation: It reinforces the message that agriculture is central to our survival, stability, and growth. Through the awards now covering more than 16 categories, such as overall best farmer, best female farmer, best youth farmer, and best livestock farmer, the nation affirms its gratitude to those who feed us.

Secondly, platform for innovation and learning: Farmers' Day has grown into a national platform for showcasing agriculture technologies, mechanisation options, improved seeds, climate-smart practices, and value-chain innovations. The AgriFest Ghana Fair, which precedes the day, brings together farmers, investors, researchers, agribusinesses for collaboration and knowledge sharing.

Thirdly, policies signaling: Themes chosen each year serves as indicators of government priorities. The 2023 theme supported the launch of “Planting for Food and Jobs Phase II”, emphasising delivering smart solutions for sustainable food security and resilience. In 2024, the theme, “Building Climate-Resilient Agriculture for Sustainable Food Security,” highlighted national concerns for climate impacts. The Theme for Ghana's National Farmers' Day, 2025, is “Feed Ghana, Eat Ghana, Secure the Future.”

Fourthly, economic contribution: Agriculture continues to contribute significantly to GDP, employment, and exports. Organisations like Alliance for

Green Revolution for Africa (AGRA) and farmer networks continue to commend the resilience of Ghana farmers and advocate for improved financing, technology, and infrastructure.

Mr Speaker, of late, the celebration of Farmers' Day is marked by several important national activities. First, Agriculture Fair and Exhibition. Throughout the week, a National Agriculture Fair is held, featuring exhibitions of machinery, seedlings, agrochemicals, livestock, processed foods, irrigation technologies, and innovations from research institutions. Second, sponsorship and funding. Official launching of soliciting the sponsorship packages and funding. Third, National Durbar and Awards Ceremony. On Friday, the climax of the celebration features a grand durbar of chiefs, farmers, fisherfolk, dignitaries, and stakeholders; cultural performances and parades showcasing Ghana's agricultural diversity; speeches addressing national agriculture priorities. Lastly, presentations for awards at district, regional, and national levels. As we commemorate the 41st edition of the national event, we are reminded that agriculture is the backbone of our food security, a pillar of our economic growth, and a source of dignity for millions of Ghanaian households. This moment calls on all of us to support our farmers with better policies, funding and resources, ensuring that Ghana's agriculture continues to thrive and grow.

Mr Speaker, as Ghana celebrates four decades of Farmers' Day, it is important we strengthen the celebration itself to deepen its relevance, transparency, and

national pride. I therefore suggest the following measures to improve the celebration activities:

1. Institutionalise a permanent national organising committee: A well-resourced permanent committee will ensure continuity, stronger planning, and better coordination across all regions and districts.
2. Improve transparency of prize structures: Publishing a clear prize structure and award criteria ahead of time will improve fairness, public trust, and sponsorship engagement.
3. Expand corporate sponsorship: formalising a national sponsorship framework will enhance prize equality while reducing financial burden on Government.
4. Strengthen district and regional celebrations: Providing logistical support with standardised guidelines will ensure quality and uniformity at the grassroots where most awards are presented.
5. Enhance public education and media outreach: A month-long public awareness campaign before the celebration will highlight farm achievements and reinforce national respect for the sector.
6. Digitalise the nomination and selection process: A digital system for nominations and

documentation will reduce delays, improve accuracy, and enhance fairness.

Mr Speaker, implementing these reforms will elevate National Farmers' Day into a celebration that reflects the true value of our hard-working farmers and fisherfolks, enhances transparency, strengthens national pride, and ensures that this important institution continues to grow in relevance and prestige. Let us use this occasion to honour the courage, resilience, and innovation of our farmers and fishermen. Let this also serve as a reminder of our duty as a nation and as legislatures to continue supporting agriculture, the very foundation upon which our nation's prosperity rests.

Thank you, Mr Speaker. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Hon Members? Yes, Prof Adam?

Prof Hamza Adam (NDC — Kumbungu): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to this very important Statement, a Statement that supports the celebration of our gallant farmers. We all know that farmers in this country continue to play a vital role in ensuring food security for this country. A lot of the farmers go the extra mile to endure to ensure that we have food on our tables at our various homes. As we celebrate the farmers, I want to emphasise that we have to re-look at the way we go about selecting the people that we give this award to.

1:15 p.m.

The politicisation of the awardees has become the order of the day. I must mention that almost all the political parties are victims of this. We really have to ensure that we do a thorough search and get well-deserving people and let them receive this award. The failure to do this is diluting and defeating the purpose for this award. We see farmers seeing this award as just an opportunity to reward political supporters, and we need to look at that.

Gender inclusion is an important thing that we also have to look at. A lot of the awardees continue to be the male gender, with very few females receiving this award. It is important that we look at how we will include women, because now we have a lot of women who are into farming, and some of them are doing far better than the men.

Mr Speaker, the smallholder farmers still battle with numerous challenges, despite the fact that the celebration has existed for many years. We still have farmers struggling to get access to basic credit to expand their farms. We also have the issue of insurance continue to be a hindrance to accessing credit to many farmers to support their farms. I want to recommend seriously that we look at the issue of how we can ensure that farmers will be able to access insurance. Also, limited access to farm machinery. A lot of farmers still struggle to get access to farm machinery, and these are some challenges that we have to look at.

I know that the current Government has taken bold initiatives to ensure that we are able to address these challenges. For example, the very popular Feed Ghana Project, is an encompassing project that I know is going to be able to address that. I believe strongly that in the trajectory of resetting the agriculture sector, the Feed Ghana project will be looked at seriously to address that.

Mr Speaker, the Farmer Services Centre is also another innovation that will address the issue of access to farming challenges, that we would have to look at and then support the Government to achieve the same.

To conclude, let me take the opportunity to congratulate our Ghanaian farmers for going extra miles to ensure that we have food to eat as a country. On this very special day, I wish all farmers the best, and I will say *ayekoo* to all farmers.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, just look at the *Order Paper* for today and the activity that we have to cover. So, if I give you the opportunity to comment, I expect you not to go beyond five minutes, I beg of you. This is because we have so many things.

Dr Patrick Boakye-Yiadom (NPP — Obuasi East): Mr Speaker, thank you. I would want to do it under two minutes. Tomorrow is National Farmers' Day; a day we choose to celebrate the hard work and the commitment of farmers. It is even meant to make them happy after putting food on the table of lawyers, doctors, and pastors. But what

do we see? Farmers are not happy. They are not happy because large cocoa farms are being destroyed. Large stretches of arable lands are being destroyed by *galamsey*.

Mr Speaker, if we watch on for this menace to continue, where are we going to get land to make sure that the Feed Ghana project succeeds? How do we achieve a sustainable security if we watch on for our lands to be destroyed? I can tell the House in all honesty that there is no political will to fight *galamsey*. Let us call a spade a spade. Mr Speaker, I am afraid that if we do not act decisively in the fight against *galamsey*, the future of Ghana and Ghanaians are in danger. I am saying this because now dangerous chemicals like cyanide and mercury, which are poisonous are being detected in our food and in our staples. So, if there is any gift on the anniversary day tomorrow that we can give to farmers, it is the Government to act decisively to stop *galamsey*.

In conclusion, let me use this opportunity to wish our hardworking farmers happy anniversary tomorrow, and to also add my voice to the call for the Government to act decisively to end *galamsey* from now.

Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us be a bit tolerant. When it comes to the discussion of farmers, farm activities, all these things happen on the land. So that is the angle he decided to take. Let us be a bit tolerant, I beg of you.

Yes, Dr Sandaare?

Dr Sebastian Ngmenenso Sandaare (NDC — Daffiama/Bussie/Issa):

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement made by the Hon Colleague. I am a product of a farmer. My parents were farmers, and I believe many of us also have that root where our parents or our grandparents farmed, even to take care of us during our various educational journey. We are grateful that tomorrow is dedicated as Farmers' Day, so that we can celebrate and award our gallant farmers.

Mr Speaker, the theme for the day is Feed Ghana, Eat Ghana, and Secure the Future. The essence of this is to ensure that there is food security, national self-sufficiency, and long-term stability of the agriculture sector. If we take a constituency like mine, about 80 per cent of the people are farmers. They are excited that this Government is taking a lot of steps to ensure that farmers now have what they need for their farming services, farm centres, fertiliser and farming equipment.

1:25 p.m.

My district is one of those that would benefit from the Farmer's Service Centre. This would trickle to almost every district. So, farmers are happy under this Government, we can assure you. It is for all of us to support the Feed Ghana Programme (FDP). This is not the time for partisanship— Let us come together as a country, because almost all of us are farmers, so let us support the Government agenda; let us support the

Feed Ghana Programme, and let us support the *Nkoko Nketenkete* Programme.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, I celebrate all the gallant farmers of this country, especially the farmers in Daffiama/Bussie/Issa Constituency. I wish them well, and together, Ghana would become better, where we would have food sufficiency and no child would go hungry in this country.

Dr Kingsley Agyemang (NPP — Abuakwa South): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to this Statement. Farmers' Day celebration— hearing from what my Colleagues said, the history and the trajectory is very clear. It looks to me that every year, slogans are celebrated as against the individuals who are involved in the critical value chain.

Mr Speaker, whether we like it or not, the concept of soil to stomach would go beyond every regime, because any activity that is done to the soil, ends up in the stomach, regardless of whoever is taking the food. Over the years, we pretend to be celebrating farmers, and farmers also pretend to be enjoying whatever we say to them.

An aspect that I want to contribute to is agricultural financing. Our people are desirous to farm, but access to capital is not sustainable. We established the Agricultural Development Bank (ADB) with the overarching objective to assist farming. They lend to farmers at commercial rates. I am a farmer. Last year, I won the municipal best farmer

award, and what we go through as farmers, in terms of capital, is grievous.

Today, we are celebrating: “Eat Ghana, Grow Ghana, Secure the Future”. What are we securing? It is as if God is going to create new lands for us. Lately, access to land and sustainability of land have been challenging. That is why I am associating with what my Colleague said. I come from a *galamsey* area, just like him. Our lands are depleting. Farmlands are yielding to *galamsey* activities. So, what are we securing? There is no future because no new lands are going to be created.

Mr Speaker, when I went to Kyebi, there was no water. The Nephelometric Turbidity Unit (NTU) level of River Birem is about 5,000 to 8,000. What are we watering our farmlands with? Cyanide or mercury? Is that the kind of future we want to secure? I think the answer is obvious. So, I do not see the theme in line with the reality of what is happening today. *Galamsey* activities have heightened. Access to land, access to capital, and bridging the gap are what we expect our farmers to enjoy. How do we bridge the gap? It is through access to healthcare for the Ghanaian farmer, education, and infrastructure. Cocoa roads have been cancelled. Access to food—how are we going to secure all these?

So, Mr Speaker, I wonder what we are really celebrating. The Ghanaian farmer deserves better. The Ghanaian farmer needs to be protected. We cannot have a future in this country if the Ghanaian farmer is not well protected. Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me turn to the Deputy Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry. He really comes from an agri-zone.

Mr Sampson Ahi (NDC — Bodi): Thank you so much for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, tomorrow is a special day for all farmers in this country, including myself. Let me take this opportunity to congratulate all farmers for their work to put food on our tables. Mr Speaker, farmers are happy as we speak, particularly cocoa farmers are very excited because before the 2024 Elections, President Mahama promised cocoa farmers to pay 70 per cent of Free-on-Board (FOB) to cocoa farmers.

President Mahama has redeemed that promise to pay 70 per cent to cocoa farmers. Mr Speaker, before we exited power in 2016, under President Mahama, we were distributing free cocoa fertilisers to cocoa farmers. Our Colleagues opposite came into Government, those fertilisers on which it was written that they are not to be sold —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, you are doing well, but do not trigger any debate. It is a national celebration, and I think we are doing well.

Mr Ahi: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I am only speaking to facts. And the fact is that under the previous regime, they were selling cocoa fertilisers, but free fertiliser has been reintroduced under the current Government. This is a fact that

everybody must know. If they are not aware, we have started the distribution of free fertiliser to cocoa farmers. Mr Speaker, this is not politics. This is factual. This is what is on the ground.

Mr Speaker, before the introduction of free education, we used to have the COCOBOD scholarship to cocoa farmers who went to secondary schools. But with the introduction of free education, that scholarship was suspended. However, the current President, H.E John Mahama, from the next academic year, is going to reintroduce the cocoa scholarship to cocoa farmers at the tertiary level. Are they not happy that when their children get to university level, they are going to benefit from a scholarship if their parents are cocoa farmers? Are they not happy? Is it not good news?

So, Mr Speaker, farmers are happy under the current President, H.E John Dramani Mahama. There is a particular problem with farming in this country. After production, farmers have to struggle to sell their produce. That is why President Mahama is looking at marketing facilities to support farmers. That is why the president recently gave GH¢100 million to the National Food Buffer Stock Company to buy foodstuffs for self-keep. Another 200 have been added so that farmers, after production, their produce will be bought. Are you not happy?

1:35 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Deputy Minister, you have spoken for seven minutes. Thank you.

Mr Ahi: Mr Speaker, I have spoken for just two minutes. Then, Mr Speaker, let me end at ten minutes, with your leave, give me an additional three minutes.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I will give you one more minute to conclude.

Mr Ahi: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

If you look at the theme, “Eat Ghana, Grow Ghana”, when we attend meetings, and conferences, we are served with perfumed rice, which is not produced in Ghana. Let us advise ourselves that, henceforth, we will encourage restaurants to serve locally made rice.

Mr Speaker, let me thank you for the opportunity, but you allowed me to speak for only four minutes. Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much. I will now turn to Leadership, and I will give them five minutes each.

Deputy Minority Leader (Ms Patricia Appiagyei): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Before I make my contribution, I would like to appeal to our Hon Member from Sekondi that today, we are here for serious Business and we are going to ensure that we close early. So, the shouting across the aisle is not something we should encourage today. Mr Speaker, I need your guidance on that one.

Mr Speaker, tomorrow is Farmers' Day and it is such an auspicious day that Ghana must celebrate with all the seriousness that it requires. You would bear with me that this celebration of our farmers and our fisherfolks has been introduced to ensure that our farmers and our fisherfolks who serve us food on a daily basis are well acknowledged and honoured. It is very important that on a day like this, we look at all the aspects of the celebration. The first one is the award of prizes to the best farmers. The second one is to also ensure that we showcase what has been done and innovation.

The theme that has been adopted for this particular celebration is apt and it is very important that we pay attention to that and not engage in propaganda on the theme. What is important at this point in time, considering the current state in which we are in, our water situation, our *galamsey* situation, is that we adopt the best of policies to ensure that our food basket is always full and people will not go hungry in the country. So, what is important today for us to take home? I know Government has come with a number of initiatives that it wants to adopt to ensure that people have some jobs to do, but let us look at it from a very holistic point of view.

I am looking at innovation. Mr Speaker, in my Constituency, for instance, you will be surprised to note that if you take the whole of Ashanti Region, we provide the highest vegetables. And you will begin to think that this is a peri-urban constituency, why are they producing that much? Because we are creative and innovative,

using tires, and other forms of farming technologies to ensure that food is served at all times. So, on a day like this, I would like for us to strictly think through what we are doing as a nation. If we get every household to at least produce something, if not vegetables, you can produce foodstuffs using innovative farming ways. It will help us as a nation. I remember some time back when I was in school, the late Ignatius Kutu Acheampong who was the former Head of State, introduced the 'Operation Feed Yourself' system. Under the circumstances in which we live now, it is important that every family begins to look at a way of producing something for its family members so that food will be in abundance and everybody can eat.

I want to conclude by celebrating especially those who are creating and innovating the farming system to ensure that we spend little on food by producing food ourselves in our house. I would like to salute all Asokwa farmers and all farmers in Ghana and celebrate them to the fullest to encourage them and give them the right resources to produce abundantly.

With these few words, I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Armah — *rose* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much. Let me come to Majority Leadership.

Mr Armah, take it lightly. What do you want to say?

Mr Blay Nyameke Armah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I wanted to rebut what the Hon Deputy Minority Leader said earlier. I want her to know that I was not shouting. We know that this is a House of serious business. We do not come here to joke. We come here to work. I was trying to correct the wrong information that my Colleague on the other Side was—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Your point is well noted. Let me now come to the Hon Majority Leader.

Mr Armah: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

1:45 p.m.

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, on an occasion like this, all of us in this Chamber and Ghanaians must recognise and pay tribute to the effort of our farmers. Indeed, the National Farmers' Day was instituted to encourage people to go into farming and to recognise the effort of all those who went into farming and to appreciate the fact that it is through them that we can create the food security that this country needs.

Mr Speaker, I do not know if the institution of a National Farmers' Day is achieving its real objectives. Since childhood, every year, I have heard of a National Farmers' Day. But as we speak, our food import still stands at over US\$3.5 billion. Indeed, some people put our food imports at the range of US\$4 to US\$4.5 billion a year.

It means that every year Ghana imports food to the tune of US\$3.5 to US\$4.5 billion. It means that every year, we carry US\$3.5 or US\$4.5 billion roaming around the world, looking for food to buy, to bring into the country. That is the reality. Why would a country like Ghana, with all the arable land from here to Tumu, to Bawku and from the east to west—Why would a country like Ghana, with the biggest man-made lake lying in its centre, with all the water that is stored in the lake, be carrying US\$3.5 billion every year roaming around the world to buy food and ship and come and eat as a country? Why?

We talk about unemployment, food inflation and the exchange rate. If we import US\$3.5 billion every year, it means that in every year, we are looking for US\$3.5 billion to go out there and buy food and bring it into the country. We are exporting jobs—As a country, why can we not after all these decades, be at least, self-sufficient in food production? Why?

One, it is no longer tenable as a people for us to assume that peasant farming can produce the quantum of food that we need as a country to feed ourselves. The countries that are producing food from which we are importing from are not engaged in peasant farming. They are engaged in large-scale commercial farming. Because, that has become the technological reality. People say the young people should go into farming. With what? They watch on television and see on social media how Ukrainians, Europeans and Americans are farming.

They are now farming large acreages of land. Lands that have been engineered for agriculture. Lands that have been irrigated; they are using machinery. Unless we transition from peasant farming of one to two acres, to large commercial farming of thousands of acreages of engineered and irrigated lands using high-tech equipment, I can assure us that we will remain importers of food in this country. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Unless that transition takes place—I just heard my Colleague, the Deputy Minister, urge us to eat made-in-Ghana rice and that we should not eat perfumed rice. Why should we not eat perfumed rice? What is so sophisticated about processing our rice to also become perfumed rice? If the taste of Ghanaians is perfumed rice, why should we not process our rice to also become perfumed rice? It is a processing issue. So let us do that.

Mr Speaker, while, I commend our farmers for their efforts so far—Because we are importing close to US\$4 billion, we do not even know exactly how much in terms of billions that we are consuming. So, we cannot even measure the effort of our local farmers, which is then supported with the US\$4 billion imported amount.

We commend them highly for their efforts so far, but Government policy must shift and start focusing on large-scale commercial farming. [*Hear! Hear!*] Government policy must shift and start focusing on irrigation and mechanisation. We must understand that farming is an engineering exercise. If we

are constructing roads, we must also construct farmlands. Because we cannot expect the graduates of Senior High School today, to pick cutlasses and pick axes to go and clear land using manpower so that they can farm. Just as we must engineer our roads, we must also engineer our farms.

Mr Speaker, the Members of Parliament who are members of the Northern Caucus took a conscious decision that we must transform the northern half of this country into the food basket of the country. We took all Regional Ministers for the five regions in the northern part of the country, to South Africa for 10 days. We took them to the Limpopo Province. They were joined by the Regional Minister for the Bono Region. They went from one commercial farm to another. They saw how commercial farming is a job creation mechanism.

We visited a farm in Limpopo Province and the owner of the farm said he has a 1,000-acre farm. He has 200 permanent workers. During the season, he has 1,000 workers. We are talking about youth unemployment. Farming is a major opportunity, a low-hanging fruit for us to create jobs. If we clear, irrigate the lands and support with mechanisation, we have the potential to produce and export.

Mr Speaker, while we were in South Africa, we went to a maize farm. When we asked them how much was one kilo of maize in South Africa, I think they were selling it for about US\$100. One of the Ministers is a farmer in Ghana and he

then revealed that we were selling our maize at about US\$250 per tonne. Can we imagine the vast difference?

That is why when government introduces a policy to support farmers and says School Feeding Programme, which buys locally produced food, if we give the contract to a businessman, he will just cut the corner and go to South Africa, buy the thing at US\$100. Even with the cost of logistics, he will get it here at US\$150 and he will still make a US\$100 on it, and we cannot blame the businessman. So, we need to find ways of making sure that we reduce all the lands that are lying here waste.

Mr Speaker, the last point I want to make is that it is ridiculous—I met a Chinese farmer, and he laughed at me and said, when we import US\$4 billion worth of food, do we know what we are doing? I said no. He said, “we are importing US\$4 billion worth of water.” Because the fact is, we drop one grain of maize on the ground, it is water that keeps drawing on with some chemicals to grow—The stem will grow to support the crop. So, one grain will now produce 1,000 grains of rice. It is just a function of water.

1:55 p.m.

So how can a country that has the biggest man-made lake laying with the White Volta, Black Volta, and all the other rivers that descend from the top, from the east, west, into the Volta—We have all these streams, and we cannot irrigate our country to feed ourselves and

we are importing US\$4 billion worth of food. That is why I chose to speak to commemorate tomorrow, which is the National Farmers’ Day, to draw attention to something that is pathetic, that as a country, we are importing.

Mr Speaker, as far back as 1963, when former President Kwame Nkrumah developed his seven-year development plan, and constructed the Akosombo Dam, he indicated, when he was addressing Parliament, that there are two reasons why the Akosombo Dam was being constructed. One is for hydroelectric power. Two is for agro-based industrialisation. We were to use the water in the lake to irrigate and produce enough so that we can build on it, to feed the industries so that we can also industrialise. How many decades now? Since 1963, 1970. How many decades now? We still have not achieved this basic objective. How could Nkrumah be far better than us in this generation? How is it possible that they were better than us in this generation? This generation must sit up. We must manage our country better and let us use this National Farmers’ Day to remind ourselves of our failure. We have failed, and we must remind ourselves of this failure so that we can sit up and do the right thing.

Mr Speaker, thank you,

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Deputy Minister, I would give you five minutes to wind up. We have discussed it extensively. The Majority Leader has done your job for you.

Deputy Minister for Food and Agriculture (Mr John Setor Dumelo):

Mr Speaker, I would want to say that tomorrow we are celebrating farmers across the country. It marks the 41st anniversary under the theme, “Feed Ghana, Eat Ghana, and Secure the Future”. As you all know, it was instituted in 1985. So far, it has been good and has created some form of healthy competition among farmers. One thing is important, that farmers are indeed happy. Farmers across the country are happy.

One, because we are instituting the Farmers’ Service Centre. Two, because we are improving our irrigation. Three, because we are giving money to the National Food Buffer Stock company to buy the excesses from them. Four, we are establishing processing factories across the country and five, with the implementation and the launch of the *Nkokɔ Nketenkete* programme, we are making sure that poultry becomes easy and affordable to most Ghanaians across the country.

Mr Speaker, one of my Colleagues said *galamsey* is an issue but I have never seen any government more committed to fighting *galamsey* than the National Democratic Congress (NDC) Government. Currently, we have distributed over 1,000 water pumps seized from these *galamsey* sites, and all these water pumps have been taken to non- *galamsey* areas where they are using it for irrigation. So, when we hear that the farmers are not happy, I beg to differ.

Mr Speaker, what I want to say is that this whole week I have been in Ho, and it is incredible to see the amount of work

that some of these universities have presented, especially their research work. What we need to do is to be able to bridge the gap between some of these research work and the business community. It is very important that when we go there tomorrow, we would see some of the amazing works that some of the Ghanaian universities are churning out. In conclusion, I would like to make certain remarks.

Mr Speaker, one, I think that each politician here, whether elected or appointed, should be able to own a farm or a processing centre. I think that will be very important. The second one is that; I think it is about time that Parliament had a farm. We should be able to institute a parliamentary farm, that will become the model for most of us. The third one is that, we should be able to institute district farms across the country, so that all these district assemblies will be able to own farms and processing centres.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, I would like to say that, indeed, the farmers are happy. Everyone is happy with the President, H.E John Dramani Mahama. Everyone is happy with the Majority, which is the NDC Government and they are looking forward to the next three years, where will would make sure that farming becomes easy, accessible, affordable, and making sure that food is indeed on the table for everybody.

On this note, I would want to wish all the farmers a happy Farmers’ Day, and also encourage households to be able to set up their farms, so that they would have some backyard farming to do. I am

also inviting each and every one of you to Ho. When you come, I would make sure I take good care of you. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, thank you so much and God bless you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this weekend, we are saying farewell to one of our Colleagues who passed on to eternity and I think it would be fair and befitting to pay our last respects by way of giving tribute in his memory. So, I will invite the Minority Chief Whip to read the tribute of our fallen hero, Hon Ernest Kumi.

Tribute to the Late Hon Ernest Kumi

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, thank you.

I begin with a quotation from the scriptures, Psalm 116:15:

“Precious in the sight of the Lord is the death of his saints”.

Mr Speaker, today, with hearts weighed down by grief, yet lifted by gratitude, we bid farewell to our colleague, brother and friend, the Hon Ernest Kumi. His passing on 7th July, 2025, remains a deep wound in our collective spirit. A reminder of the fragility of life and the profound impact of life lived with purpose. Hon Kumi’s journey to Parliament was not merely a political ascent. It was a story of a man who refused to quit. A man whose resolve was stronger than the storms that

confronted him. He was a fighter in every sense, principled, courageous, and anchored family in the belief that God’s time is always the best. He contested the 2020 General Elections and narrowly lost. Yet, as was his nature, he rose again. He won the confidence of his party as the 2024 parliamentary candidate on the ticket of the New Patriotic Party (NPP).

Mr Speaker, in December 2024, the good people of Akwatia spoke clearly and overwhelmingly, entrusting him with their mandate. Even when his victory was challenged, he stood undoubted. As a learning Colleague of the noble legal profession who valued the supremacy of the courts and the rule of law, he fought calmly and courageously through the legal processes until justice prevailed.

2:05 p.m.

That was Yaw, a fighter, resilient and unwavering.

On 7th January, 2025, he took the Oath of Office, affirming what his people already knew. He was a legitimate Member of Parliament for Akwatia. In Parliament, he served diligently on the Committee on Lands and Natural Resources and other assignments. Whether at the Committee level or on the Floor, he distinguished himself for brilliance, clarity and deep insight. Despite heckling and needless interruptions, he spoke with the calm authority of a man who understood his duty. He debated with wisdom, argued with conviction, and carried himself with dignity. Indeed, he was an orator of

uncommon grace. But beyond his words was his spirit, a spirit that taught us his Colleagues priceless lessons. His life taught us to fight on, no matter the odds. His steady demeanour encouraged us to persevere even when the path seemed impossible. His focus reminded us that victory belongs to those who refuse to be distracted.

In these moments, when our Caucus carries an enormous weight of holding the Government accountable, though few in number, yet mighty and quality in purpose, his example reassures us that we shall reach the seats of victory soon. He has left us not only memories, but motivation; not only sorrow, but strength for the journey ahead. His life itself becomes a message to us: Do not give up. Do not fear the overbearing Majority; stand firm, for truth, discipline, and courage will always prevail.

Mr Speaker, beyond the walls of the Chamber, Mr Kumi was a brother, always available, always willing to help, always ready to join a colleague's campaign, no matter how far the constituency, no matter how tight his schedule. His selflessness was inspiring. His discipline was unwavering, a man who respected time and honoured every obligation.

Mr Speaker, today, as we honour his public life, we cannot ignore the deep personal loss felt by those closest to him. To his aged mother, who nurtured him into the man who we came to admire, we say, your son fought a good fight, finished his course, and kept the faith (2

Timothy 4:7). Take comfort in knowing that the values you instilled in him, courage, humility, truth, became the very qualities that defined his service to Ghana. To his wife, a woman of quiet strength, who stood faithfully beside him through every political battle and personal challenge, may God's peace, which surpasses all understanding, continue to guard your heart. Philippians 4:7; know that you are not alone, the Minority Caucus stands firmly with thee. To his lovely children, who must now grow with the memory of a father who loved them deeply and worked tirelessly to give them a better future, your father's legacy lives in you. Walk proudly, for he was a man of honour. We, his colleagues, will always remain within reach. As fathers, as uncles, as guides, and as pillars you can lean on. To the entire Kumi family, may the God of all comfort wrap his arms around you. This loss is heavy, but you do not carry it alone.

As the New Patriotic Party (NPP) Minority Caucus, we reaffirm our commitment to stand with the family, not only in this season of grief, but in the many days and years to come. Mr Ernest Yaw Kumi was one of us. His family is our family. His children are our children. His memory is our shared inheritance.

Mr Speaker, Mr Kumi lived well, he served well, he loved well. And though he has left our side, his legacy will remain a shining light in Parliament, in Akwatia and in the hearts of all who had the privilege of knowing him.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Eric Edem Agbana (NDC — Ketu North): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the Statements in memory of my dear Friend and Brother, Mr Ernest Yaw Kumi.

Mr Speaker, long before we were sworn in on 7th January, 2025, as Members of the 9th Parliament, Mr Ernest Kumi and I had been very good friends. We have appeared in the media on numerous occasions, and on many occasions after our debates in the media, we drove to restaurants to have breakfast or lunch together, and we have always been very good friends for so long.

Mr Speaker, in 2023, I was in Pretoria for a programme, and after he noticed the posts I made on social media, he called me and said he was in Johannesburg. He drove all the way from Johannesburg to Pretoria just to meet me, and that, for me, defines how deep our friendship was beyond politics.

Mr Speaker, my pain at the loss of Mr Ernest Kumi goes beyond just losing a colleague in the House of Parliament, but it is a pain that also cuts deep, because since I got to know him, he had always had one dream: to become a lawyer. On many occasions, he encouraged me to pick forms to study the Bachelor of Laws (LLB) programme, and I kept postponing it. For close to 10 years, he dedicated his life to the study of the law. When he got admission to the Ghana School of Law, Makola, we all celebrated with him. The first time he was supposed to, he had to repeat and a few others—To cut a long story short, after so many years of struggling to be

called to the Bar, just when the battle was over and he was supposed to be called to the Bar in October, a few weeks before, we lost him. It is a pain that we cannot explain.

Mr Speaker, on this occasion, I want to remind all of us that indeed, on days like this, we should remember that this life is not ours, but it belongs to the Almighty God. Beyond politics, Ernest was truly a reliable friend and a brother, and many of my Colleagues would attest to the fact that usually during lunch or when we are on break, they saw me sitting with him at the cafeteria, sharing a meal or a drink. He was a gentleman who lived beyond party politics and who was a true friend to those of us who were close to him.

I wish to remind all of us that even as we find ourselves here on tickets of political parties, we should always remember that we are first and foremost Ghanaians, we are human beings, and we must first love one another before we place our partisan politics ahead of whatever national interests.

2:15 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I wish his young wife and his family the very best. I pray that God grants them strength. Indeed, it will be very difficult to lay Ernest to rest this weekend. I pray that the Lord God Almighty himself will strengthen his family, his party, the NPP, and our Friends in the Minority. We pray that his legacy should live beyond him. The goal of life is not to live forever, but to create something that will outlive us.

Mr Speaker, with these words, I say thank you for the opportunity.

Prof Kingsley Nyarko (NPP — Kwadaso): Mr Speaker, I am grateful for the opportunity to share a few words as we celebrate the memory of our wonderful brother, Ernest Yaw Kumi, who used to be the Member of Parliament for the good people of Akwatia.

Mr Speaker, Ernest Yaw Kumi, popularly known as the “Akwatia Star Boy”, was born on 5th December, 1984, and today is 4th December, so tomorrow, he would have been 41 years old. This was a young gentleman full of passion, energy, and drive, and his academic prowess was so telling. After obtaining a Bachelor of Science (BSc) in Ports and Shipping Administration from the Vietnam Maritime University in 2009, he went ahead to obtain a Master of Business Administration (MBA) in Corporate Governance from the University of Professional Studies. He also obtained a Bachelor of Laws (LLB) degree from Mountcrest University College and a Master of Science (MSc) in Defence and International Politics from Ghana Armed Forces Command and Staff College.

Mr Speaker, looking at his pedigree and what he achieved and obtained on the academic ladder, I can say that we have lost a gem. We lost somebody who, for the brevity of life and death, will have contributed enormously, not only for his Constituency and its region, but for the entire nation. We are going to miss him, and standing here this afternoon, I am

saddened because by paying tribute to him, I am recollecting that since I came to this Parliament on the 7th January, 2021, we have lost four precious souls. It began with the MP for Kumawu, Hon Philip Basoah, my classmate at Secondary School, Tweneboa Kodua Secondary School, then our very good friend, John Kumah, Hon Member for Ejisu, then Ernest Yaw Kumi, Hon Member for Akwatia, and our friend, Murtala Muhammed.

Mr Speaker, for the first three, I remember clearly that we had a Sitting that ended around 11 p.m. We were supposed to take a vote, which did not happen, and it was rescheduled for the next day. I met Philip Basoah in the washroom, and I asked him how things were. He said he was fine, and the next day, Philip was gone.

John Kumah was agile and hardworking. Few moments, he departed. Ernest had a programme at Takoradi; he came back on Sunday. The next day, he was gone. What is wrong? Is it that we as MPs are not doing something right? Probably, it is time for us to do a deep introspection and see if we can do something differently regarding our lives, and how we execute our parliamentary responsibilities.

Mr Speaker, life is short. It means that every moment and second of our lives is precious. So if we have something to do, we must do it now, and not tomorrow. Now Ernest is gone, we do not know who will be next, but we are praying to God to give us the strength and power to, at least, put our respective

quotas to make this country more meaningful.

As we celebrate our Brother, all we can say is that may God give him comfort and lasting peace, wherever he is. To his family, especially his wife and children, may God provide them with the fortitude, a resolute mind and clear direction, so that they will not remain comfortless, and the almighty God, who is the source of our being, will comfort them. I want to plead with our Leadership. Ernest was in this House for about six months. That is so sad. Perhaps, in the Fourth Republic, he might be the MP who spent a short time in the House. I might be wrong, but that is what I am thinking. So our Caucus, and even the entire House, must take delight in helping the children and the remaining spouse of our Brother, so that we can do something meaningful to memorialise his legacy.

Hon Ernest, I bid you godspeed. May God be with you and strengthen you, till we meet again someday.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Fred Kwesi Agbenyo (NDC — Guan): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to add my voice to the Statement made in eulogising the memory of our Brother, our friend, our comrade, and our colleague, Ernest Yaw Kumi.

Indeed, we are on a journey. The day we depart this planet Earth, nobody knows. The way it will come, we do not know. When? We do not know. But it is

important to remind ourselves that, indeed, we are on a journey. Hitherto, we thought that one would be 90 years and above before one passes on. It is evidently clear today that the young are departing, the old are departing; everybody is departing.

Mr Speaker, I knew Ernest Yaw Kumi for some time, especially because of our media engagement. Ernest is one person I can describe as very passionate when it comes to NPP politics; he will defend the NPP at all costs. But the most beautiful thing about him is his warm personality, because after the debates in the studios, he will walk up to his opponents, and where he disagrees, he will share with his opponent. He will discuss politics, business and academic life.

Mr Speaker, a day before his passing, I met Ernest. Then he said in Twi, MP *kakra a mese medi nti, mo atwe me wo fom saa. Me se, ebe ye yie, ekaho bi*. To wit, just because I want to be an MP, you have taken me through all this ordeal. I encouraged him that it is part of life. Now, life is a struggle. Life is war and if we are looking forward to a peaceful life, then, of course, we should look forward to a cemetery or a coffin to go and lie in the cemetery. From the day we are born to the day we exit this planet, we will go through a lot of challenges. All of us would have wished that our brother Ernest were in this House with us.

The very few months he spent in this House, Mr Speaker, Ernest did not allow this House to intimidate him. Any time he had an opportunity on the Floor, we

saw the confidence with which he made his presentation, as though he was someone who had been in this House for a very long time. So with time, it was very clear that we would all become better and better. But, as fate would have it, he left us when we least expected him to do so. So, we can only take a cue from this, that the work we are doing is very demanding. I cannot remember the last day I went to bed before it was 2 a.m. and I woke up very early. It is incumbent on all of us to take our health very seriously. We should enter the hospital and check.

2:25 p.m.

We should know exactly what our health condition is. Sometimes, we close very late, we are hungry and we go eat and sleep immediately. The time to even exercise itself is a problem. We love Ghana so much that we want to serve Ghana, but we can only do so when we are in good health. So, let me use this opportunity to call on all of us that even as we struggle to serve our constituencies and serve Mother Ghana, our health should be our number one priority.

Let me also use this opportunity, Mr Speaker, to pray for his wife and children, that God in heaven should strengthen them and keep them. One of the things I have noticed for the many years I have been in politics is that when it happens like this, beautiful speeches are given, people gather at the funeral ground in the party colours and do all the fanfare, as soon as their body is lowered into the grave, that is the end of the story. Our brother Kumi has young children. It is incumbent on us to assist the wife and

to take care of those children. It will not be out of place if Parliament can even put a mechanism in place where when such things happen, Parliament can extend a hand of support, especially for the young children to go through education. I believe the New Patriotic Party that he belongs to as well, will not go to Akwatia, have the burial and come back home. The future of his children is very key. We should not leave the burden on the woman alone. Let us do everything possible so that the children will not miss their father too much.

I wish his soul well. May he rest peacefully in the bosom of Father Abraham. Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Let me now come to Leadership. Yes, so I am yielding Minority Leadership's time to the Hon Member for Ofoase Ayirebi.

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah (NPP — Ofoase Ayirebi): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity, and it is with a heavy heart that we all contribute to this Statement in tribute to our brother, Ernest Yaw Kumi. One of the reasons for which those of us who had personal relations with him are so much pained is the fact that he was a man of many dreams. Unfortunately, a good number of them were not fulfilled before his passing. He had dreams of becoming a lawyer, and spent many years going through the LLB and even through the Qualifying Certificate in Law (QCL) preparations. Just on the verge of his qualification, in fact, a day to his moot court, the good Lord called him.

For those of us who are familiar, he had personal business dreams. He had just reached the edge of securing the necessary paperwork for the next stage of his business. Unfortunately, it did not materialise. He was just on the verge of putting his daughter in Senior High School. Unfortunately, he did not have the opportunity to see her first day at school. He had dreams of building a good parliamentary career, and he would come around Leaders and seniors getting guidance, *et cetera*, even before the election. Unfortunately, as he was sworn in, there were a lot of legal battles. He did not have the opportunity to fully express that parliamentary career.

He was a man of deep conviction and big dreams, but death has snatched him away from his family, from his region, from his party and from his nation. Mr Speaker, if there is any glimmer of hope, it would be the fact that, again, for those who know him, he is somebody who had accepted Christ as his Lord and Saviour. We take consolation in the fact that he will rest in the bosom of the Lord.

There are a couple of lessons that I believe we can learn and implement as our best tribute to Yaw, the first being his courage. No matter the difficulty or the impediment you put in his way, Yaw was a man of courage. From his first primaries, to the main election, to the court battles— I remember the days when we would go to court with him in Koforidua, and the days when he would not go to the Supreme Court, but upon return, we would be having conversations. He was a man of courage, no matter what you put him through.

Even we remember the night before our swearing-in here, when the question was put to him by the Clerk, he was a man of courage and he said he would stand up and do what he believed was right. I believe that the biggest testament we can give to his life is to reflect his courage in the endeavours ahead of us.

He was also a man of selflessness. In fact, the Thursday before his unfortunate demise, Hon Agyare, Hon Kumi and I had a conversation on the 11th floor. His focus was on how to find some money to pay some school fees for some constituents of his. The Friday, he left town to go attend a youth programme to be of use to young people in the Western Region, and to assist another member of Parliament in his course. His selflessness is something that I believe that we can carry on as our biggest testament to him. We pray for strength, especially this weekend, for his wife and the children, and for the legacy that he has left behind, as short as it was. We pray that the Lord gives us strength to carry it forward. I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Majority Leadership? I am yielding the time to Hon Collins Dauda for the Majority Leadership.

Alhaji Collins Dauda (NDC — Asutifi South): Mr Speaker, I add my voice to the tribute being made on the Floor in honour of Hon Ernest Kumi. I want to say that the news of his death came to me as a shock. Before his death, the Committee on Lands and Natural Resources had a retreat in the Akropong

area, at the Safari Valley Resort, where he actively participated. It was my last encounter with Ernest Kumi. It is not just his participation, but on that day, I recall, during break, Mr Ernest Kumi walked to me and said he wanted to find time to come to my office to see me. I asked what he was coming to discuss and he indicated that he wanted to stay in this House for long, like I have been, and that he wanted to learn some strategies with which he could stay very long in this House. That was Mr Kumi's ambition, to stay long in Parliament, not just for the interest of staying in this House for long, but to be able to serve his people for very long. Unfortunately, he did not live to do what he planned to do. He was called to eternity. We can only say that may Allah accept his soul and keep him well for us.

His life has ended. That is how, in my view and according to my belief, he was destined to live on this earth. He has left some legacies. His courage, his determination and what he planned for his constituents must be held. We were all his friends, so whatever we can do to keep some of his dreams, we should come together and do it. In particular, he left the wife and the children. When it happens like this, it becomes very difficult for the woman. I am sure she is devastated and needs comfort.

2:35 p.m.

I call on Leadership. They prevailed on the Speaker to constitute an ad-hoc Committee to look into the establishment of a pension scheme for MPs. This situation raises concern for that. The Committee has worked, a Report has

been produced and it is yet to be taken. It is a very important report that this House put every seriousness to so that we can take care of ourselves when we are weak, incapacitated or no more. I am sure Leadership will do well to bring up this report, so that we drive it forward to ensure that some situations like this would be properly taken care of. I wish Mr Ernest Kumi well wherever he is. May he rest in peace.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Members, shall we respectfully rise and pray silently for one minute in honour of his soul.

[A minute of silence was observed]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: May the soul of our brother Mr Ernest Kumi and all the departed Hon Members rest in perfect peace. Amen.

2:36 p.m. — *Sitting suspended.*

2:39 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much for your indulgence. Yes, Leader?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, given the mood of the House, we would want to pray that we vary the order of Business so that we take item numbered six on the *Order Paper* and take the Business Statement slated for next week. So, when that is out of the way, we can come back and deal with the Motions.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, are we taking the Business Statement?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, Business Statement.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we are aligned.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Before then, let me acknowledge at the public gallery, on my left side, First Century Preparatory School at Agona Nyakrom. They are being led by Jacob Kwesi Mensah, who is the administrator. The school is located in Agona West Constituency. You are welcome and we wish you a pleasant stay in Parliament.

[Pupils of First Century Preparatory School were acknowledged]

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader stepped out and indicated that he will come back. He is not here, so I pray that I take this on his behalf as the Chairperson of the Committee.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

BUSINESS OF THE HOUSE

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor *on behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee:* Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Introduction

Mr Speaker, the Committee met today, Thursday, 4th December, 2025 and arranged Business of the House for the Eighth Week ending Friday, 12th December, 2025.

Mr Speaker, the Committee accordingly submits its report as follows:

Arrangement of Business

Formal Communications by the Speaker

Mr Speaker, you may read any available communication to the House.

Question(s)

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee has scheduled the following Ministers to respond to Questions asked of them during the Week:

	<u>No. of Question(s)</u>
i. Minister for Food and Agriculture	6
ii. Minister of State in Charge of Public Sector Reforms	3
iii. Minister for Roads and Highways	10
iv. Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry	4

v. Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment	3
vi. Minister of State in Charge of Government Communications	2
vii. Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy, and Religious Affairs	10
viii. Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts	<u>4</u>
Total Number of Questions	<u>42</u>

Mr Speaker, in all, eight (8) Ministers are expected to attend upon the House to respond to Forty-Two (42) Questions during the Week. The Questions are of the following types:

- i. Urgent – 0;
- ii. Oral – 42

Statements

Mr Speaker, pursuant to Order 91(2), Ministers of State may be permitted to make Statements on Government policies. You may also admit Statements by Hon Members in accordance with Order 93.

Bills, Papers and Reports

Mr Speaker, in accordance with Order 159, Bills may be presented to the House for First Reading. However, those of urgent nature may be taken through the various stages in a day in accordance with Order 160.

Pursuant to Order 97, Papers may be laid during the week and reports from Committees may also be presented to the House for consideration.

Motions and Resolutions

Mr Speaker, Motions may be debated and their consequential Resolutions, if any, taken during the Week.

Committee Reports on Annual Budget Estimates of Related Motions

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee acknowledges the hard work the Chairpersons of Committees who have presented the Reports on the Budget Estimates and entreats those yet to report on the Estimates to expedite action to facilitate the passage of the Appropriation Bill, 2026 before the House adjourns *sine die*.

Mr Speaker, Chairpersons of Committees are once again entreated to schedule Committee sittings in the mornings before noon to ensure full participation of Hon members at plenary.

Public Holiday

Mr Speaker, tomorrow, Friday, 5th December, 2025 is Farmer's Day. Thus, the day would be observed as a statutory public holiday. The Committee seizes this opportunity to appreciate the roles of

our dedicated and industrious farmers in nation building and also encourage farmers to keep up the good work.

Conclusion

Mr Speaker, in accordance with Order 216 (2) and subject to Order 67, the Committee submits to the House the order in which the Business of the House shall be taken during the Week.

2:45 p.m.

Tuesday, 9th December, 2025

Roll Call

National Pledge

Statements

- (a) **Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso (Krachi West):** To make a Statement on Volta Lake Disaster.
- (b) **Mr Misbahu Mahama Adams (Mion):** To make a Statement on prioritising Disability inclusion in Ghana's Governance and Development Agenda.
- (c) **Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (Offinso North):** To make a Statement on the persistent and escalating threat of Highway Robbery on our roads in Ghana.

Questions

***433. Mr Kwame Dzudzorli Gakpey (Keta):** To ask the Minister for Food and Agriculture what measures are

being taken to control pests and diseases in crops and livestock.

***428. Mr Kwame Dzudzorli Gakpey (Keta):** To ask the Minister for Food and Agriculture what initiatives have been implemented to boost agricultural production and increase farmers' income.

***431. Mr Kwame Dzudzorli Gakpey (Keta):** To ask the Minister for Food and Agriculture how the government is strengthening extension services to provide farmers with information on best practices.

***465. Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (Kwabre East):** To ask the Minister for Food and Agriculture what the Ministry intends to do to address the volatility of the world market prices of cashew and its impacts on farm gate prices and exports.

***528. Mr Lawrence Agyinsam (Hemang Lower Denkyira):** To ask the Minister for Food and Agriculture the plans to enhance the poultry value chain from production to processing and value addition, marketing and distribution and consumption and demand.

***530. Mr Anthony Mmieh (Odotobri):** To ask the Minister Food and Agriculture what interventions the Ministry is undertaking to ensure fair and equitable distribution of food nationwide in the light of the increasing cost of foodstuff across the country especially in mining communities

***236. Ms Gloria Owusu (Trobu):**

To ask the Minister of State in Charge of Public Sector Reforms what specific reforms the Ministry is implementing to improve efficiency, transparency and accountability.

***249. Mr Samuel Awuku (Akwapim North):**

To ask the Minister of State in Charge of Public Sector Reforms what steps are being taken to digitise public services and reduce bureaucratic delays at key government agencies.

***500. Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta (Fanteakwa South):**

To ask the Minister of State in Charge of Public Sector Reform how the Public Records and Archives Administration Department (PRAAD) digitisation of 55,259 archival sheets and disposal of 8,540 boxes is improving records management, efficiency and what resources have been allocated for further digitisation in 2025.

Presentation of Papers

Report of the Committee on Sanitation and Water Resources on Monitoring Visits to Selected Metropolitan, Municipal and District Assemblies in the Greater Accra and Ashanti Regions to Assess the State of Sanitation.

Presentation and First Reading of Bills

Bank of Ghana (Amendment) Bill, 2025

Motions

Committee sittings

Wednesday, 10th December, 2025

Roll Call

Statements

- (a) **Mr Bismark Tetteh Nyarko (Upper Manya Krobo):** To make a Statement on the Overflow of River Klum on the Asesew- Abuorso road and its impact on commuters.
- (b) **Mrs Ernestina Ofori Dangbey (Agona West)** To make a Statement on the commemoration of the International Day for the elimination of violence against Women.
- (c) **Mr Charles Forson (Tema Central):** To make a Statement on the designated One-Hour slot for Backbench Business.

Questions

***377. Mr Yao Gomado (Akan):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when work will commence on the following areas in the Kadjebi District, since the Feeder Department completed the survey and mapping years ago: (i) Dodi-Papase to Dodo-Pepesu (ii) Dodo-Amanfrom to Daapa Junction (iii) Asato to Wawaso (iv) Koto-Nkwanta to Titiaka (v) Koto-Nkwanta to Sabram

***453. Mr Yao Gomado (Akan)** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the following roads will be fixed:

(i) Dodo – Olobi to Okrakrom (Koru) (ii) Akposokodzi Township Kadjebi road.

***455. Mr Sanja Nanja (Atebubu/Amantin):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways what immediate measures the Ministry is implementing to fix the potholes on the Amantin and the Yeji stretch of the Kumasi-Yeji Highway to prevent further deterioration of the road.

***380. Mr Maxwell Kwame Lukutor (South Tongu):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the government is going to renovate the Sogakope Bridge (Lower Volta Bridge), especially the expansion gaps and the metal railings.

***381. Mr Maxwell Kwame Lukutor (South Tongu):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the current state of work on the Agave-Afedume road and when work will commence on site.

***476. Mr Kwabena Boateng (Ejisu):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the current state of the Ejisu-Onwe-Assieninpong-Kwaso road in the Ejisu Constituency and when work will resume to complete the road.

***512. Ms Shirley Kyei (Atwima Nwabiagya South):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the construction of the following abandoned roads will be resumed and completed (i) Maakro – Agogo- Twedie (ii) Supreme Saviour – Canaan.

***516. Ms Shirley Kyei (Atwima Nwabiagya South):** To ask the Minister

for Roads and Highways when the construction of the following abandoned roads will be resumed and completed: (i) Bosankro Junction – Bosankro (ii) Akuapim Junction – Akuapim.

***517. Ms Shirley Kyei (Atwima Nwabiagya South):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the construction works will resume on the following roads: (i) Wiosu – Amanchia (ii) Nkawie – Nkran Foase (iii) Ntabanum Junction – Ntabanum.

***515. Mr Charles Forson (Tema Central):** To ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the contractor for the Community 9 Light Industrial Area road network will return to site.

***470. Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo (Manso Nkwanta):** To ask the Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment what proactive measures the Ministry is taking on labour upheavals that has become rife lately in the country.

***503. Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo (Manso Nkwanta):** To ask the Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment what the Ministry is using to track employment growth and if these targets area being met.

***504. Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo (Manso Nkwanta):** To ask the Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment what is being done to improve occupational health and safety standards, especially in high-risk industries like construction and mining.

Presentation of Papers

- (a) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ministry of the Interior for the year 2024.
- (b) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Kofi Annan International Peacekeeping Training Centre for the year 2024.

Motions

- (a) Third Reading of Bills

Ghana Deposit Protection
(Amendment) Bill, 2025

Committee sittings

JOINT CAUCUS MEETING

Thursday, 11th December, 2025

Roll Call

Statements

- (a) **Ms Dorcas Afo Toffey (Jomoro):** To make a Statement on addressing Violence against Women and Girls
- (b) **Mr Eric Edem Agbana, (Ketu North):** To make a Statement on population and development: Shaping Ghana's Development
- (c) **Mr Emmanuel Tobbin (Anyaa-Sowutuom)** To make a Statement on Broken Traffic

Lights and Pedestrian Safety in Ghana

Questions

***286. Dr Isaac Yaw Opoku (Offinso South):** To ask the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry the status of the Komenda Sugar Factory.

***315. Mr Michael Okyere Baafi (New Juaben South):** To ask the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry the status of the vehicle component manufacturing policy.

***316 Prof Kingsley Nyarko (Kwadaso):** To ask the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry the specific interventions the Ministry has taken to stimulate domestic production, increase export volumes and add value to our products to boost trade earnings.

***401. Mr Lawrence Agyinsam (Hemang Lower Denkyira):** To ask the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry the plans of the Ministry to increase exports to take advantage of the current cedi performance as well as increase the share of the trade sector to Ghana's GDP.

***367. Rev John Ntim Fordjour (Assin South):** To ask the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts the measures the Ministry is implementing to prevent the desecration of the Independence Arch, Kwame Nkrumah Mausoleum and other sacred national monuments by same-sex couples and LGBTQ+ activists.

***544. Mr Lawrence Agyinsam (Hemang Lower Denkyira):** To ask the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts the plans of the Ministry to expand employment to the indigenes in Kakum National Park enclave who have been marginalised from employment opportunities in the Constituency.

***577. Mr Charles Forson (Tema Central):** To ask the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts how the Ministry plans to implement the Black Star experience in 2025 and what institutional partnerships and private sector collaborations are being established to ensure its success as a diaspora tourism brand.

***595. Mr Felix Akwetey Okle (Bortianor Ngleshie Amanfro):** To ask the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts the plans of the Ministry to develop the Solo Monkey Forest in Bortianor to expand the tourism industry for economic development and sustainable ecological management.

***535. Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh (Nsawam-Adoagyiri):** To ask the Minister of State in Charge of Government Communications the full details of the Government Advisory Council which was set up upon the invitation of the President to representatives of Civil Society Organisations (CSOs) in Ghana, and what this auxiliary body is costing the taxpayer.

***96. Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah (Old Tafo):** To ask the Minister of State in charge of Government Communication

the total cost of all committees formed by the President and Ministers and the sources of funds since the expenditure was not included in the first-quarter budget approved by Parliament.

Presentation of Papers

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Tamale Teaching Hospital for the year 2024.

Motions

Committee sittings

Friday, 12th December, 2025

Roll Call

Statements

- (a) Mr Lawrence Agyinsam (Hemang Lower Denkyira):** To make a Statement on the importance of connecting entrepreneurs in Micro, Small and Medium-Sized Enterprises landscape in Ghana.
- (b) Mr Kweku Asante-Boateng (Asante Akim South):** To make a Statement on tragic road accident around Juaso on the Accra-Kumasi Highway.

Questions

***199. Dr Albert Tetteh Nyakotey (Yilo Krobo):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy, and Religious Affairs the plans of the Ministry for the rebuilding of the Klo-

Agogo and the Nkrakan Markets in Yilo Krobo Constituency.

***313. Prof Kingsley Nyarko (Kwadaso):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy, and Religious Affairs the total number of churches in the country and the number of them that are registered.

***314. Prof Kingsley Nyarko (Kwadaso):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy, and Religious Affairs how the Ministry intends to promote a productive working relationship between Members of Parliament and the Metropolitan, Municipal and District Chief Executives to ensure effective governance in the various local assemblies.

***364. Mr Kwame Kodua Appiah (Fanteakwa North):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs the measures implemented for the final completion of the Begoro Central Market.

***365. Mr Maxwell Kwame Lukutor (South Tongu):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs the plans of the Ministry to upgrade the Assemblies which were conferred with Municipal/Metropolitan status last year and when the Legislative Instrument will be passed for the Assemblies to be inaugurated.

***395. Mr Daniel Dung Mahama (Talensi):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Regional Affairs when the Upper East Region will

receive the Toyota Hilux that was distributed to the other regions in 2024.

***526. Mr Martin Adjei-Mensah Korsah (Techiman South):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs whether the reports of DRIP machines being used at Galamsey Sites have come to his attention, and what the Ministry is doing to ensure accountability in the use of the said machines.

***436. Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta (Fanteakwa South):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious affairs what steps are being implemented to ensure the timely completion of 618 infrastructure projects and 60 markets under the Gulf of Guinea Social Cohesion (SOCO) Project.

***543. Mr Seth Osei-Akoto (Atwima Mponua):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs what is stalling the nomination of a District Chief Executive for Atwima Mponua District since other Metropolitan, Municipal and District Chief Executives had been nominated and approved by other Assemblies in the country.

***438. Mr Charles Owiredo (Abirem):** To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs to provide an update on the elevation of the Birim North District Assembly to a municipal status by President Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo Addo on 7th November, 2024.

Presentation of Papers

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana Meteorological Agency for the year 2024.

Motions

Committee sittings

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: When you said we left here on one occasion at the dawn of the 25th. I read from Mrs Abena Osei-Asare's mouth that it was rather the dawn of the 24th.

Hon Members, the Business Statement has been read to us by the Majority Chief Whip. We invite comments on it. Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah?

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah: Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity, and I commend the Business Committee for the presentation that they have just done.

Mr Speaker, I have gone through the Papers that are supposed to be presented next week. They are important Papers, but there are some equally important Papers that we have been asking the Government to present to Parliament for several months now, and those Papers are not being presented. This is about the programmes that the Government has launched.

These programmes, first of all, in and of themselves – remember, Mr Speaker, now that the economic policy does not

come by Motion, we do not approve the economic policy, so the programmes that they have mentioned in them, they are not programmes that, as was being done previously under the old Standing Orders, would have received approval when the policy is approved. We keep asking, even if not for the purposes of approval, just present those programme documents so that Parliament is seized with it, Civil Society Organisations (CSOs), the general public, and citizens can understand.

Mr Speaker, currently, the Government has launched 17 programmes. The last time we talked about it was about nine. When it got to 11, we spoke about it. Now, it is 17, not one—[*Interruption*]

The Majority Chief Whip is asking; may I give him a list? The Agriculture for Economic Transformation Agenda, launched on 12th April, 2025, is not before Parliament. One Million Coders Programme, launched on 16th April, 2025, is not before Parliament. Adwumawura Programme, launched on 28th April, 2025, is not before Parliament. National Apprenticeship Programme, 1st May, 2025, is not before Parliament. Mr Speaker, when an informal copy of the 24-Hour Economy document was presented to the Speaker, he advised that that one should also be brought and laid. That has also not been—There are several of them. I do not want to take too much time. But I think it is important that the Government brings these programme documents so that scrutiny can be better established. That is my first point.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Kojo Nkrumah, yesterday, the 24-Hour Economy Bill was laid here.

Mr Nkrumah: No. The programme document as has been approved by Cabinet. Because that Bill will emanate from the programme document. It shows the policy direction of the Government. Previously, we used to approve the economic policy. So once one mentions it and then you have that cover, you are fine. It is for their own good because there will be times when a Question may come up, and then they will have the cover that the policy has been approved. So it is for their own good, and it is also for the benefit of the oversight function.

Mr Speaker, another matter that I would have loved to see in the Business Statement is a matter of grave concern to a lot of parents and wards across our country today. The West African Senior School Certificate Examination (WASSCE) results were just released. There are distinct worries about the levels of failure in Mathematics and Social Studies. We would have expected that by now, we are programming to at least bring in maybe the Ghana Education Service (GES), the Minister for Education, or persons who are associated with it, so that first of all, we can get an empirical understanding of why.

As at now, all we hear is people on the radio; everybody giving their own interpretation, anecdotes here and there. It is important that a matter like this, the thousands of students who have failed, their parents, and the entire country have

an understanding of why. Mr Speaker, I would like to encourage the Leadership of the Government benches to find a way to programme as quickly as possible the Minister for Education, maybe with the support of GES, to appear before us and begin to give us an empirical sense of the “why.” That way, we can tone down on everybody’s anecdote and story and reason and what is now becoming unnecessary partisan politicisation of the matter, and get a clear understanding, and if possible, some interventions to resolve it. Else, the fate of the over 200,000 Ghanaian children we have been told is at stake, and it is now being reduced to political football. I think as important as these ones are, this is a matter that should be programmed for urgent attention by Parliament.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, thank you for indulging me. I just want to bring this matter that has come before the House on several occasions, again, to the attention of Leadership. It is a matter that has been overflooded. I am referring to the defective air conditioners in our offices. I would like to know the updates. Every time we bring this matter to the Floor of the House, we are told that it is being worked upon. We want to know updates. If we have begun a new procurement process, let us know how far we have gone, because it is becoming a nuisance.

Mr Speaker, I have also observed that a Question that I asked that has been programmed for today has resurfaced again on the Business Statement for

Thursday, 11th December; Question numbered 316. So, I will suggest that it be deleted.

Mr Speaker, one other issue is, you remember I asked three Questions on the number of churches, mosques, and shrines and the week ending 31st October, on the Business Statement, two of them were programmed; the number of shrines that are registered, and the number of mosques that are registered. Strangely, the one on mosques was deleted, and the shrine was programmed for me to ask. Today, I have seen on the Business Statement that on Friday, 12th, they brought up the Question on churches. Meanwhile, the one on mosques is missing. These questions were asked on the same day and admitted by the Speaker on the same day. I went to the Table Office and looked into the Question book, and they were all admitted and transmitted to the Minister. So why do you bring them in piecemeal? The other day was a Question on shrines, and it appeared as if I did not know what I was doing. Next week, the Question is on churches, and the Question on mosques is missing. They are related questions.

So, the three should be programmed at the same time. I am just pleading with the Leader of the Business Committee. If the Question on churches has found expression here, then we should add the Question on mosques. Otherwise, there is no need for it to be programmed for me to ask.

Again, the traffic situation in the country is becoming so alarming. I mean,

congestion in town. This is normal, especially when we are heading towards Christmas. I do not know what is being done to ensure that there is some easiness when we are driving from Parliament and to our respective places of engagement.

Mr Speaker, thank you for indulging me. I am grateful.

2:55 p.m.

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, I am extremely grateful. Let me thank the Chairman of the Business Committee.

Mr Speaker, I wish to find out at the start of this very meeting, it has been advertised that we would be going on recess by 19th of this month and the Hon Leader who just presented the Business Statement has mentioned something significant which has to do with the fact that we need to join our families, not only our families but as representatives of the people, we have a lot of activities, invitations here and there. I wish to respectfully find out from Leader if the advertised timetable still works or whether we are looking at extension or reduction, whichever way, if the Committee is in a position to let the House know when exactly we will be going on recess.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me listen to Hon Member for Tafo first.

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I think I am relatively younger in this Chamber as compared to the Chief Whip. This is my fifth year in this House.

Mr Speaker, in fact, this is the first time that we see an item advertised in the *Order Paper* for close to a month and it has not been taken. You may check the Business Statement that was read here last week. Almost all Questions that were advertised and were supposed to have been taken by the Ministers have been repeated. Where are their Ministers? Have they abandoned Government Business? Is it that they are not told that these Questions have been advertised and for that matter they are supposed to be in this Chamber to answer to the Questions that have been asked by Members of Parliament? In fact, it is one of the few tools that is available to the Minority to be able to play that oversight responsibility that has been enshrined in the Constitution of the Republic of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, we are appealing to them. The Ministers should be available in this Chamber to answer to these Questions that have been advertised. Last week, 27 Questions were advertised. This week, almost all those Questions have been re-advertised and they have added on to about 42. As to whether we are really going to exhaust these Questions is something that I do not trust. So, we are pleading with the Majority Chief Whip to make sure that the Ministers appear before this House to answer those Questions.

Secondly, Mr Speaker, a matter was raised here last week during a Business Statement in respect of an update that was given to the State or if you like, to the Republic by the Ghana Health Service that about 880 cases of Monkey pox (Mpox) have been reported and confirmed as of 20th November. We argued that it is a matter of public interest and for that matter, the Minister for Health should be programmed to appear before this House and comment on it so that we will know how the Ministry of Health intends to deal with the matter. In fact, Members of Parliament also agreed that it is a matter of public interest and when the Minister for Health finally appears before this House, we would find a way to help the Ministry to deal with this problem. As we speak, if we check the Business Statement that has been advertised, nothing of the sort has been stated in it. Clearly, the Government is not even interested in the diseases that affect Ghanaians in this country.

Mr Speaker, I also want to add my voice to what the Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah said, and maybe I should state a few statistics for us to know the enormity of the challenge that we have. Since 2021 to date, when students write WASSCE, we had always been seeing an increment with respect to their performance. It is only in 2025 that all the core subjects, that is, English Language, Mathematics, Integrated Science and Social Studies, we have had a dip in terms of their performance. In fact, in 2024, the performance rate for the English Language was 69.52 per cent.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Assafuah, I think the issue has been raised and will be addressed, so you do not need to go into the details.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, I agree with you, but let me end. It is important for the Ghanaian people and the Minister for Education to know that you cannot have 69.52 per cent of persons passing English Language in 2024, only to have about 48 per cent of them passing in 2025. It is an important matter and it is proper that the Minister for Education is scheduled to come before this House to be able to do that.

Mr Dafeamekpor — *rose* —

Mr Assafuah: They do not even have the patience to listen to us.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Assafuah, that application has already been made by Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah.

Mr Assafuah: Yes, Mr Speaker, but I am also adding the statistics to it for us to know the enormity of what is happening; we are just giving more information. Mr Speaker, sometimes, allow us to be able to also communicate what the Ghanaian people want to hear.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to add my voice.

I want to commend the Business Committee for a good job done, except to say, Mr Speaker, that there are some concerns among the Ghanaian public about many instances where people are being arrested for expressing their views, exercising their right to free speech. Given our role, I am of the view that we may have to programme the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice to come to this House, not as Attorney-General, but Minister for Justice. We need to distinguish the two and know when he is coming here as Attorney-General, and when he is coming as Minister for Justice. He should be programmed to come to this House as Minister for Justice to brief us on how he is going to protect the fundamental human rights of Ghanaians, particularly free speech, so that they can speak freely without being arrested. Just yesterday, we heard Martin Kpebu was arrested for making some allegations against the Special Prosecutor. There is also the case of Nana Yaw Yeboah Wendell; it is becoming one too many.

Mr Speaker, the transition to democratic rule should be fruitful to all Ghanaians, particularly the exercise of free speech. Ghanaians are being arrested, incarcerated, and being imposed with serious bail terms. This was a feature of pre-1992.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, we have not forgotten that the current Government was given birth to by the Provisional National Defence Council (PNDC), which is known for breaching fundamental human rights. Our democracy should bear fruit.

Mr Dafeamekpor — *rose* —

Mr Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, because we do not have much time, I want to take all the comments and then you respond to all the issues.

Let me now take comments from Hon Agbana.

Mr Eric Edem Agbana: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Let me commend the Business Committee for a good work done.

Mr Speaker, I rise to seek guidance. About four weeks ago, I had a Statement that was admitted by the Committee on the Ohawu Agricultural College. It kept appearing. *[Interruption]* I am seeking guidance. Mr Speaker, I had a Statement that was admitted by the Business Committee and programmed for the week, but due to the nature of Business, we could not take it. I want to humbly plead if it is possible to have, because it is a very important Statement on the Ohawu Agricultural College. It is a constituency-specific Statement, and I would ask the Chief Whip if there is any chance that can be programmed for next week. Thank you.

3:05 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Do not be intimidated. I am happy that you were not intimidated, because the Minority Chief Whip was warning

you, but you were bold and were not intimidated.

Yes, Hon Second Deputy Minority Whip?

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): I thank you very much for the opportunity. I want to commend the acting Leader, Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor, for his stability so far.

Mr Speaker, as I proceed to make my enquiry, it has to do with Zipline. During our debate on the Ministry of Health's Budget, the Deputy Minister—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Order! Order!

Mr Shaib: The Deputy Minister made a very scathing statement to the effect that, we are using the Zipline drone to lift condoms, mosquito nets and paracetamol to the recipients who may need these services.

Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the acting Majority Leader if he is aware that on the 1st December, during the celebration of the World AIDS Day, it was announced that 42 people get infected by Human Immunodeficiency virus (HIV) daily in Ghana. As I speak, recent statistics show that approximately 330,000 to 355,000 people are living with HIV. Is the Deputy Minister for Health saying that we should stop using condoms or stop making provisions for condoms to people who need them?

Mr Speaker, the National Democratic Congress (NDC) youth organiser in the Western North—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Second Deputy Minority Whip, I do not know if you want the Leader—

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I was going to round up that, the Minister for Health, respectfully, should be programmed to come and respond to the surge in HIV cases and what the Ministry is doing about it. Also, to tell us what is happening to Zipline. Because we are aware that it saved an NDC organiser in the Western North.

Thank you much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Yes, Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe?

First Deputy Majority Whip (Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, today is Thursday, tomorrow Friday, the Farmers' Day and then on Saturday, we have to attend the funeral of the former Member of Parliament for Akwatia. An Hon Member here also has a funeral. We have a lot and a chunk of work. So, I am begging the Majority Chief Whip who is working on behalf of the Leader, to defer some of the Questions for next week. When the Majority Leader comes, he would answer them all. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Then, make sure we leave here early. We do our Government Business and leave here early. So, we should cut short

some of the contributions, so we can do Government Business and go home.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let me thank Members for the comments and the concerns raised in respect of the Business Statement presented by way of matters arising.

The Hon Member for Ofoase Ayirebi made the point that there is the need for Government to, as it were, present the policy programmes. Programme documents regarding all Government's flagship programmes launched thus far and by his reckoning, there are about 17 of them. It is well noted. We will take it up with the Minister for Finance and the other sector Ministers. I know that some are coming by way of Bills, for instance, the 24-Hour Economy Policy has come by way of Bills. Legislation will be passed to ensure that there is a proper legal framework and others. It is well noted and we would endeavour to do that. In fact, that is how it is supposed to be.

Then the issue about the West African Senior High School Examination (WASSCE) Fortuitously, I can report to the House that the President has directed the Minister for Education to, as it were, study the Chief Examiner's Report on the 2025 WASSCE results with the Director General of Ghana Education Service (GES). I believe that the Minister will be well informed to come and brief the House regarding the matters contained in the chief examiner's report. We would try and programme him for next week to do this.

Mr Speaker, Professor Kingsley Nyarko raised the issue of the situation of air conditioners and some offices numbering about 54, according to my record. The complaints that are officially before myself and my Brother, the Minority Chief Whip; there are about 54 offices that are not having functioning air conditioners. So, Members find it difficult—

It is also a matter of record that Parliament is going through the procurement processes to get the air conditioners rehabilitated and replaced. Also, on the issue of the lift, the procurement processes are unfortunately painfully tedious. Because if we do not go through, we would be in breach and nobody wants to be in breach. So, things are being approached with some alacrity. But I believe that by the time we are back, they would be installed.

Then the Hon Member also noted that he has a Question but same has been repeated. This is also noted for deletion. His concern was also about the fact that he has filed some Questions regarding the number of shrines and mosques that exist in the country. But he is surprised that another Question regarding the number of churches has rather been slated.

What I can say about that is this means the Minister has obtained the adequate information necessary for him to come and respond to the Question. But the information available for that of the number of mosques and shrines has delayed. That is why we cannot advertise a Question for him to come and respond

to when he has not gotten the material to do so. So, that would be the plausible reason for advertising that—Next week, the Minister would come and respond to that of the number of churches. But that of the number of shrines is not ready. But we would look into this and explain why that of the shrine is not listed for next week.

I believe when he is ready, he will notify us; then it can be advertised for him to come and respond to.

Then, on the issue of traffic. Professor Kingsley Nyarko, how can the issue of traffic congestion be a matter for the Business Statement? *[Interruption]* Please, Parliament cannot control traffic. So, what we can do is that—It is that particular time of the year, where there is a general congestion because of the upcoming yuletide. So, we want to encourage Members to endeavour to leave home early, so they can beat the early morning heavy traffic congestion which starts from about 7:30 a.m. to 8:00 a.m. If they leave home by 6:30 a.m. to 7:00a.m., they would get to Parliament from wherever they are located in the metropolis. Even if they are in Tema and leave home by 6.30 a.m., they would be in Parliament by 7:00 a.m.

3:15 p.m.

But if we sit at home till about 9:00 a.m. or 10:00 a.m., then leave home, one would not get here by 12:00 noon, because all the traders will be pouring in. Be it as it may, we want to urge the Director-General of Motor Transport and Traffic Department (MTTD) to deploy

more men onto the roads to ensure an easy flow of traffic. So, for the general ease of movement within the city towards Christmas and immediately after Christmas and New Year, it is noted. On behalf of my Majority Leader, I want to encourage Members to leave home early. We are in the budget season, so get here early so we can do Business early.

Mr Speaker, then, Hon Frank Afriyie raised the issue of the advertised time for going on recess and whether that timetable is still in operation. Yes, it is. But the general concern of Hon Members is that, this time, we have the opportunity to be able to do things much quicker than it is advertised. If that happens, it means we can go on recess before the 19th of December. We can take about five, six or seven more reports today in addition to what we did yesterday, it means we are doing close to 16 to 20 out of 41. If next week we are able to take — we can finish the reports by next week, depending on the circumstances. If we are able to finish the reports by the 12th, it means when we enter the third week of the month, we would be able to pass the Appropriation Bill and go on recess, even before 19th December, 2025. So, it depends on the enormity of work and the alacrity with which we are handling the reports and its approval.

Then my Hon Brother Vincent Assafuah rehashed. He is not on the Floor to listen to me. Hon Member, stop the conspiracy and pay attention. With the WASSCE, I believe the Minister, upon perusal of the Chief Examiner's report, will be informed well enough to come and brief the House. We would

then see how we can all formulate programmes and policies to ensure that we do not experience this again. This has not happened for some time and we are all concerned. So, once he briefs us, I am sure we would look at what to do and the directions to give. The call that the Minister for Health comes to brief the House is also noted.

Mr Speaker, we can endeavour to programme him to come and respond to Members' concerns, if the Business of the House permits. Then, the call that the Attorney-General (AG) should come here not as AG, but constitutionally speaking, the AG cannot be decoupled from the Minister for Justice. He is in a composite capacity. So, whenever he is here, he comes as the AG as well as the Minister for Justice. I agree that we need to programme him to come to respond to some of the issues you have raised. I would be raising that matter shortly.

Hon Edem Agbana's concern is noted. Statements that have been advertised, for the sponsors of those Statements to take them on the Floor. Given the exigencies, they are being rolled over to next week. Yesterday, I was actually looking out for him, because we had a window to take a couple. Because we could not see some of them, we rolled them over to next week and given the exigencies, when we get the window like we did today and yesterday, we would take them alongside Government Business.

Then, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib's concerns about Zipline are noted. The Minister for Health is then being

demanded to appear to address the issue of the Zipline as well as the other matter that Hon Vincent Assafuah raised.

Mr Speaker, these are the compendium of issues that Members raised.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, let me start off by saying that I also recognise we do not have time. I do not agree with the Majority Chief Whip. By the way, he has done well so far. At least, he is not attempting to trivialise the issues we are raising and I commend him highly. It is unfortunate the matter on air conditioners is coming up on the Floor. Ideally, what should be done is that an Administrator should have ferry progress reports to the Chief Whips so that the Whips can update Members on the various platforms. It is not a matter that we should be discussing at Plenary. So, that should be taken in good stride.

Hon Leader, on traffic congestion, I disagree with the Majority Chief Whip because they are saying that we should reset and the reset cut across all spheres of life. In other jurisdictions, authorities are getting innovative. In the context of their reset agenda, they must get innovative and they should get the Minister for Roads and Highways and his agencies to come and tell us. It is predictable that getting to the Christmas festivities, there will be traffic. We cannot sit. We must get innovative.

Mr Speaker, we are clearly getting closer to adjournment. We have a lot of issues. The morale of their Backbench is weak. I do not have to mention names. It

is weak. So, Leader, do something. There are real issues that Mr Speaker has cancelled.

Mr Speaker, there is a lot of noise coming from the Majority Side, I do not know if they are not interested in the morale issues I am going to raise. Hon Deputy Minister, listen, we are talking about real issues. They are important. They cannot talk about these issues. It is the Minority who relates. We are speaking for them and they are making noise. Yes, now they are talking. We are getting closer to rising. There are real issues I do not want to elucidate unnecessarily. Leader, I nudged you at the Business Committee. We need, as a matter of agency, Committee of the Whole. The exchequer must come here. That is why he is one of us. There are a lot of things that are outstanding, bordering on Members and some are statutory. He must be here. So, I propose to him to do all the legwork. Today, I see he is standing in the stead of the Majority leader. I will not be surprised.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, I could see some of the Backbenchers giving indication that —

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: They are excited.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, they are excited.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: The news is exciting. They are in power. So, on Wednesday, we should have a Committee of the Whole. The Minister

for Finance should be given foreknowledge, not just the news of the Committee of the Whole, the items which I cannot elucidate on. I will relate to the Majority Chief Whip so that the Minister will come prepared. That is the first one. Still on the Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, again, there is a matter which is of huge public interest. The Ministry of Finance is owing the Administrator of Stool lands nine months' arrears. This is money for our chiefs. Our traditional leaders are being owed nine months of payment, royalties.

3:25 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister should find it. When he coming to the Committee of the Whole, he must prepare to speak to this matter.

Mr Speaker, if I may reference Order 6 of the Standing Orders, and with your leave I read:

“Independent Constitutional Bodies include the Electoral Commission, Commission on Human Rights and Administrative Justice, National Commission for Civic Education, National Media Commission, Office of the Administrator of the District Assemblies Common Fund, Office of the Auditor-General, Bank of Ghana, and other bodies established to have exclusive jurisdiction in the performance of assigned functions;”

Mr Speaker, the PURC clearly falls under the description. A while ago, cumulatively, they have increased utility;

specifically, electricity, to some 18.34 per cent. Just recently, there has been an additional 9.8 per cent. It is generating a lot of discussion, and its impact on productivity generally in this country could be called to question.

Mr Speaker, at the Committee of the Whole, the PURC must find their way here. They must come and meet the people's representative and explain why the increment. Of course, we are all aware of the dollar effect on this utility pricing. They claim that they have stabilised the dollar, and I am not contesting it. If they have stabilised the dollar, it must reflect in the pricing of the utility. If the Minister for Finance is being scheduled for Wednesday, the PURC must find its way here on Thursday, whether rain or shine; they must come to Parliament. They should come and explain and put matters in context.

Mr Speaker, we have all been passionate about our pension scheme. We seem to be running away from it, today, Alhaji Dauda related to it. Why are we afraid of something that is beneficial to us? The Committee that was put together by this House has travelled across the globe, and a Report has been generated. The Report was programmed by the *Order Paper*, and suddenly, the Business programmed on the *Order Paper* has vanished.

What is happening? This is our welfare. Mr Speaker, I am begging the Hon Leader, let us get these Reports presented, and then we can set them into motion, the other Businesses we have to execute.

Lastly, Mr Speaker, the solid and liquid waste management service providers in this country have not been paid by this Government for close to one year; it is true. With the entire liquid waste generated by Parliament, if we are not careful, there will be a blast; if that happens, the effect will be enormous.

Mr Speaker, apart from the Minister for Finance coming to the Committee of the Whole, the Leadership should meet with him. Mr Speaker, I implore your directive that these two matters must be raised. The royalties to our chiefs, and the payment to waste management service providers must be done. For one year, they have not done it, and there could be a possible epidemic breakout in our country.

Again, Mr Speaker, let me commend Hon Majority Chief Whip that at least, he has not trivialised the things we are relating to. I pray that he will always present the Business Statement.

Mr Speaker, having said this, I thank you for the opportunity, and he must also do his work in the printing room to get the Reports. If the passage of the Appropriation Bill is delayed, he cannot trace his hands to the Minority. We are ready to help them pass their Appropriation Bill, but if their Reports are not being generated, there is nothing we can do. At least so far, we have been very magnanimous to them.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I knew he would do this.

With the issue of the air conditioners, we want to assure Hon Members that the

House has taken this matter seriously, and therefore, the tender committee has done its work. The procurement processes are underway, and it has come up a lot of times. The Deputy Clerk is here; he deputises for his boss. They should expedite action on that, so that Hon Members can function from their offices.

Mr Speaker, with the issue of the congestion, I do not know why the Hon Minority Chief Whip wants to bring Parliament into the management of traffic; I do not get it. We are imploring Hon Members, technically, to leave home earlier than they do; that is the surest solution to the matter. But it is noted, we are calling on the Director General of the Motor Traffic and Transport Department (MTTD) to deploy more men to ease the congestion. More roads are being tarred, and more access roads are being generated. We are resetting the traffic network in the metropolis and elsewhere. So, I am sure by January, they will get to Parliament faster than they do.

Mr Speaker, with the issue about the coming of the Minister for Finance to meet Hon Members at the Committee of the Whole, that is acceptable to us. We will programme him. Even though the Minority Chief Whip indicated that he would not reveal the agenda, he went ahead to reveal a couple. So, with the issues that he listed, he and I, as the Whips, will sit and agree on the items that he needs to brief the House on. We will also discuss with the Leaders, and when he comes, he can address all of them as a whole.

Mr Speaker, it will be more prudent, given the times, to schedule the PURC on the day that the Minister for Finance will be here, just to manage time. If the Minister for Finance comes on a day, and we have to programme another day for the Committee of the Whole to get PURC, it may burn our time. So, I want to plead that the day we are programming the Minister for Finance, we get PURC to also appear, so that we can deal with the issues.

Then, with the issue of the Pension Scheme reports, it has been advertised for some time, and the reports are ready. I do not think there is any deliberate attempt to gloss over it. It is just because of the exigencies. So, I believe on Tuesday, if we have good numbers, it can be taken, debated and adopted. Then, the processes can be initiated.

Mr Speaker, on solid waste, we will meet about it and discuss this matter with the Minister for Finance when he comes. So, as part of the briefings that the Minister for Finance will come and give to the Committee of the Whole, this will feature. He and I will agree on the items for the agenda. The royalties will also feature.

Mr Speaker, why is Mr Annoh-Dompreh heckling me? He raised the matter, and I am responding to that, yet he is still heckling me.

Mr Speaker, save me from Mr Annoh-Dompreh. *[Laughter]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: You are saved.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, with these matters raised by Hon Members and responded to and noted, I believe that we are good to adopt the Business Statement for next week.

I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Members, the Business Statement, as thoroughly discussed, is hereby adopted.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let me seek your leave to raise a matter of urgent public importance.

Mr Speaker, yesterday, while we were on the Floor trying to conclude Business, news filtered through that one of our seasoned lawyers, Mr Martin Kpebu, was invited by the Office of the Special Prosecutor (OSP). He presented himself willingly, and somehow, he got detained. Until about 10:00 p.m., he was still in detention, and he was supposed to have been granted bail. He was given onerous bail terms; he has been asked to produce landed property and all that. Mr Speaker, we cannot do this at this time. These are serious matters.

3:35 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, permit me.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: All right, but under what Order are you coming?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, it is a matter of urgent public importance.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, come properly.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I have invoked the Orders.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Which Order?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I invoked Order 93, and I was in full flight.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Anyway, now that you have mentioned Order 93, you can go on.

STATEMENT

Office of the Special Prosecutor

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we are saying that the Office of the Special Prosecutor has abused its powers in this matter. I will not hesitate to say that this House created the Office of the Special Prosecutor, and if it continues to abuse its powers, then we may have to abrogate it. Because we cannot create such an office to handle important matters of concern to the state, and it will be detaining citizens who have submitted themselves willingly, because of a certain supposed abstraction of a public officer from performing a certain duty. That is a misdemeanour.

So, Mr Speaker, let me place this matter on record, that this House shall be inviting him to brief us on the circumstances under which the Office will detain a citizen under such flimsy, whimsical circumstances; it is untenable. And yesterday, his conduct was frowned upon by the entire nation.

I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, you came under Order 93, but it was the wrong time. We normally invoke Order 93 during Statement time. Now, we have gone past Statement time, and about to do Government Business, and we are bringing this discussion again. Anyway, I will invite one person from the left Side, Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, to comment on it.

Mr Nkrumah: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, first of all, I wish that the Business Committee had properly programmed this, so that it would have been part of the earlier conversations. The subject that the Majority Chief Whip has raised is an important matter. But in my view, it is not about the Office of the Special Prosecutor. It is about a culture that has crept into the investigative and law enforcement bodies in this country. Where they invite persons, and to quote the words of the Majority Chief Whip, who appears on their own volition, to assist them in investigations. Then they arrest and detain and put onerous bail conditions on them. In fact, in the case of his good friend, the respected lawyer he is speaking about, he was asked to bring landed property in his own name. These are some of the onerous bail conditions that we have been speaking about, that the investigative bodies are beginning to weaponise.

Unfortunately, Mr Speaker, as we say in Twi, *etua wo yonko ho a, na etua dua mu; etua wo ho dez a, na etua nipa mu*. To wit, when it happens to somebody,

and he is complaining about it, they see absolutely nothing wrong with it. When it happens to them, now they complain. Today, he is complaining because it is his friend. So, if he wants to invite the Special Prosecutor to come and answer why, in his view, they are weaponising their powers, perhaps he should extend that invitation to all the other investigative bodies that people have raised complaints about, that they are beginning to weaponise the powers of the state given to them.

Today, because it happened to Martin Kpebu, he is making it a matter of urgent public interest. The Minority Leader, Osahen, raised this matter over and over again, that investigative bodies are weaponising their powers and imposing onerous bail conditions. In fact, instances where one does not even expect them to detain—They invited a man, who appeared and provided information, and because they know where he is, there is no basis to detain him. They will detain persons and put onerous bails, whip and whisk them away to an unknown destination. And their lawyers, everybody, will be looking for them. We have had clients at our firm, and we are chasing all over town. When we say it, because it has not happened to them, they do not complain.

That is why our elders say, *ɔkɔtɔ deɜ ne bo dwɛ*. Today, because it has happened on their Side, they are complaining. If we take a leaf from the book of history, when the Preventive Detention Act was being passed, Members of the Convention People's Party (CPP) who were happily shouting that it was a good idea, in the end,

became victims of it. If there is a practice that is untoward and it is being raised, let us look at it without partisan lenses. We on this Side, if indeed they extend that invitation, I am not sure we will object. But perhaps our advice would be that all the other investigative bodies that are being weaponised, which have been complained about, which they turn a blind eye and a deaf ear to, maybe the Chief Whip should add it, so that we can do a nonpartisan, diligent job in the interest of the Republic. Because precedents are being set, which will not be good for our democracy going forward.

Mr Speaker, those would be my words in contribution.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

I am not taking any comments again. We have brought the Statement to a close, and I am unable to take any further comment on that. Leadership, any indication?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let me pray that we take the Motions. Yesterday, the Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies had three of their Reports ready. So, we want to take those three Reports quickly because the Member has been waiting patiently to present them.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, which page?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, that would be page 12. So, let us take the Motions numbered 26, 27, 28 and 29. We will take those in that order.

3:45 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Members, today appears to be the last day of the week. We have already spent more than three hours. With regard to the Motion, if the Hon Ministers are here or if the Estimates of the Institution is supposed to be laid by the Hon Majority Leader, the Chairperson and the Ranking Member—the Chairperson will obviously be seconding and presenting the Committee's Report. The Chairperson will not use more than eight minutes. The Ranking Member will not use more than eight minutes. All the other Members who will be commenting on any report will not use more than five minutes. I hope I am making myself clear. No Member will be allowed to speak more than five minutes by way of comment. We want to regulate the time in such a way that we will be able to do as many as we can.

On that note, let me invite the Majority Leader to—

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let me make this small correction. The Motion numbered 26 ought to stand in the name of the Chairperson of the Committee on Economy and Development. Inadvertently, we advertised this in the name of the Majority Leader. If we can make that correction.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Who is the Chairperson of the Committee on Economy and Development? Hon Afful is not here, but the Ranking Member is here.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, this often happens, so it is not a problem. When we get to that item, we can make that up. The one who moved the Motion can seek your leave and make that amendment.

Are we starting from the item numbered 24? Which item are we taking now?

ANNUAL ESTIMATES, 2026

AUDIT SERVICE

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That this honourable House approves the sum of GH¢907,924,349.00 for the services of the Audit Service for the year ending 31st December 2026.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Chairperson of the Committee also doubles as the Leader of the House. He has directed that the Hon Member, being a member of the Committee, is permitted under our rules to be able to present the Report of the Committee. Mr Speaker, that is our prayer.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I have already granted the leave.

Mr Isaac Ashai Odamtten (NDC — Tema East) *on behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee:* Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion, and in so doing, present your Committee's Report. I urge the *Hansard* to capture the entire Report as read.

Executive Summary

This Report embodies the deliberations, observations, and recommendations of the Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies on the 2026 Annual Budget Estimates of the Ghana Audit Service, as referred by the Rt Hon Speaker pursuant to Order 254(2) of the Standing Orders of the Parliament of Ghana. The referral followed the presentation of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2026 Financial Year by the Hon Minister for Finance in accordance with Article 179 of the 1992 Constitution.

The Committee undertook a thorough examination of the proposed allocations, guided by the constitutional and statutory mandate of the Ghana Audit Service under Article 188 and the Audit Service Act, 2000 (Act 584). The Committee affirms that the Service plays a pivotal role in promoting transparency, accountability, and good governance across the public sector.

In 2025, the Ghana Audit Service achieved significant operational results, including the completion of 5,989 audits, submission of 15 Auditor-General's Reports to Parliament within the constitutional deadline, recovery of GH¢21,876,101.88 into the Auditor-General's Recovery Account, and receipt of 2,040 Asset and Liability Declaration forms, reinforcing integrity within the public service. Under its Management and Administration Programme, the Service advanced capacity-building initiatives and

recorded substantial progress on regional office construction projects in Kumasi (98.69 per cent) and Tamale (88 per cent).

For the 2026 Financial Year, the Service intends to strengthen its oversight responsibilities through comprehensive audits of Public Accounts, enhanced staff training in new audit methodologies, oil and gas revenue auditing, and GIFMIS systems controls, as well as the nationwide roll-out of the Audit Management Information System (AMIS) and the Learning Management System (LMS). Planned audit coverage includes the Consolidated Fund, Public Boards and Corporations, District Assemblies, Pre-Tertiary Institutions, Special Funds, Bank of Ghana foreign exchange operations, and Ghana Missions abroad.

The Committee also noted key challenges, including shortfalls in Compensation and Goods and Services allocations for 2026, logistical constraints affecting recovery efforts, delays in recruitment approvals, procurement bottlenecks affecting CAPEX utilisation, and policy concerns regarding the national Asset and Liability Declaration regime. The Committee commends the Auditor-General for uncovering major irregularities such as the US\$5.6 million breach at Ghana's Mission in Washington and for significant recovery efforts that have contributed to improved public financial accountability.

After careful scrutiny, the Committee is satisfied that the proposed budgetary allocation of nine hundred and seven

million, nine hundred and twenty-four thousand, three hundred and forty-nine Ghana cedis (GH¢907,924,349.00) is justified and essential for the effective execution of the Service's mandate. The Committee emphasises that timely and adequate funding is indispensable to maintaining the Service's operational efficiency, improving compliance within the public sector, and safeguarding the public purse.

Accordingly, the Committee recommends that the House adopts this Report and approves the sum of GH¢907,924,349.00 for the 2026 Financial Year.

Introduction

The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana (GoG) for the 2026 Financial Year was presented to Parliament by the Hon Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson, on Thursday, 13th November 2025, in accordance with Article 179 of the 1992 Constitution and Section 21(3) of the Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921).

Pursuant to Order 254(2) of the Standing Orders of Parliament, the Rt. Hon. Speaker subsequently referred the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ghana Audit Service to the Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies for consideration and for the submission of a Report to the House. This referral is in line with Parliament's constitutional duty to ensure that all independent oversight institutions, particularly those central to accountability, transparency,

and the protection of the public purse, receive the necessary scrutiny and budgetary support to discharge their mandates effectively.

In fulfilment of this directive, the Committee undertook a detailed examination of the Audit Service's 2026 Estimates, assessed the consistency of the proposed allocations with the Service's constitutional and statutory obligations, and engaged extensively with the Auditor-General and his team to obtain clarifications on operational priorities, financial needs, and emerging challenges. The Introduction therefore sets the context for the Committee's subsequent deliberations, findings, and recommendations regarding the 2026 Annual Budget Estimates of the Ghana Audit Service.

Deliberations

On Wednesday, 26th November 2025, the Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies convened a formal meeting with the Auditor-General, Mr Johnson Akuamoah Asiedu, officials of the Ghana Audit Service, and technical officers from the Ministry of Finance to consider the 2026 Annual Budget Estimates of the Audit Service. The engagement formed a critical part of the Committee's oversight responsibility, enabling Members to interrogate the proposed allocations, seek clarification on operational priorities, and assess the alignment of the Service's financial requirements with its constitutional mandate under Article 188 and the Audit Service Act, 2000 (Act 584).

During the deliberations, the Auditor-General and his team provided detailed submissions on the Service's 2025 operational performance, challenges encountered in implementing planned activities, the status of audit recoveries, logistical constraints, staffing needs, and the projected deliverables for the 2026 Financial Year. The Ministry of Finance further furnished explanations on the basis for the approved ceilings and the fiscal considerations informing the allocation.

The Committee expresses its sincere appreciation to the Auditor-General and the accompanying officials for their technical insights, candour, and co-operation, which substantially enriched the Committee's analysis and facilitated a comprehensive examination of the Budget Estimates.

Reference Documents

In the course of its work, the Committee relied on a range of authoritative documents to guide its scrutiny of the 2026 Annual Budget Estimates of the Ghana Audit Service. These documents provided the necessary constitutional, legal, policy, and budgetary context for assessing the mandate, operational priorities, and financial requirements of the Service. The key reference materials consulted were:

- i. The 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana, which establishes the mandate and independence of the Ghana Audit Service under Articles 187–188;

- ii. The Standing Orders of the Parliament of Ghana, particularly provisions relating to the referral and consideration of budget estimates;
- iii. The Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921), which outlines the legal framework for public budgeting, financial governance, and accountability;
- iv. The Audit Service Act, 2000 (Act 584), which operationalises the constitutional mandate and sets out the functions and administrative structures of the Service;
- v. The National Medium-Term Development Policy Framework (NMTDPF), 2022–2025, which provides national strategic direction relevant to public financial management and anti-corruption efforts;
- vi. The Medium-Term Expenditure Framework (MTEF), 2025–2028, which details the resource envelope and expenditure ceilings applicable to the Service;
- vii. The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2026 Financial Year, presented to Parliament by the Hon Minister for Finance; and
- viii. The Report of the Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies on the Annual Estimates of the Audit Service for the 2025 Financial Year, which offered

comparative insights and context for tracking progress and outstanding commitments.

Policy Objectives of the Service Under the National Medium-Term Development Policy Framework (NMTDPF) For 2022-2025

Under the National Medium-Term Development Policy Framework (NMTDPF), 2022–2025, the operations of the Ghana Audit Service are anchored on two core policy objectives that directly support national efforts to strengthen public financial management and uphold accountability in the use of public resources. These policy objectives are as follows:

- i. To strengthen domestic resource mobilisation, by enhancing audit oversight across Ministries, Departments and Agencies (MDAs), Metropolitan, Municipal and District Assemblies (MMDAs), and other public institutions, thereby contributing to improved revenue assurance and efficiency in public expenditure; and
- ii. To promote the fight against corruption and economic crimes, through the conduct of timely, high-quality audits, enforcement of audit recommendations, recovery of misapplied public funds, and the reinforcement of transparency and integrity mechanisms within the public sector.

These objectives guide the Service's strategic focus and underpin the budgetary requirements submitted for the 2026 Financial Year.

Mission and Vision of the Audit Service

The mission of the Ghana Audit Service is to promote good governance, transparency, accountability, and probity within the nation's public financial management system. This is achieved through the conduct of independent, objective, and professional audits in accordance with recognised international standards, and through the submission of timely audit reports and actionable recommendations to Parliament for appropriate oversight and redress.

The vision of the Service is to evolve into a world-class Supreme Audit Institution, recognised for delivering professional, excellent, and cost-effective auditing services that contribute substantively to national development, strengthen the integrity of public institutions, and ensure the prudent management of public resources.

Core Functions

The Ghana Audit Service performs a set of core functions derived from its constitutional mandate under Articles 187–188 of the 1992 Constitution and its statutory obligations under the Audit Service Act, 2000 (Act 584). These functions are central to safeguarding the integrity of public financial management and ensuring accountability in the use of national resources. They include:

- i. Ensuring that all auditing activities prescribed under the Audit Service Act, 2000 (Act 584) are conducted in accordance

with best international auditing standards and practices, thereby promoting quality, independence, and professionalism in public sector auditing;

- ii. Conducting audits of all public funds and submitting corresponding reports to Parliament. This encompasses constitutional bodies, statutory institutions, and any organisation or entity established by an Act of Parliament, thus providing comprehensive oversight of the public financial ecosystem; and
- iii. Overseeing the effective implementation of the Assets and Liabilities Declaration regime, aimed at enhancing probity, transparency, and integrity among public office holders, and supporting national efforts to combat corruption and illicit enrichment.

2025 Operational Performance of the Audit Service

In fulfilment of its constitutional mandate, the Ghana Audit Service undertook several key activities across its core programmes during the 2025 financial year. The performance highlights under the Management and Administration Programme and the Audit Operations Programme are presented below.

Management and Administration

During the year under review, the Service implemented a number of

strategic administrative and capacity-building initiatives aimed at strengthening institutional efficiency and enhancing audit quality. Key achievements included:

- i. The organisation of a training workshop, in collaboration with the Public Financial Management Secretariat, for staff across eight regions on the newly adopted Financial Audit Methodology, marking the transition from the former Regulatory Audit Methodology;
- ii. The delivery of technical assistance training, in partnership with the United Kingdom National Audit Office, focused on Revenue and Information Systems Auditing, to build staff competence in applying an integrated financial and IT audit approach, particularly within the revenue sector;
- iii. The attainment of 98.69 per cent and 88 per cent completion levels, respectively, for the ongoing regional office construction projects in Kumasi and Tamale, reflecting significant progress in the Service's infrastructure expansion programme; and
- iv. The receipt of 2,040 completed Asset and Liability Declaration forms as of September 2025, in line with the Service's statutory responsibility to advance transparency and accountability among public office holders.

Audit Operations

Under its Audit Operations Programme, the Service continued to provide comprehensive oversight of public financial management by undertaking audits across a wide range of public institutions. The following achievements were recorded:

- i. Completion of 5,989 audits as at the end of September 2025, representing 87 per cent of the planned 6,880 audits for the year. The breakdown is as follows:
 - 4,596 audits of Ministries, Departments and Agencies (MDAs);
 - 261 audits of Metropolitan, Municipal and District Assemblies (MMDAs);
 - 62 audits of Traditional Councils;
 - 905 audits of Pre-Tertiary Educational Institutions and 10 Technical Universities;
 - 70 audits of Public Boards and Corporations, 72 Subvented Organisations, and 7 Defence advisories;
 - 6 Performance and Information Technology Audits.

- ii. Submission of fifteen (15) Auditor-General's Reports on the financial year ending 31st December 2024 to Parliament before the constitutional deadline of 30th June, together with five (5) performance audit reports submitted thereafter;
- iii. Recovery of GH¢21,876,101.88 into the Auditor-General's Recovery Account, of which GH¢20,400,000.00 was transferred to the Consolidated Fund, thereby reinforcing public confidence in the Service's recovery efforts and the broader public financial oversight system.

2025 Financial Performance of the Audit Service

For the 2025 Financial Year, Parliament appropriated a total amount of eight hundred and thirty-eight million, three hundred and sixty-nine thousand, eight hundred and sixty-five Ghana cedis (GH¢838,369,865.00) to the Ghana Audit Service for the implementation of its programmes and activities. Of this amount, GH¢833,479,865.00 was provided by the Government of Ghana (GoG), while GH¢4,890,000.00 was sourced from Foreign Loans and Grants (FLG).

The approved budget was distributed across the three main economic classifications as follows:

Economic Classification	Allocation (GH¢)
Compensation of Employees	710,735,897
Goods and Services	88,670,978
Capital Expenditure (CAPEX)	38,962,990
Total	838,369,865

As at the end of September 2025, an amount of GH¢492,714,154.65, representing 59 per cent of the total approved budget, had been released to the Service. This figure includes the full disbursement of the Foreign Loans and Grants component earmarked for Goods and Services. Over the same period, the Service recorded a total expenditure of GH¢470,014,492.45, reflecting ongoing commitments under compensation, operational activities, and capital projects.

A summary of the Service's budget execution for the period January to September 2025 is presented in **Table 1** below.

Table 1: 2025 Budget Expenditure Performance of the Audit Service (January – September 2025)

Economic Classification	Approved Budget (GH¢) (A)	Releases (GH¢) (B)	Actual Expenditure (GH¢) (C)	Variance 1 (A–B)	Variance 2 (B–C)
Compensation of Employees	710,735,897.00	414,483,162.41	414,483,162.41	296,252,734.59	–
Goods and Services	88,670,978.00	54,853,198.24	54,828,536.04	33,817,779.76	24,662.20
Capital Expenditure	38,962,990.00	23,377,794.00	702,794.00	15,585,196.00	22,675,000.00
Total	838,369,865.00	492,714,154.65	470,014,492.45	345,655,710.35	22,699,662.20

Source: 2026 Programme Based Budget Estimates for the Audit Service

Further details on the GoG-funded component of the budget execution are shown in **Table 2**.

Table 2: 2025 GoG Budget Performance (January – September 2025)

Economic Classification	Approved Budget (GH¢) (A)	Releases (GH¢) (B)	Actual Expenditure (GH¢) (C)	Variance 1 (A–B)	Variance 2 (B–C)
Compensation of Employees	710,735,897.00	414,483,162.41	414,483,162.41	296,252,734.59	–
Goods and Services	83,780,978.00	49,963,198.24	49,938,536.04	33,817,779.76	24,662.20

Capital Expenditure	38,962,990.00	23,377,794.00	702,794.00	15,585,196.00	22,675,000.00
Total	833,479,865.00	487,824,154.65	465,124,492.45	345,655,710.35	22,699,662.20

Source: 2026 Programme Based Budget Estimates for the Audit Service

Outlook for The 2026 Financial Year

In 2026, the Ghana Audit Service will intensify its role in safeguarding the integrity of public financial management by expanding the scope and depth of independent audits across ministries, departments, agencies, local authorities, and state enterprises. The Service will also strengthen measures to trace and recover misused public funds, improve mechanisms for monitoring the implementation of audit recommendations, and enhance integrity and accountability through more robust administration of the Assets and Liabilities Declaration regime.

In line with its constitutional mandate under Article 188 and the provisions of the Audit Service Act, 2000 (Act 584), the Service proposes to undertake the following activities during the 2026 Financial Year:

Management and Administration Programme

Under the Management and Administration Programme, the Service intends to pursue targeted initiatives aimed at improving institutional efficiency, staff capacity, and overall audit quality. The planned activities include:

- i. Submitting all Auditor-General's Reports to Parliament before the

constitutional deadline of 30th June;

- ii. Issuing and receiving 4,000 Assets and Liabilities Declaration forms from public office holders as part of efforts to strengthen transparency and ethical conduct;
- iii. Conducting capacity-building programmes on the application of new audit methodologies, in alignment with global best practices;
- iv. Organising specialised training both locally and internationally for staff in oil and gas revenue auditing, a sector of increasing national importance;
- v. Providing training on audit methodologies for assessing the controls and operations of the Government Integrated Financial Management Information System (GIFMIS);
- vi. Implementing full national roll-out training for staff on the use of the Audit Management Information System (AMIS) and the Learning Management System (LMS);
- vii. Holding five (5) sensitisation workshops on accountability

practices, including the implementation of the National Anti-Corruption Action Plan (NACAP); and

- viii. Undertaking five (5) quality assurance exercises to assess internal audit standards and ensure consistency with international norms.

Audit Operations

As part of its core mandate, the Service will, in 2026, undertake comprehensive audits of all Public Accounts of Ghana and submit the corresponding reports to Parliament. Audit coverage will extend to the Consolidated Fund, Public Boards and Corporations, Pre-Tertiary Institutions, District Assemblies, Special Funds, Bank of Ghana foreign exchange operations, Ghana Missions abroad, and other statutory and non-statutory funds.

The specific audit targets for the year are as follows:

- i. 5,153 audit units of Ministries, Departments and Agencies (MDAs);
- ii. 261 Metropolitan, Municipal and District Assemblies (MMDAs);
- iii. 100 Traditional Councils;

- iv. 961 Pre-Tertiary Educational Institutions;

- v. 10 Technical Universities;

- vi. 86 Public Boards and Corporations;

- vii. 91 Subvented Organisations;

- viii. 11 Performance and Information Technology (IT) Audits;

- ix. 45 Ghana Missions Abroad; and

- x. 7 Ghana Armed Forces Peace-keeping Operations Abroad.

2026 Annual Budget Estimates of the Audit Service

For the 2026 Financial Year, a total amount of nine hundred and seven million, nine hundred and twenty-four thousand, three hundred and forty-nine Ghana cedis (GH¢907,924,349.00) has been allocated to the Ghana Audit Service for the implementation of its planned programmes and activities. This entire allocation is to be funded by the Government of Ghana (GoG), reflecting the centrality of the Service's mandate to national governance, public accountability, and the protection of the public purse.

The budget allocation is distributed across the three main economic classifications as outlined in Table 3.

Table 3: 2026 Budgetary Allocation by Economic Classification

Economic Classification	GoG (GH¢)
Compensation of Employees	776,871,589.00
Goods and Services	93,780,978.00
Capital Expenditure	37,271,782.00
Total	907,924,349.00

Source: *Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2026 Financial Year*

This allocation is expected to support the full execution of the Service's oversight functions, ongoing institutional reforms, and planned capacity-building and audit activities across the country during the year under review.

Observations

In the course of its deliberations, the Committee made the following key observations regarding the operational, financial, and administrative posture of the Ghana Audit Service.

2025 Compensation Budget Performance

The Committee observed that the approved 2025 Compensation budget amounted to GH¢710,735,897.00, of which GH¢414,483,162.41 had been released and fully expended by the end of September 2025. This left an outstanding variance of GH¢296,252,734.59. Although this variance appeared substantial when assessed against the outstanding salary obligations for the final quarter of the year, officials from

the Audit Service clarified that the variance reflects not only salaries for October to December 2025, but also salary arrears accrued from January to December 2025. The Committee noted the clarification and underscored the importance of timely and full releases to avoid the accumulation of arrears.

2025 CAPEX Releases and Utilisation

The Committee observed that the Audit Service received GH¢23,377,794.00 in Capital Expenditure (CAPEX) releases for 2025 but had utilised only GH¢702,794.00 as of September 2025, leaving more than GH¢22 million unspent. Officials explained that the bulk of these funds had been committed to procurement processes particularly the acquisition of vehicles but had not yet translated into actual disbursement because procurement procedures were ongoing. The Committee advised the Service to expedite its procurement processes to ensure full utilisation of CAPEX allocations and avoid potential lapses or reversals of funds.

Compensation Allocation Shortfall for 2026

The Committee noted that although the Audit Service proposed GH¢825,425,673 for Compensation in 2026, the approved allocation was GH¢776,871,589, resulting in a shortfall of GH¢48,554,084. This gap poses significant challenges to the Service's ability to meet its personnel-related obligations, including salaries, new recruitments, and staff replacements. The Committee expressed concern that the shortfall may hinder the Service's capacity to maintain adequate staffing levels particularly in newly established offices and may compromise the effective execution of its nationwide mandate.

2026 Goods and Services Allocation and Operational Impact

The Committee observed that the Audit Service requested GH¢114,995,368 for Goods and Services, but received GH¢93,780,978, representing a shortfall of GH¢21,214,390. The Auditor-General informed the Committee that this reduction will impede several essential activities, including:

- The annual **launch of audits** and stakeholder engagements;
- Participation in international programmes of INTOSAI and AFROSAI;
- Media engagements aimed at promoting transparency; and

- Execution of mission-critical audits, some of which require extensive fieldwork and specialised expertise.

The Committee expressed concern that the shortfall may weaken operational effectiveness and limit the Service's ability to meet international obligations and best practices.

Audit of the Ghana's Mission to the United States (US)

The Committee was informed that the Audit Service is conducting an ongoing audit of the Ghana Mission in Washington, D.C., where preliminary findings have uncovered significant irregularities amounting to USD\$5.6 million. Officials reported that an IT staff member who had naturalised as a US citizen and was therefore ineligible to work within the Mission's IT system had created a fake platform mimicking the official government site, diverting visa applications to a personal website. This constituted a grave breach of internal controls.

The Committee noted that the Service sought and received authorisation from the Ministry of Foreign Affairs to engage forensic experts to support the investigation. The Committee commended the Audit Service for its vigilance and professionalism in detecting such irregularities and emphasised that this work provides a strong deterrent against mismanagement and financial impropriety in Ghana's overseas operations.

Recovery of Funds and Enforcement Actions

The Committee expressed concern that despite the extensive discussions arising from Public Accounts Committee (PAC) hearings and parliamentary debates, a persistent enforcement gap remains. Often, limited sanctions or recovery actions are taken following the identification of financial infractions.

In response, the Auditor-General highlighted recent efforts to strengthen enforcement mechanisms. He reported that through the Auditor-General's Recovery Account, which focuses primarily on unearned salaries, approximately GH¢51.376 billion has been recovered into the Consolidated Fund, including GH¢20.4 million recovered in the current year alone. Additionally, follow-up audits conducted between 2022 and 2024 have yielded a further GH¢12.7 billion in recoveries. The Auditor-General also noted that plans are underway to surcharge individuals responsible for financial losses—an intervention expected to serve as a strong deterrent and to reinforce the accountability framework.

The Committee commended the Audit Service for these remarkable recovery efforts and recommended that the Service be adequately resourced to sustain and expand its enforcement operations.

Audit Findings in the Road Sector and Unjustified Claims

The Committee examined reports concerning ongoing audits within the

road sector, particularly questions arising around the legitimacy of certain financial commitments and payments flagged by the Auditor-General. In response to enquiries, the Auditor-General confirmed that several claims submitted for payment were unsupported by requisite documentation. He cited a notable example involving Plan Visions Limited, where following audit queries, the company responded in writing acknowledging that it had not submitted any certificates or documentation for the claims referenced in the Auditor-General's publication of 3rd November 2025, and further stated that it had no knowledge of the amounts attributed to it.

The Committee commended the Auditor-General for uncovering such significant irregularities and underscored the importance of maintaining an independent and autonomous audit function, especially where findings may implicate individuals or entities across political lines. The Committee further noted that the Service's ability to detect such systemic weaknesses demonstrates the critical need for increased funding to strengthen its oversight role. It was also observed that in some jurisdictions, the Auditor-General holds a formal seat in Parliament, highlighting the centrality of the office in ensuring public accountability.

Resource Requirements to Enhance Audit Recoveries

The Committee observed that the Audit Service continues to face logistical constraints that impede its capacity to intensify nationwide recovery efforts.

The Auditor-General stated that the Service urgently requires additional vehicles and computers to support field operations and audit teams, noting that although 280 computers were procured in 2025, this remains insufficient to achieve the institutional policy of “one officer, one computer.” He explained that rapid depreciation of equipment, combined with increased operational demands, has deepened the need for sustained retooling.

In recognising the direct correlation between adequate resources and the Service’s ability to achieve higher levels of recoveries, the Committee considered the proposal that a percentage of recovered funds be allocated to the Service as an incentive-based support mechanism. The Committee therefore appeals to the Ministry of Finance to give favourable consideration to this proposal, as it would significantly enhance the operational efficiency and recovery capacity of the Service.

Outstanding Recruitment Approval and Staffing Constraints

The Committee noted persistent staffing constraints confronting the Service, particularly its request to recruit 390 new staff to operationalise 19 newly established offices across the country. The Auditor-General reported that these offices currently lack essential support staff such as cleaners, drivers, and security officers, due to the absence of financial clearance from the Minister for Finance. This has resulted in service delivery challenges and inefficiencies at the local level.

Additionally, the Auditor-General indicated that the Service’s request to replace 150 staff who had exited remains outstanding, further constraining human resource capacity. Recognising the indispensability of adequate staffing to the Service’s nationwide audit operations, the Committee urges the Minister for Finance to expedite the issuance of financial clearance for both the recruitment of new staff and the replacement of separated personnel. These measures are essential to ensuring uninterrupted audit coverage and the effective delivery of the Service’s constitutional mandate.

Status of KfW Donor Partner Support

The Committee reviewed the status of the KfW German donor support programme, which was approved by Parliament in 2016 with a funding allocation of €13.5 million for the construction of 25 new offices for the Audit Service. Due to project delays and inflationary cost increases, only 19 offices comprising 3 regional offices and 16 district offices were completed.

Following renewed efforts by the Audit Service to revive the stalled components of the programme, KfW expressed confidence in the Service’s commitment and indicated its readiness to provide an additional €11.5 million to support the construction of 6 offices in newly created regions and 6 additional district offices. However, the release of these funds remains delayed due to IMF conditionalities, which require the project to be placed on the Government’s priority list.

The Committee therefore recommends that the Minister for Finance accord the project the requisite priority in order to facilitate the timely release of the additional funding and ensure the continuation and completion of this critical infrastructure programme.

Policy Concerns on Ghana's Asset Declaration Regime

The Committee raised concerns regarding the effectiveness of Ghana's current Asset and Liabilities Declaration regime, noting criticisms from the IMF and other development partners describing the framework as incomplete and ineffective. In particular, it was highlighted that declarations can only be accessed by court order, which limits their utility as a preventive or investigative tool in combating corruption.

The Auditor-General concurred with these concerns, explaining that auditors are unable to verify the accuracy of submitted declarations due to legal restrictions, rendering the system largely unproductive in practice. Additional concerns were raised about the differentiation between assets held by public officers and those held by their spouses and children, who are not covered under the current regime.

The Auditor-General proposed the introduction of lifestyle audits as a supplementary mechanism to detect unexplained changes in the financial status or lifestyle of public officials. While the Committee agreed in principle, it cautioned that such audits

must be applied fairly and judiciously to avoid mischaracterising legitimate income from non-public sources.

The Committee acknowledged that meaningful reform of the Asset Declaration regime will require both constitutional amendment and complementary legislation, particularly in addressing unexplained wealth, and encouraged the commencement of broader national dialogue on strengthening integrity systems.

Furthermore, the Committee wishes to place on record that prior to the issuance of the directive requiring Committees to invite relevant stakeholders to meetings with MDAs for the consideration of their 2026 Annual Budget Estimates, it had already met with officials of the Audit Service and concluded deliberations on their Estimates. The Committee, however, acknowledges the import of the directive and affirms its commitment to fully comply with this requirement in all future engagements.

Conclusion and Recommendation

The Committee, having diligently and thoroughly examined the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ghana Audit Service for the 2026 Financial Year, is satisfied that the proposed allocations are appropriate, justified, and necessary for supporting the full implementation of the Service's programmes and for sustaining its operational effectiveness. The Committee underscores that timely and adequate financing of the Audit Service remains indispensable to strengthening public sector compliance, enhancing

accountability mechanisms, and ensuring value for money in the utilisation of public resources.

The Committee further notes that the expanding audit responsibilities of the Service combined with emerging governance challenges and the growing complexity of public financial management require consistent and predictable budgetary support to safeguard the integrity of the national oversight architecture.

Accordingly, the Committee recommends to the House the adoption of this Report and the approval of the sum of nine hundred and seven million, nine hundred and twenty-four thousand, three hundred and forty-nine Ghana Cedis (GH¢907,924,349.00), to enable the Ghana Audit Service to effectively execute its planned activities and deliver on its constitutional and statutory responsibilities during the 2026 Financial Year.

Respectfully submitted.

But having said that, may I call your attention to the very important function of the Audit Service, which function seeks to enhance transparency in our governance system, and also promote accountability in the use of financial resources of this country. Mr Speaker, among the many functions the Audit Service undertook in the year 2025, I reckon that we ought to applaud the Service that, in spite of the fact that they did not get the full allocation and release of their 2025 budget, they made very good use of what was given them and executed over 1,000 audit activities of

our Ministry Departments and Agencies for the year, 2025. Again, they were able to audit all 261 Metropolitan, Municipal, and District Assemblies (MMDAs) of our country. Of interest was also their quest to audit even our traditional authorities. About 100 traditional councils were audited in the year. For the current year, we acknowledge that their goods and services will be key the execution of the many activities planned for the ensuing year. I want to encourage the Ministry to release enough funds for them to undertake their activities.

I so submit, Mr Speaker.

Question proposed.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved:

That this honourable House approves the sum of GH¢907,924,349.00 for the services of the Audit Service for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, with your indulgence, if we can take Motion numbered 28, that is the estimates for the Electoral Commission.

3:55 p.m.

ELECTORAL COMMISSION

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That this honourable House approves the sum of GH¢203,569,245.00 for the services of the Electoral Commission (EC) for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Isaac Ashai Odamtten *on behalf of the Chairman of the Committee:* Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion, and in so doing, I present your Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies' Report. I invite the *Hansard* to capture the entire Report as though it was read in its entirety.

Introduction

The Hon Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Forson, presented the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2026 financial year to Parliament on Thursday, 13th November, 2025. This presentation was made in accordance with Article 179 of the 1992 Constitution of Ghana and section 21(3) of the Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921).

In line with Order 254 (2) of the Standing Orders of the House, the Rt Hon Speaker referred the Annual Budget Estimates of the Electoral Commission to the Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies for consideration and report to the House.

The Committee expresses its gratitude to the Deputy Commissioner, Dr Eric Bossman Asare; Ag Head of Finance, Mr Emmanuel Oteng; Budget Officer, Mr Edgar Mensah Gyawu; and officials from the Ministry of Finance for attending and supporting during the Committee's deliberations on Wednesday, 26th November, 2025.

Reference Documents

The Committee referred to the following documents during the deliberation on the estimates:

- a. The 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana;
- b. The Standing Orders of the Parliament of Ghana;
- c. The Public Financial Management Act, 2016, (Act 921);
- d. The Electoral Commission Act, 1993 (Act 451);
- e. The Political Parties Act 2000 (Act 574);
- f. The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2025 and 2026 Financial Years;
- g. Report of the Special Budget Committee on the Annual Estimates of the Electoral Commission for the 2025 financial year; and
- h. The Medium-Term Expenditure Framework (MTEF) for 2025 - 2028.

Mandate of the Commission

The Electoral Commission is tasked with managing all public elections and referenda, as well as overseeing all matters directly related to the conduct of elections in the country.

Core Functions of the Commission

The Electoral Commission, under Article 45 of the 1992 Constitution and section 2 of the Electoral Commission

Act, 1993 (Act 451), is mandated to perform the following core functions, among others:

- a. Compile the register of voters and revise it at such periods, as may be determined by law;
- b. Demarcate electoral boundaries for both national and local government elections;
- c. Conduct and supervise all public elections and referenda;
- d. Educate the people on the electoral process and its purpose;
- e. Undertake programmes for expansion of the registration of voters;
- f. Properly store election materials; and

- g. Perform such other functions as may be prescribed by law.

Review of 2025 Performance

In year 2025, the Electoral Commission was allocated an amount of GH¢177,647,046.00 for its programmes and activities. The allocation comprised a Government of Ghana contribution of GH¢177,379,225.00 constituting 99.85 per cent and Internally Generated Funds (IGF) component of GH¢267,820.50 representing 0.15 per cent.

As at November, 2025, the Commission had spent a total amount of GH¢131,784,672.33, constituting 74.18 per cent of the approved budget. The spending covered key operational activities and programmes to enable the Commission deliver on its mandate.

The breakdown of the allocation and expenditure is provided in Table 1:

Table 1. 2025 Allocation and Releases

EXPENDITURE ITEM	APPROVED BUDGET GH¢ (A)	AMOUNT RELEASED GH¢ (B)	ACTUAL PAYMENT C	VARIANCE GH¢ (A-B) (D)	% VARIANCE
Compensation	101,000,003	83,289,777.26	83,289,777.26	17,710,225.74	82.5
Goods and Services	73,993,364	48,494,895.07	44,689,152.64	25,498,468.93	65.8
Assets	2,653,679	0	0	2,653,679.00	9
Total	177,647,046.00	131,784,672.33	127,978,929.50	45,862,373.67	74.18

Source: Electoral Commission's 2026 Programme Based Budget Estimates and Presentation

During the year under review, the Commission achieved the following, among others:

- i. Conducted Council Akwatia By-elections.
- ii. Conducted elections for the confirmation of Metropolitan, Municipal and District Chief Executives.
- iii. Conducted District Level Elections for Nkoranza North and other Electoral areas.
- iv. Undertook media dialogue through the “Let the Citizen Know” Platform.
- v. Engaged regularly with key stakeholders including Civil Society Organisations, Peace Council, Council of State, Security Agencies, and the Religious Bodies.
- vi. Conducted promotional interviews for eligible staff.
- vii. Built the capacity of permanent staff.
- viii. Conducted a re-run of the Ablekuma North Parliamentary Elections.

Outlook for 2026

The Electoral Commission, in year 2026, will undertake the following programmes and activities among others:

Repairs and Maintenance of Vehicle and Equipment.

Conduct elections to fill vacancies in Electoral Areas.

Build capacity of Staff.

Procure IT support services.

Review audited financial reports of the political parties.

Conduct District Assembly Bye-Elections.

Recruit and Train staff.

Undertake Voter Registration and Exhibition.

Budgetary allocation for the year 2026

For year 2026, the Electoral Commission has been allocated an amount of Two Hundred and Three Million, Five Hundred and Sixty-Nine Thousand, Two Hundred and Forty-Five Ghana Cedis (GH¢ 203,569,245.00).

The breakdown of the allocation by source of funding and expenditure item is captured in Table 2.

Table 2. Breakdown of 2026 Budgetary Allocation by Source of Funding and Expenditure Item

ITEM	GOG GH¢	IGF GH¢	TOTAL	% ALLOCATION
Compensation	111,914,522.00	-	111,914,522.00	54.98
Goods and Services	83,725,544.00	275,500.00	84,001,044.00	41.26
CAPEX	7,653,679.00	-	2,653,679.00	3.76
Total	203,293,745.00	275,500.00	203,569,245.00	100
%	99.86	0.14	100	

SOURCE: Electoral Commission's 2026 Programme Based Budget Estimates and Presentation

Table 2 indicates that an amount of GH¢111,914,522.00 representing 54.98 per cent of the total budgetary allocation, has been dedicated for Compensation, while a total of GH¢83,725,544.00 constituting 41.26 per cent of the allocation will be committed to Goods and Services. An amount of GH¢2,653,679.00 representing 3.76 per cent of the total allocation, has been earmarked for Capital Expenditure. It is important to note that 99.86 per cent of the total allocation is sourced from the GOG, with 0.14 per cent coming from IGF.

Observations and Recommendations

The Committee made the following observations and recommendations during its deliberations:

Non release of CAPEX

The Committee observed that the Commission was allocated GH¢2,653,398.10, representing 9 per cent of the 2025 Budget, for capital

expenditure. However, as of the day of the hearing, no funds had been released. The Commission explained that the delay was due to its engagement of AESL to assess the buildings scheduled for renovation and prepare the Bill of Quantities, a necessary step to initiate access to the allocated funds.

The Committee urged the Commission to expedite this process to enable timely access to the funds. It further recommended that the Ministry of Finance ensure the release of the funds so that planned renovation projects can proceed without further delay to enable the Commission safeguard the dilapidated buildings from potential collapse.

Outstanding Compensation Relating to Rent and Fuel Allowances

The Committee noted that GH¢13,332,398.00, approved for rent and fuel allowances for 2025 staff, has not yet been released to the Commission. The Commission informed the

Committee that it has formally written to the Ministry of Finance requesting the release and is awaiting a response.

The Committee expressed concern over the prolonged delay, especially as these allowances form part of staff's approved compensation, by the Fair Wages and Salaries Commission. The Committee therefore urged the Ministry to expedite the release to enable timely payment and prevent further hardship among affected staff.

Additional Budget Support

The Committee was informed that the Commission will require an additional budget of GH¢208,522,291.32 in 2026 to undertake voter registration and exhibition exercises. The Commission explained that the upcoming registration will include new voters aged 18 years and above, a measure aimed at reducing the last-minute rush that typically leads to overcrowded centres, tension among political parties, and avoidable public anxiety.

The Committee recognises this exercise as critical to ensuring that every citizen who turns age 18 is duly registered and able to exercise their constitutional right to vote. While acknowledging the importance and scale of the exercise, the Committee recommended that the Electoral Commission considers adopting a more regular and decentralised voter registration system, such as opening registration centres in all polling centres or district offices on a monthly basis, similar to practices in other jurisdictions.

The Committee noted that this approach could help ease pressure on major registration periods and may prove more cost-efficient compared to the current event-based model.

The Committee further expressed the view that, despite the high financial requirement, the Ministry of Finance should make the necessary funds available to enable the Commission to carry out this national exercise. At the same time, the Committee encouraged the Commission to examine the proposed monthly registration option as a long-term strategy to help manage and reduce costs in future electoral cycles.

Internally Generated Funds (IGF)

The Committee observed that although the Commission's primary source of funding remains Government of Ghana budgetary allocation, there has been a noticeable increase in its Internally Generated Funds, rising from 0.15 per cent to 0.59 per cent. The Commission explained that these internally generated funds were accrued mainly through accreditation fees, filing fees, and ID card replacement fees. However, the Commission clarified that filing fees collected during elections are refunded to political parties and eligible candidates, and are not retained for internal use.

The Commission further informed the Committee that a total of GH¢8.7 million has been deposited into a dedicated Bank of Ghana refund account for filing fee reimbursements. Although the EC serves as a joint signatory on the

account, it emphasised that it cannot access or disburse the funds without approval from the Ministry of Finance.

The EC also noted the urgency of gaining access to enable refunds to be made to eligible candidates from the 2024 General Elections. It stated that eligible refund thresholds include parliamentary candidates who secured 12.5 per cent or more of valid votes, and presidential candidates who obtained 25 per cent or more. The Commission disclosed that the total refund liability is approximately GH¢5.7 million.

The Committee acknowledged the concern and urged the Ministry to grant the needed approval within reasonable time to avoid further delays in candidate reimbursements.

Outstanding Commitments

The Committee was informed of an outstanding payment of GH¢10,160,793.01 to Toyota Ghana for the supply of 15 Toyota Highlander vehicles that were used by District Officers during the 2024 General Election. The Commission explained that delays in the release of funds to settle the debt have resulted in Toyota Ghana repossessing two of the vehicles as a means of pressing for payment.

The Committee expressed concern about the development and the operational risk it poses to the Commission. The Committee therefore urged the Ministry of Finance to release the required funds and fulfil its financial obligations to the Commission to enable

the debt to be settled without further disruption.

Projections for By-Elections

The Committee raised concerns over the Electoral Commission's inability to include by-elections in its post-general election budget planning. The Commission explained that traditionally, by-elections are not formally budgeted for but are usually funded by the Ministry of Finance from the contingency fund when they happen.

The Committee disagreed, emphasising that by-elections are predictable electoral contingencies and should be included in expenditure projections to ensure adequate financial planning. The Commission responded that while preparations are made internally, by-elections are excluded from formal budgets to avoid potential political interpretations.

The Committee urged the Commission to revise its approach and incorporate by-election projections in future budgets.

Conclusion

The Committee has carefully reviewed the Electoral Commission's 2026 budget estimates and is confident that the proposed policies and programmes will effectively support the Commission in fulfilling its mandate.

The Committee recommends that the House adopts this Report and approves the total allocation of two hundred and three million, five hundred and sixty-

nine thousand, two hundred and forty-five Ghana cedis (GH¢ 203,569,245.00) to enable the Commission implement its planned programmes and activities for the 2026 fiscal year.

May I highlight a few of the issues that came up. We all know that in this country, the Electoral Commission plays a pivotal role in sustaining our democratic pathway. So far, we would say they have done so well. For the 2025 allocations, it has been clear that your Committee, led by the Hon Majority Leader, has supported the cause for the Commission to get the needed resources to operate and to function effectively.

In 2025, we noted that an allocation was made in 2024, which was not released, impacted their performance negatively. But because the Committee has supported their work, they got some releases with an outstanding amount of about GH¢20.3 million of which currently, they have received about GH¢6 million. Mr Speaker, we would want the Ministry of Finance to really look into the allocations of constitutional bodies. We want to ensure that for institutions that are a creation of the Constitution, their allocations must be of concern to all of us, so that the reason for which the Constitution established them will not be lost on us.

So, for the outstanding amount of about GH¢14 million against 2024, we are told that they have been embarrassed by Toyota Ghana for vehicles that they procured in 2024 for their rounds during the election. They have not been able to

pay for those vehicles, so Toyota Ghana has been on them. We call on the Ministry of Finance to deal with this matter expeditiously.

This year, the outlook for the Electoral Commission emphasises their mandate. We believe that if this House approves the requested amount, it will help them to execute their mandate. I call attention to their claim that there are few accounts that hold their money. We are told that for parliamentary and presidential elections, the fees that we pay are escrowed into an account, and it is said that for parliamentary candidates who are able to secure about 12.5 per cent of the votes, they qualify for a refund of their fees, and for presidential—So, we want to encourage the Ministry to make available those funds for the EC to be able to utilise under their internally generated funds.

In conclusion, the Committee has carefully reviewed the Electoral Commission's 2026 budget estimates and is confident that the proposed policies and programmes will effectively support the Commission in fulfilling its mandate. The Committee recommends that the House adopts this Report and approve the total allocation of GH¢203,569,245 to enable the Commission to implement its planned programmes and activities for the 2026 fiscal year.

Question proposed.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Before I will invite anybody for comment, the Rt Hon Speaker will assume the chair.

4.01 p.m. —

[THE SPEAKER, RT HON ALBAN SUMANA KINGSFORD BAGBIN, IN THE CHAIR]

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, I have just been briefed that you are on the Motion numbered 28, and that the Motion has been moved and has been seconded for the consideration of the House. Yes, Majority Leader?

4:05 p.m.

Mr Ayariga: That is so, and I was on my feet when the Second Deputy Speaker announced that you were assuming the Chair.

Mr Speaker, I was on my feet to comment and support the Motion moved by myself and seconded by the Member for Tema East. Mr Speaker, essentially, he had given all the figures, but I just want to make one comment. He made a comment, but I just want to reinforce it.

Mr Speaker, if you would realise, over the years, we did not make provision for a special committee of Parliament to oversee the affairs of Independent Constitutional Bodies. The 1992 Constitution has indicated that it intends that the Independent Constitutional Bodies should be insulated from all manner of control. And, in relation to the Electoral Commission (EC), let me, for instance, read Article 46 of the 1992 Constitution. It states:

“Except as provided in this Constitution or in any other law not

inconsistent with this Constitution, in the performance of its functions, the Electoral Commission, shall not be subject to the direction or control of any person or authority.”

Mr Speaker, we know that financial instruments and budgetary allocation could be a very subtle medium of control. And this provision is similarly provided in relation to all the Independent Constitutional Bodies, that is, the National Media Commission and the Commission on Human Rights and Administrative Justice. And so, if we do not devise a mechanism for dealing with budgeting for these Independent Constitutional Bodies, we may say that the 1992 Constitution insulates them from control, but the Executive arm of government will use financial provisioning as a tool for control.

So, Mr Speaker, it is my proposal as Chairperson of that Committee that this House must develop a mechanism for determining budgetary allocation to these institutions. Instead of the leadership of these institutions engaging directly with the Ministry of Finance, where they are given ceilings by the Ministry of Finance, and given their weaker political weight, they have difficulty pushing to get what they actually need to perform their constitutional roles. It is my view that going forward, this Parliament should be the institution that interfaces between these Independent Constitutional Bodies and the Ministry of Finance in the determination of what should go to these Independent Constitutional Bodies.

At the time of designing our 1992 Constitution, the institutions that the framers expressly thought to insulate by way of protecting the processes of budgeting for them have been Parliament itself and the Judiciary, where there is a mechanism that sorts of protects the Judiciary, for instance, in terms of determining their budget. But for the other Independent Constitutional Bodies, even though the same mechanism of non-control which the 1992 Constitution provides in relation to the Judiciary is also provided for in relation to these Independent Constitutional Bodies, the 1992 Constitution did not go further to provide a mechanism for budgeting for them which actualises the desire of the framers to have these Bodies to be really independent and not subject to any form of control.

Mr Speaker, whilst I support the Motion and urge that we approve it, going forward, for all the Independent Constitutional Bodies, we may want to make provisions in our Standing Orders that require them to bring their proposals to Parliament. We consider their proposals, and if we deem it fit that these Independent Constitutional Bodies should be given those sums that they require to do their work, or why not? We should then make that presentation to the Ministry of Finance for consideration and for them to capture it in the budget estimates that will be brought to Parliament.

As it is now, they are invited to the Ministry of Finance, they are given a ceiling, and they cannot negotiate their way out. Every year, when they come,

they complain about inadequate provisioning, and even what has been approved, a lot of it is not released to them. So, increasingly, we find these pillars of democracy not functioning to the extent that we want them to function and undermining our democracy. It is the same with the Commission on Human Rights and Administrative Justice (CHRAJ), the Audit Service, and National Media Commission. Now, we see new media, and we see the abuse of new media, and the National Media Commission is weak, and therefore cannot protect the citizenry against the abuses that we see in the new media. It is all because of the weak budgetary allocation that they have suffered over the years.

So, this House must find a mechanism to protect these Independent Constitutional Bodies in the process of budgeting for them, and to ensure that we negotiate and get proper budgetary allocations for the independent constitutional body. I thought to draw attention to this, I think it is a constitutional weakness, and in the future, the Constitutional Review Commission should take it on board. Even as we are waiting for the outcome of the work of the Constitutional Review Commission, I think that as a Parliament, we can provide for it in the Standing Orders of Parliament, because the 1992 Constitution says that the mechanism by which the Appropriation Bill should be approved should be determined by us. So, we can put in our Standing Orders provisions that make special arrangements for the consideration of the budget of Independent Constitutional

Bodies, to actualise the desire of the 1992 Constitution that these Bodies should indeed be insulated from all manner of executive control.

On that note, Mr Speaker, I thank the seconder of the Motion and urge Colleagues to approve the sum of GH¢203,569,245.00 for the services of the Electoral Commission for the year ended 31st December, 2026.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Samuel A. Jinapor (NPP — Damongo): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I rise to support the Motion requesting the amount as stated for the Electoral Commission, and to associate myself with the sentiments expressed by the Majority Leader and to say that budgeting and allocation of public funds historically and contemporarily has been a major tool of control.

Mr Speaker, if I may stretch it even further, this House, Parliament itself, I should say, not only the Independent Constitutional Bodies of our state, are susceptible to the use of budgeting, as a tool of control. Even Parliament and the budgeting process we have in our country, which means that literally all institutions and organs of state are subject to, more or less, the discretion of the Ministry of Finance and, for that matter, the Executive and Government, continues to be a major avenue and lever of control of institutions that are required to be independent and assertive.

4:15 p.m.

Mr Speaker, in the Congress of the United States, the experts will say that their source of strength is because of their control of the budgeting process, their capacity and mandates, pursuant to the Budget Act of 1921, which gives them the mandate to literally determine the contours of budgeting and are able to increase or reduce whatever allocation the Treasury presents to the Congress. So, it is important. And I think that we have also had a history in our country, sometime in 2004, when issues of even procurement by the Electoral Commission became a subject matter of intense public discussion *vis-a-vis* whether the attempt of the Executive to interfere in the procurement processes of the Electoral Commission will constitute a compromise of the independence of the Electoral Commission as enshrined in the Constitution of our country.

And so, Mr Speaker, it is all well that this amount is being allocated to the Electoral Commission, and I see that it is an increment in the allocation for 2026 over that of 2025. But that said, the point the Hon Majority Leader has made is one that I believe the House should pay particular attention to, not only in respect of Independent Constitutional Bodies, but the general budgeting framework of our country, even as it relates to a very important arm of government such as the Legislature, Parliament, and ensure that we have a system which makes these bodies which are meant to be independent, truly independent.

Mr Speaker, with this, I support the Motion for the request of the said amount for the Electoral Commission of Ghana. Thank you.

The Speaker: May I be guided by Leadership as to the agreement on contributions by Members? There is no agreement? Very well.

Yes, Prof Nyarko?

Prof Kingsley Nyarko (NPP — Kwadaso): Mr Speaker, I thank you for that space given me to contribute to the Motion numbered 28.

Mr Speaker, I partly share the frustration of the Leader of the House regarding the allocations given to the Independent Constitutional Bodies. I used to be on the Special Budget Committee and I know the challenges. I think that we need to tread cautiously because if the challenge of inadequate budgetary allocations to Independent Constitutional Bodies is distinct from what is given to the Ministries, Departments, and Agencies, then I will be worried. What I have seen over the years is that the budgetary allocations are not even fully provided by the Ministry of Finance. What we should be doing is to ensure that the Ministry of Finance, seeing the critical, crucial and relevant roles these institutions play, ensures that they are given adequate resources for them to embark upon their work more effectively and efficiently.

On that score, I also saw from the Report, the item numbered (e), Outstanding Commitment, that EC was

owing Toyota Ghana a sum of over GH¢10 million. Due to that, two of their vehicles were repossessed by the company. I see this to be a worrying signal. I want to urge the Ministry of Finance that some of these commitments that are obligatory be honoured. Otherwise, it puts some form of a dent on the reputation of this country. I will want to agree with the Hon Member for Tema East that as a matter of urgency, these moneys be provided so that the vehicles can be gotten back for the EC to beef up the work that they do.

On that score, I also want to support the Motion that the sum of GH¢203,569,245.00 be appropriated for the Electoral Commission. Thank you, Mr Speaker, for indulging me.

The Speaker: Hon Members, I think this is an important issue that has been raised. I listened to the debate earlier in the day, and this issue came up many times, and I think that it is important because we are doing a constitutional review for us to emphasise the point that has been made by the Hon Majority Leader.

It is because of that, if you go through our Standing Orders, we have provided for a Budget Committee. And when you go to Order 235, it says:

- (1) “The Budget Committee comprises a Chairperson, a Ranking Member, a Vice Chairperson, a Deputy Ranking Member, and not more than 13 other members.
- (2) The Budget Committee shall collaborate with the Ministry for Finance and the Office of the

President in the initiation, formulation, and implementation of the national budget.

(3) The Budget Committee shall:

(a) consider and report to the House on

- (i) the Medium Term Expenditure Framework and the broad Medium Term Policy Target;
- (ii) an Appropriation Bill laid before Parliament; and
- (iii) a report laid in respect of Off-Budget Reporting or Expenditure in Advance of Appropriation;

(b) consider the annual budget and determine whether the annual budget gives effect to chapter six of the Constitution;”

And you know what Chapter 6 deals with, the Directive Principles of State Policy.

- (c) “analyse and report to the House the impact of tax waivers on the economy; and
- (d) perform any other function assigned by Parliament.”

And in doing so, clause 4 says:

(4) “The Budget Committee may request aspects in finance, public

financial management, economics, or any other related discipline to support memoranda, to submit memoranda, or provide any other assistance that the Committee may require in the performance of the assigned functions.”

And so, you have this main Committee, the Budget Committee, when it comes to matters concerning the budget. It is true that we need to clarify some of the Orders. As stated by the Hon Majority Leader, even when you are looking at the Standing Orders on Committee or Independent Constitutional Bodies, they are a bit general in nature. They should be more specific.

But this is a beginning worth carrying forward and signaling to the Constitutional Reforms Committee that this is the position. In fact, I just drew the attention of the Table to the effect that what we are doing now is to adopt the reports of the Committees. If you approve the reports now, then the Appropriation Bill will just capture what you have approved. So, Second Reading will be otiose because there will be no need for you to start debating the policies and principles again of what you have approved generally in the House. What we are doing now is to move Motions to adopt the reports of the Committee. When they are now captured in the Appropriation Bill, it will come before the House where you now debate and approve what has been captured there as the various items to be approved for the utilisation of the various MMDAs, the Constitutional Bodies, Parliament and the Judiciary.

But between adoption of the reports, at least you are giving some idea to the Executive if there is a need for reconsideration and for the elimination of some items from the Budget, that could be done before they are captured in the Appropriation Bill for the consideration of the House.

4:25 p.m.

I think we should start doing it this way until we get the new Constitution which will properly capture the sense of the House. So, I told the Clerks-at-the-Table that the Motions should have been differently worded. What you are doing now is adopting the Reports of the Committees. I have serious problems with them, and I have raised issues with the Hon Minister for Finance and His Excellency the President that we need to realign some of these amounts to the priority areas that will even allow the President to lead the reset that he mentioned. With the way things are going, I do not think that can lead us to reset because the agencies that anchor the national programmes, if not well resourced, you will not be able to change the existing framework, starting with the legal framework.

Parliament has to do a lot to change many of the laws that we have. If not, we will be caught by the existing law, and even though you have good intentions, legally, they will not be applicable, and until you amend the laws, you cannot implement the good ideas that you have. So, it means that Parliament has to work a lot. But what has been provided there for Parliament is woefully inadequate. It

is same for the Audit Service. Before I came in, I heard the House adopting and approving it. You would realise that in the Budget, there is a provision to establish a Value for Money Audit Department, and there is a Bill coming for us to do that; all these were being done by the Audit Service. So, if that is being done by the Audit Service, and you now think that there is a need to establish a specialised unit, they are all doing the same thing; that is, auditing. One may be doing performance audit, the other, management audit, and another, value for money audit: there are various types. But what is provided for the Audit Service now is so inadequate that they will not be able to do the work we are doing, particularly as we have gone down to the district assemblies level. You would realise that your Committees are being asked to now do audit work. The Committee on Local Government and Rural Development for example, has started sitting like a Public Accounts Committee. So, you need a lot of resources to be able to do this.

We cannot continue to budget the way we used to. This is a very important matter that we should carry on board and make sure that we support the Executive to realign the projections and the provisions they have made before this House. If not, let us forget about real democracy or true democracy, and we should stop deceiving ourselves.

There are some agencies, in fact, this morning, I heard you talking about one of them; that is the Office of the Special Prosecutor (OSP). If you would recall, during the deliberation on the OSP, a

number of us stated on the floor of this House that there was no constitutional basis, but we wanted to signal to the world that we were going to fight corruption. At the end of the day, we have seen the results. We cannot continue to allocate those huge sums to the same office when we are not getting the results.

This is one of the agencies we should be looking at. It is getting almost the same amount as the Attorney-General's Department. Let us hold the bull by the horns and make sure that the right thing is done.

So, I agree with the Hon Majority Leader, and as we go through this, the Hon Minister for Finance, I hope his representative is here. As for his Deputy, I always see him. It is the Hon Minister who comes in from time to time, but for his Deputy, he is always around.

I think the Hon Majority Leader will take note of it and apprise him of the discussions. I am happy that the House agreed that there will be either a Committee of the Whole or a Closed Sitting to look at some of these major things.

It is important to note that as a House, we cannot continue to be failing the good people of Ghana. If we do our work well, we will be able to curb corruption. We will be able to hold the Executive to account for its stewardship. Not only in terms of money, but in terms of the trust that the people repose in Leadership. In the meantime, we may have to change the wording of our Motions that we can

do in-house, then we adopt the Reports. When it comes to the Appropriation Bill, you have the opportunity to debate the policies and principles, and then come out with the approvals of the Estimates.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved:

That this honourable House approves the sum of GH¢203,569,245.00 for the services of the Electoral Commission (EC) for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we now move to the item numbered 29.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, even before we take the Motion, in your remarks, you raised the issue of the OSP, and some discussions that took place earlier in this House.

Mr Speaker, this House, as a body, needs to take a firm decision on the issue of the institution of the OSP and make sure that we take advantage and realign our constitution properly.

Yesterday, the Office arrested and detained a legal practitioner by the name Mr Martin Kpebu. It is obvious that the practitioner had publicly criticised the manner in which the Special Prosecutor was going about performing his functions. He was invited, and I am told that at the entrance to the OSP, he sought to address the media, which was objected to by the security detail at the Office.

There was some altercation between him and the security responsible for the building that houses the Special Prosecutor. Subsequently, it was ordered that he should be detained. It took the intervention of most Ghanaians on social media and people calling the Special Prosecutor and demanding that he release the legal practitioner —

The Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, the difficulty the House has is that this was extensively deliberated upon, led by your Majority Chief Whip, so it will be like we are repeating what was said.

Some Hon Members: For emphasis.

The Speaker: You want it for emphasis?

Some Hon Members: Yes.

4:35 p.m.

The Speaker: Well, if that is the sense of the House, I will grant him the opportunity because I have a few things to say about this matter. But, Majority Leader, they say for emphasis, you could go on.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I support the Majority Leader fully, in recanvassing the issues. He should do that with all diligence. We support him. Please proceed.

The Speaker: Hon Members, this matter is so endemic that it does not deal with any regime. Let us all be honest. It cuts across all the regimes and even goes

beyond the Constitutional Bodies or the Office of the Special Prosecutor (OSP). To a culture, even in the Ghana Police Service, the Military, and in fact, the security agencies. They think that when somebody is invited, the person is arrested. And the law is very clear on this matter. So please, let us not bring partisanship into it. Let us look at it as we have all experienced it over the years, and try to prescribe the way forward.

So, Majority Leader, you may go on.

Mr Ayariga: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the lawyer, Martin Kpebu, was subsequently released last night. But it raises fundamental issues about the very existence of that Office. I recall vividly in this Chamber when the proposal to establish the Office of the Special Prosecutor was presented, I opposed it. The *Hansard* will bear me out. I took a position that it was unconstitutional to strip the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice of the power to be responsible for the prosecution of criminal cases. There was a contrivance to align with the language of the Constitution by nuancing the processes for the appointment of the Special Prosecutor, to say that the actual special prosecutor is being nominated by the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice for approval by Parliament. So in that sense, the exercise of the prosecutorial powers is being done by the OSP with the authorisation of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice. It still did not make sense.

The fact that we had to struggle and nuance the whole process clearly betrays the fact that we knew we were doing something that did not sit well with our constitutional architecture. Mr Speaker, the Office has been in existence for how many years now? Close to eight years. Tell me what the real achievement of that Office is. What has been the achievement of that Office? I cannot see my way clear in terms of the achievement of that office. I have consistently held the position that fighting corruption is not about littering the place with institutions. It is the political commitment of those who lead, who fight against corruption. Not the designations of institutions that have been established.

I believe it is high time this Parliament reconsidered its decision to approve the establishment of the Office of Special Prosecutor. I honestly think that we should abolish it. Because we have experimented with it, and we cannot see any achievement. In major cases of clear corruption, to date, the Office has not been able to do anything. If the institution of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice that we established in our Constitution is adequately resourced, protected and held accountable by Parliament, I believe that the Office will equally deliver. If we look at the Cabinet, no office is expressly established by this Constitution apart from the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice. It is the only one that is actually a constitutional entity. So, it is an entity that this Parliament should ensure is resourced and protected so that it stands above ordinary ministries, and can ensure that criminality is dealt with in this country.

Look at the budgeting. If we agree that a prosecutor fighting corruption needs to be resourced, why have we not resourced the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice? Why do we establish an entity out of the functions of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice and resource it more than the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice? And even after doing that, it is still not delivering.

So Mr Speaker, yesterday, I did not see it, but I am told that your predecessor, the Rt Hon Mike Oquaye, who spoke on TV3, indeed recommended that this House abolish it. That we should use a Private Member's Bill to abolish it. Let me sound a warning that abolishing it will not let off the hook those who we are considering prosecuting for violations of the law when it comes to corruption. I can assure Members that abolishing the Office of Special Prosecutor will not let off anybody who is found culpable or has violated any of the laws of Ghana when it comes to financial accountability. Zacchaeus will not be let off the hook. I can assure Members.

So people should not see the call for the abolition of the Office of Special Prosecutor as an indication that those who are going to be held accountable will be let off the hook. Indeed, I will ensure that the process is expedited. But I am strongly of the conviction that the Office of Special Prosecutor should be abolished. Whether we are going to do it through a Private Member's Bill, as advised by the for Rt Hon Speaker, Prof Michael Oquaye or that we will call on

the Executive to expedite a Bill that we will consider and approve to abolish it. That is for us as a House to decide. But I think that it is high time we realise that the constitutional experiment is futile. To say that because the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice is appointed by the President and is a Member of a political party, he will not be functional or effective in fighting corruption. The OSP, is he coming from space? Who is nominating him? The same political process is going to generate the occupant of the Office of Special Prosecutor. So he will not be freed of that political pressure.

If we want to be serious about fighting corruption, let us do it. Political leadership at the highest level must lead. This Government has been in office for about 11 months now. Mr Speaker, we have not reported a single scandal; we have not reported a single scandal because of the political commitment to ensure accountability. *[Hear! Hear!]* And we are available. Show me any scandal, and we will take the person on.

Mr Speaker, political corruption is a function of political leadership. If political leadership is determined not to be corrupt, it will not be corrupt. And when they are corrupt, they will hold each other accountable. It is not about creating fanciful institutions and giving them fanciful names. We have seen it in big budgets with all sorts of perks. It has lived out, and it is not working. Let us go back to what the Constitution has ordained. Let us use the money we are giving to the Office of the Special Prosecutor to resource the Attorney-

General and Minister for Justice's Office. And I am sure that this particular Attorney-General and Minister for Justice will produce the kind of results that we expect of him. As it is now, there is some confusion in the system. Which corruption cases should the OSP handle? Which ones should the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice handle?

4:45 p.m.

Which corruption cases should the EOCO investigate and which ones should the OSP investigate? When there is a corruption case and one runs and then places its hands on it, then the other is clearly, disabled from dealing with it. Even if the one that has rushed first to take it is obviously not politically committed to fighting it. So there is clear confusion. Institutions obstructing each other. Powers blocking each other. I think that we should use this opportunity to streamline it. Let one person lead the fight against corruption as stipulated by this Constitution, that is the Attorney General and Minister for Justice. That is what is provided for in our Constitution.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.
[Hear! Hear!]

The Speaker: Hon Members, this is a very important matter but before we continue, let me acknowledge the presence of some distinguished guests, our colleagues, brothers and sisters from the Parliament of Liberia. We have four of them, led by Hon Prof Thomas Romeo Quioh. He is the head of the Delegation and is the Chairman of the Election and Inauguration Committee. Please, you are

most welcome. We also have Hon Ellen A. Attoh-Wreh who is the Chairperson for the Women's Legislative Caucus of Liberia. We have the Counsellor-at-Law, Rumses T. Kuwbuyal. He is a representative of the Law Reform Commission of Liberia, and then the Counsellor-at-Law, Ernesten Morgan, a representative from the National Electoral Commission.

On behalf of the Parliament of Ghana, I warmly welcome you to your own country, the Republic of Ghana, and I wish you all the best. Take time not only to learn, but also to feel the pulse of the life of Ghana. I was there not long ago when you had those crises. I am sure my good friend the Speaker now is managing, even though it is a difficult situation. A lot of our Members visit you almost every weekend. Some of them say that Liberia is their second home. So please, you are warmly welcome.

[The delegation from the Parliament of Liberia were acknowledged]

The Speaker: Let me listen to Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor on this matter before I come to the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs.

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor (NPP — Damongo): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity, as you rightly pointed out, to contribute to this very important subject. First of all, I think it is absolutely important that we point out that the intendment and the motivation behind the Akufo-Addo Government's efforts and decision to create this office was a noble one. I was

Deputy Chief of Staff at the time this office was created, and I was very much involved in the deliberations and discussions leading up to the establishment of the Office. The general intendment was really, as is captured by *Hansard*, to ensure that we had a dedicated office which was focused on fighting, unravelling, investigating, and punishing corruption. We will agree that in some jurisdictions, particularly in the American jurisdiction, the concept of Special Prosecutor is very common. In Africa, we have South Africa. I take the point the Hon Majority Leader made, and also to say that the legal question, in my view is not absolutely settled. If we look at Article 88 of our 1992 Constitution, particularly Article 88 (4), where all criminal prosecutorial powers, are vested in the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice. Today in our country, police prosecutors conduct criminal prosecutions. The EOCO conducts criminal prosecutions. Several institutions, Social Security and National Insurance Trust (SSNIT) and others, conduct criminal prosecutions. Therefore, the question which arises is whether or not the Office of the Special Prosecutor is exercising delegated prosecutorial powers. The answer to that, I think, is still at large, and I will leave it at that.

But in any event, Mr Speaker, it is this Parliament that enacted a law to establish the Office of Special Prosecutor. That said and by that, I say that I do not have, today, conclusive answers to the legal questions. They were deliberated upon. They may not have been grounded or they may have been grounded, but the intention and the

intendment of President Akufo-Addo and his Government is one that I believe we should celebrate, which is that he intended to set up an office dedicated to fighting corruption.

Mr Speaker, today, the question is, has the Office of Special Prosecutor eight or nine years down the road achieved results? Do they have any significant achievements when it comes to the fight against corruption? Those are matters before this House, those are matters before the country and those are matters that I believe the jury is out there. Has it been a successful office? Has it not? The question is still at large, and we all have a take on it.

Secondly, the Leader of Government Business, the Leader of this House, the Majority Leader, has had cause to rise up in this House to indicate that the Office of Special Prosecutor is not an office which is fit for purpose. He has even gone a step further. He has gone to the extent of indicating that the Office of Special Prosecutor is an unconstitutional body. That is exactly the point the Majority Leader is making, that the existence of the Office of Special Prosecutor is at variance with the provisions of our national Constitution. One year down the road, they build an office. They have a supermajority. What are they telling us?

Mr Speaker, this country, with the greatest of respect, is sick and tired of talk. The Leader of Government Business is not just the Majority Leader; he is a leader of Government Business. He is a Leader of this House. He sits in

Cabinet. He has indicated that when the Bill was tabled before this House, he, as Member of the 8th Parliament, he said he opposed the establishment of the Office of Special Prosecutor. He indicates that his party, the NDC, opposed the establishment of the Office of Special Prosecutor. I have just indicated the policy rationale or the policy motivation for the establishment of that office by the Akufo-Addo government. Mr Speaker has indicated that you were also opposed to it. Today, the political party that opposed the establishment of the office, the member of that political party who opposed it in the Eighth Parliament, today, Majority Leader, Leader of Government Business, in the wisdom of the Ghanaian people, they have given them a super majority. They have Majority in this House. They have a super majority. Why? What is happening? What is happening in our country?

Mr Speaker, you just made a point about allocation. They made a point about reset and the fact that we may struggle with the reset. Too much talking. The country needs action. If they believe the Office of Special Prosecutor is not fit for purpose, they have the majority, they call us micro-Minority, we are mighty Minority indeed, Repeal it! What are they waiting for? One year down the road, we are still being given sermons, lectures and being told that this office is unconstitutional.

Mr Speaker, with the greatest of respect, because one of their own was touched. Mr Speaker just made a point, not too long ago, that we should be

careful when we enact laws and when we apply the laws. When one is at the right-hand side of the Speaker and certain actions are being taken, many a times, we just tend to think that it will not affect us.

4:55 p.m.

Mr Speaker, needless to point out, that the history is there for us to appreciate that the law on causing financial loss to the state is only caught up with people or persons from the side which passed the law. Which is why the point the Rt Hon Speaker made is a very important. The law, when it is applied fairly, works for all of us, regardless of where we find ourselves.

Of course, Mr Martin Kpebu is somebody I know very well. Indeed, yesterday, when I heard the news that he had been arrested by the Office of the Special Prosecutor, I even attempted to reach out to him. But it should never be the case that when Wontumi is arrested and put behind bars, and told to bring bail conditions of GH¢100 million, and he stays in prison for two months, when we all know too well that basic teaching of Criminal Law tells us that bail should never be used as a form or a means of punishment, that one is all right.

When Mr Osei Assibey Antwi is still in custody today because he has been subjected to onerous unreasonable bail conditions which he cannot meet. He has been told to satisfy a bail condition of GH¢650 million. That one is fine. Bail should not be used as a tool of punishment, but we did not hear the Majority Leader. We have seen it in this

country several times; government changes, and then some of these measures are put in place and political opponents are put behind bars. When Paul Adom Otchere was arrested by the OSP, because allegedly, he had been critical of the office, and some of us raised our voices, the Majority Leader's voice and the Majority Side was mute. Because today, it is lawyer Martin Kpebu —

When the law is applied unfairly against Wontumi, Mr Osei Assibey, Mr Paul Adom Otchere or Mr Martin Kpebu, it is bad. We make good laws to the best of our ability for all of us, and we respect the law for all of us.

Mr Speaker, I want to conclude by indicating that what happened yesterday is a wake-up call to all of us, that when the law is applied unfairly against a citizen, it does not matter whether he is from the north or the south, whether he is NDC or an NPP member, let us insist. That is our only safeguard, that if Hon Mahama Ayariga is suspected to have committed an offence, he should be taken through due process and his rights should be respected. If it is Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, I should be taken through due process and my rights should be respected. That is the only way we can build a civilised and prosperous nation. It should not be the case that the Office of Special Prosecutor suddenly should be scrapped because Martin Kpebu has been taken through a raw deal.

Mr Speaker, I conclude with this quote by Martin Niemöller:

“First they came for the socialists, and I did not speak out—because I was not a socialist. Then they came for the trade unionists, and I did not speak out—because I was not a trade unionist. Then they came for the Jews, and I did not speak out—because I was not a Jew. Then they came for me—and there was no one left to speak for me.”

I thank the Majority Leader for the sentiments he has expressed, and Mr Speaker, I thank you too for the opportunity you have given and the sentiments you have expressed. Today, 4th December, the super-Majority should join us, we, the advocates of rule of law, the bastions of rule of law, the originators of rule of law, the promoters of rule of law, the doyens of rule of law to shake off their revolutionary tendencies a bit. They should shake it off and let the rule of law prevail. When it prevails, it prevails for Hon Mahama Ayariga, it prevails for Abdulai Jinapor and it prevails for all of us and the people of Ghana. [*Hear! Hear!*]

The Speaker: Hon Members, please, as leaders of the country, if we do not change our attitude, we will never achieve anything. That is the biggest problem. I do not think there is moral authority in this House to pontificate on this matter. Please, let us all start afresh. Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, I was expecting you to quote traditional wisdom, not from Germany—[*Laughter*]—because we have it here too. In our traditional norms and wise saying, we use three cattle. Are you aware? That used to fight the lion, and the lion was able to go in between them

and said, the red cow is telling you the black cow that it is because of its strength that they overpowered the lion. You know about that but you are not quoting that but you are quoting Germany because of the formal education. That has changed all of you from being Ghanaian.

You are talking about the rule of law. It started long before colonial rule, and you are quoting latter day saints. That is a challenge we have. But I do not want any family thing here, so I will give it to the Minister, that is why I said family. I do not want that fatherly respect here. I will allow the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. We just finished listening to Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor.

Mr Ahmed Ibrahim: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. Before I proceed to make some comments, let me thank Hon Mahama Ayariga, the Majority Leader of this House, for his consistent and principled position. I am saying this because not only him—I believe my Brother Samuel Abu Jinapor is young in this House, and was not here when we were passing the Office of the Special Prosecutor Act, 2017. He was not a Member of Parliament, and that was in the 7th Parliament. At that time, he was the Deputy Chief of Staff, so he was not present to listen to the critical issues and the superior argument that was made by the then 106 Minority Members in this House.

Hon Haruna Iddrisu, who was then the Minority Leader, Hon Mahama Ayariga, who was then the Chairperson

of the Subsidiary Legislation Committee of this House, before he became the Ranking Member of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs, and Mr Speaker, your good self-made extensive superior debate that we do not need the Special Prosecutor before we can fight corruption. The records are there between us and them, and the *modus operandi* are there.

5:05 p.m.

In 2015, when Ghana scored 48 out of 100, we did not have a special prosecutor, and that was under President Mahama. [*Hear! Hear!*] In 2014, when Ghana scored 47, we did not have a special prosecutor; yet President Mahama fought corruption. The Transparency International Corruption Perception Index (CPI) records are clear. Without a Special Prosecutor, the difference between you and us is clear.

Mr Speaker, in 2017, when we were 106 Members, they were 169 Members. So, the super Majority did not begin today. The distinguished Emeritus Professor Aaron Mike Oquaye sat in the Chair to supervise it. I know that if for nothing at all, Speakers of Parliament are independent. Even to unseat them, we need three-quarters of the Members. This is the most difficult thing to do. So, nobody tied his hands; he had 169 Members. We were here and raised every argument; they even started with an independent prosecutor, before they whitewashed it and arrived at a special prosecutor. The *Hansard* is there to bear us out. We said everything. [*Uproar*] I have said that between you and us, it is clear.

Mr Speaker, as a Second Deputy Speaker, you made a superior argument that the special prosecutor was not coming to serve any good purpose. I still remember. Mr Mahama Ayariga made a similar argument. We were perceived as if we did not want the Special Prosecutor, and we do not want to fight corruption. We said, “Do it and let us see”. How many of your Colleagues are there? Let us put that aside. Mr Speaker, even your presence in the Chair and your opening of Parliament to fight corruption alone, was able to help fight corruption more than the Special Prosecutor. If Parliament will do it work well, — when they had 169 Members, we were just here. Every law that came with every opposition we staged, they will tell you to put the Question, and that they had the numbers. That is what they did.

Mr Speaker, under your Leadership from the Eighth Parliament, you reduced Parliament to fighting corruption and making sure that the few eroded democratic dividend that was eroding was restored. That is how this Parliament became the most open Parliament in Africa. [*Hear! Hear!*]. Was that by a Special Prosecutor? No. Mr Speaker, is Prof Oquaye telling us today that when we were passing the law on the Office of the Special Prosecutor, he did not know what we were doing? He knew. So yesterday, I listened to him when he said we did not need that one and that he opened a Private Member’s Bill, so we could come up with a Private Member’s Bill to trash it up. Mr Speaker, I will even go for that. Before I get there, President Mahama will not come and say that he is bringing a law to take the Special

Prosecutor away. They have just started saying that we do not want to fight it. This House can come up with a Private Member's Bill and trash it out. That is the window opened to all of us.

Mr Speaker, from January to date, using Parliament and getting a strong political will for H. E. the President, how many political scandals have you gotten? How many corruption cases have we received? How many corruption scandals have we seen under President Mahama from January to date? We do not need a special prosecutor to fight corruption. All we need is to get an open Speaker seated in this Chair, opening Parliament to investigate every case. Because Mr Speaker, that is what you stood for. That is why we are achieving this

I am a Cabinet Minister, President Mahama has told all Cabinet Ministers, including all his Ministers, that anybody who commits any scandal will be fired. That alone has put a scare on all of us. Everybody is ruling with diligence. Everybody is ruling with a critical ethical governance principle, and he is always concerned about the future and this country.

So, Mr Speaker, we do not need a Special Prosecutor. When Mr Ayariga criticised the establishment of that office, he was the first victim. We do not have to personalise that state office to chase our critics. Mr Mahama Ayariga criticised the establishment of the Office of the Special Prosecutor, and he was the first victim. He was taken for buying an ambulance for his place. He was taken so

many times before a successor of the then Special Prosecutor and said that it was not a case of merit, and he won it. Mr Speaker, why was he put through all those ordeals when he did nothing wrong? Because he criticised the establishment of that Office.

In the same way, Lawyer Martin Kpebu also criticised the current Special Prosecutor and he is running after him with the entire Office of the Special Prosecutor. Mr Speaker, as I stand here talking, is it that we cannot criticise state offices? And should we use state offices to pursue our political or personal opponents who criticise us? Mr Speaker, as the longest-serving legislator in this country, how many times have you not been criticised? But you have opened up. With your experience, Parliament can help fight corruption. Most parliamentary committees such as the Committee on Local Government and Rural Development sit in open; the Public Accounts Committee sit in the open, and that alone can help fight corruption. What we need is a strong ethical leader like President Mahama with a strong corruption-fighting record, and those by Transparency International as the effective fighter of corruption in Ghana than any president. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, with Africa endorsing you as the most open Parliament and the most open Speaker because even with 188 or 189 MPs with a super Majority, what can you not use these numbers for? But you are still protecting divergent views and the concerns of the Minority to safeguard democracy. Mr Speaker, Ghana is blessed to have you. [*Hear!*]

Hear!] I was always worried seated here when Parliament was only interested in passing laws, but with you in the Chair, you changed everything. Parliament was just passing laws, and even in passing the laws, some could go to the Supreme Court and could be trashed. Today, the Speaker himself is saying that some of the laws are not needful. What were we doing when they had 169 Members? I can foresee that if the 189 Members for the Majority were under a certain regime, miracles would have happened. But thank God it is you and it is President Mahama on the seat. My Brother Samuel Abdulai Jinapor is not there.

5:15 p.m.

Mr Speaker, with the Special Prosecutor, the highest mark of President Akufo-Addo on the Corruption Perception Index is 43 over 100. It fluctuates between 40 and 43; he could not go beyond 43. The worst performance of President Mahama in fighting corruption was 43, and the highest was 48, the medium was 47. Our worst performance in fighting corruption was their highest mark. Between us, the records are clear. That is the records. What they could say was that, we have given this much budgetary allocation to the Office of the Special Prosecutor; we have given this much budgetary allocation to the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice. We have given more money to the corruption-fighting institutions, and what was their record?

So, Mr Speaker, on that note, I go by the proposal for the scrapping of the

Office of the Special Prosecutor and resourcing the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice. That is what we use and had the highest mark in fighting corruption. We do not create bureaucracies and think that we are fighting corruption. I have now seen clearly that in the corruption debate, in fighting corruption, we are far better than my Colleagues on the other Side. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

The Speaker: Hon Members, I think the message from the House is clear, and we are happy that we have senior Members outside the House and former Speakers, supporting this message. I will proceed, not to direct you, but to urge you on to do what is proper. If we all agree that it is serving no purpose, we know what to do as a House.

Secondly, I am grateful to the House because a delegation, which is being led by His Excellency the President, to a conference in Qatar, is called upon to sponsor a Motion for the whole world to take a position on fighting corruption. His Excellency the President will be there before we get there. After him, I may be leading the delegation at the conference, and we want to put this position of Ghana across to the whole world, as to the best way to fight corruption. I am happy that the House is giving us this signal. I will call upon my delegation to take copies of the *Hansard* as we move to the conference next week. We are grateful to you, and we will carry this message along.

This time around, the Constitutional Reforms Committee, led by Professor Prempeh, will do the proper thing to make sure that we capture all these concerns and we get a better Constitution, a more improved Constitution, than what we have implemented so far. The 1992 Constitution has done well, it has stabilised our democracy. It has taken us this far, but there is an urgent need to sharpen some of the tools, to restructure it for us to deliver what we all want. I thank you.

We have some very serious Business to transact, and I am prepared to be here for some time.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh — *rose* —

The Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, I am sorry, I want to curtail the discussion on this matter, because I have given enough space to both Sides to articulate their views. I think there is consensus on it. I do not want us to go back to it.

Yes?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I do not intend to take you back. I recall when we met at Conclave, the Leader of the House had nudged us that it is a subject matter he wanted to raise under Order 93. In his absence, the same matter was raised. Mr Speaker, because of your earlier direction, I do not intend to defy you at all.

The Hon Majority Chief Whip, if the House would bear me out, raised same matter. There was a bit of argument. I

thought that we should do a proper thing. From where I sit, it appears that it is just in the spur of the moment argument. If we could prepare and do a proper argument on this matter—Otherwise, it appears that we are rushing the matter. It is not with any disrespect to you. So probably we should engage more and come properly and have a proper debate on this subject matter.

The Speaker: Thank you so much. We just need direction, and that is the direction I have given. What you are talking about, the need for preparation, will definitely be done, so that we have enough legal basis and moral authority to refine the existing legislation, and even the practice and procedures of the House. So we did talk about all that. We will not just in the spur of the moment do a knee-jerk reaction and mess up the situation.

So, let us continue with the Business. We got to the item numbered 27, that was adopted. Now we are moving to—In fact, we even adopted the item numbered 28. We are now moving to the item numbered 29 when my attention was drawn that there are some other Businesses they want to speak about.

Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, instead of the item numbered 29, I want to pray you to move to the *Order Paper Addendum*, so we can take the Motion numbered 1.

The Speaker: Hon Members, I said that at this moment, what we are doing is to adopt the Reports of the Committee. I

am referring to the wordings of the Motions that you have on the *Order Papers*. I told the Clerks-at-the-Table to look at it, so that we do the approvals when we are debating the Appropriation Bill. I thought that was the position. Do we agree to that? So that when they are moving the Motion, they just amend it to “to adopt the Report of the Committee on the allocation of”.

Yes, Minority Frontbench. They want us to take the *Order Paper Addendum*, the Motion numbered 1.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we are aligned.

The Speaker: So, we may start with the Motion numbered 1, and that is in the name of the Minister for Education.

ANNUAL ESTIMATES, 2026

MINISTRY OF EDUCATION

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That this honourable House adopts the Report of the Committee on Education on the allocation of the sum of GH¢39,233,795,022.00 for the services of the Ministry of Education for the year ending 31st December 2026.

Mr Speaker, in doing so, I would like to highlight that Ghana’s educational system needs a reset, and a reset by way of investment in structures and in standards from kindergarten through

primary school, secondary education to higher education. A chunk of this amount is dedicated to compensation, because rightly and justifiably so, the Ghana Education Service has the largest workforce in Ghana. But Government is determined to reset basic education and to increase investment in foundational learning. We are currently reviewing the curriculum at that level to incorporate the teaching of ethics. More importantly, even this morning, His Excellency the President launched a STEM initiative, where we are emphasising investment in Science, Mathematics and Engineering education to support young people to develop critical minds and also be ready for problem solving.

5:25 p.m.

Mr Speaker, Parliament is approving this Budget at a time that the country is going through a very worrying development, with a significant number of Ghanaian students not performing well in the West African Senior School Certificate Examination (WASSCE). On this matter, I have requested for the examiners’ report for a thorough study and analysis, and as and when it is appropriate, I will come and brief this House as to what accounts for it.

So, Mr Speaker, I beg to move that the House approves GH¢39,233,795,022.00 for the services of the Ministry of Education.

I beg to move.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we are dealing with our rules of procedure. I

realised that what I introduced is accepted, but the wording is not yet refined. So, in such a situation where we are adopting the report of the Committee, it has to be moved by the Chair of the Committee, and then the Hon Minister will come in, but because it was not put on the *Order Paper*, the Hon Minister has moved it, and he says, if I may read it to your hearing:

“That this honourable House adopts the report of the Committee on Education on the allocation of the sum of GH¢39,233,795,022.00 for the services of the Ministry of Education for the year ending 31st December 2026.”

So, insert after “honourable House, “adopts the report of the Committee on Education on the allocation of” then you continue, with “the sum of ...” That will be the Motion, and that is how all the rest will have to be recouched. The Chairpersons of the Committees, or an Hon Member by our rules, could do so on behalf of the Chairman, and then the Hon Ministers will come in, and also contribute like other Members.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: We are grateful for your guidance. Consequently, it must apply, because I recall all the earlier actions we have taken, were at variance with your —

The Speaker: So, I will give the directives. After we have adopted this, then I will direct that it should have a consequential effect on all the Motions that have been adopted by the House, so that we can have space to properly debate

the Appropriation Bill, because you recall that it was a Statement, and with what you did, we said you were making comments. So, you actually did not get time to debate, even though there was much difficulty between the comments and the debates. We had a challenge with that, but in essence, what we said was that it was a Statement, and you were making comments. But you have to debate the policies and principles of the Budget, and there are new policies that have been introduced, which have to be debated and approved by the House, and the Executive will now go to implement what has been approved by the House; that is the way to go. In the meantime, the Hon Minister for Education has moved it. We will adopt that, and then, consequently, the others will be moved by the Chairpersons of the Committee.

So, the Chairman will now present the report and we would allow Hon Members to contribute.

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Peter Kwasi Nortsu-Kotoe): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to present the report of your Committee, the Committee on Education, on the 2026 Annual Estimates of the Ministry of Education.

Mr Speaker, before I present the report, I want to make a few corrections. Page 3, item 7.0, line 4, reading from “this amount” to the end, should be deleted from the report. Then, again, same on page 4, line 3, from “representing 99.8” to the end, should also be deleted from the report. Then, finally, on table 3 on the same page 4,

instead of “revised”, we should delete “revised” and insert “released.”

Mr Speaker, on Wednesday, 13th November, 2025, the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2026 financial year was presented to Parliament by the Hon Minister responsible for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson, in accordance with Article 179 of the Constitution of Ghana, 1992, Section 21(3) of the Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921) and Order 193 of the Standing Orders of Parliament.

In accordance with Orders 195(4) and 250 of the Standing Orders of the House, the Rt Hon Speaker referred the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Education to the Committee on Education for consideration and report.

Deliberations

The Committee convened on Tuesday, 2nd December, 2025, to review the Annual Estimates of the Ministry. Present were the Hon Minister for Education, Mr Haruna Iddrisu, his Deputy, Dr Clement Apaak, the Chief Director of the Ministry of Education, and representatives from the Ministry of Education and its Agencies, the Ministry of Finance and Civil Society Organisations (CSOs) who supported the Committee during the discussions.

The Committee extends its gratitude to the Hon Minister, the Deputy Minister, the Heads of the Agencies, officials from the Ministries of Education and Finance and CSOs for

their invaluable insights, contributions and support.

Reference Documents

The Committee referred to the following documents during the consideration of the estimates:

- i. The Constitution of Ghana, 1992
- ii. The Standing Orders of Parliament of Ghana
- iii. The 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana
- iv. The 2026 Programme-Based Budget (PPB) Estimates of the Ministry of Education
- v. The 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana
- vi. The 2025 Programme-Based Budget (PPB) Estimates of the Ministry of Education
- vii. The Report of the Committee on Education on the Annual Budget Estimates for the Ministry of Education for the 2025 financial year.

Goal of the Ministry

The goal of the Ministry of Education is to establish an educational system intended to produce well-balanced individuals with the requisite knowledge, skills, values, aptitudes, and

attitudes to become functional and productive citizens for the total development and democratic advancement of the nation.

Policy Objectives

The policy objectives of the Ministry of Education are as follows:

- Increase inclusive and equitable access to and participation in quality education at all levels;
- Strengthen School Management Systems; and
- Ensure sustainable sources of financing for education.

Core Functions

To achieve its objectives, the Ministry of Education performs the following core functions:

- Initiate and formulate policy options on education for the Government's consideration;
- Conduct research as necessary for the effective implementation of Government policies;
- Review Government policies and plans regarding education;
- Coordinate the implementation of sector policies and strategies; and
- Conduct periodic monitoring and evaluation of the education sector.

Implementing Agencies

The under-listed Agencies are responsible for the implementation of the programmes and activities of the Ministry of Education:

- i. Ghana Education Service (GES)
- ii. Ghana Tertiary Education Commission (GTEC)
- iii. Ghana TVET Service
- iv. Commission for Technical and Vocational Education and Training (CTVET)
- v. National Council for Curriculum and Assessment (NaCCA)
- vi. Ghana Library Authority (GhLA)
- vii. National Teaching Council (NTC)
- viii. West African Examinations Council (WAEC)
- ix. Ghana Book Development Council (GBDC)
- x. Centre for Distance Learning and Open Schooling (CENDLOS)
- xi. National Schools Inspectorate Authority (NaSIA)
- xii. Ghana Commission for UNESCO
- xiii. Complementary Education Agency (CEA)

xiv. Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund)

sixty-four thousand, three hundred and eighty-two Ghana cedis (GH¢31,772,464,382) was approved for the operations of the Ministry, its Departments and Agencies.

Financial Performance for the Year 2025

Total Approved Budget for 2025

In the year 2025, a total amount of thirty-one billion, seven hundred and seventy-two million, four hundred and

The breakdown of the allocation of the Ministry for the year 2025, by economic classification and sources of funding are provided in Tables 1 and 2.

Table 1: 2025 Budgetary Allocations by Cost Centres and Sources of Funding

ECONOMIC CLASSIFICATION	2025 APPROVED BUDGET (GH¢) SOURCE OF FUNDING			TOTAL (GH¢)
	GOG (GH¢)	IGF (GH¢)	Foreign Loans & Grants (FLG) (GH¢)	
COMPENSATION	27,149,518,449	803,161,825	-	27,952,680,274
GOODS & SERVICES	1,123,519,342	1,401,310,976	265,266,200	2,790,096,518
CAPEX	120,000,000	780,329,569	129,358,021	1,029,687,590
TOTAL (GH¢)	28,393,037,791	2,987,802,370	394,624,221	31,772,464,382

Source: 2025 Programme Based Budget Estimates for the Ministry of Education

Table 2: 2025 Revised Budgetary Allocations by Cost Centres and Sources of Funding

ECONOMIC CLASSIFICATION	2025 APPROVED BUDGET (GH¢) SOURCE OF FUNDING			TOTAL (GH¢)
	GOG (GH¢)	IGF (GH¢)	Foreign Loans & Grants (FLG) (GH¢)	
COMPENSATION	16,647,803,249	152,460,030	-	16,800,263,279
GOODS & SERVICES	414,314,577	1,789,091,744	98,533,855	2,307,508,440
CAPEX	12,000,000	10,658,848	-	22,658,848
TOTAL (GH¢)	17,074,117,826	1,952,210,622	98,533,855	19,130,430,567

Expenditure for 2025

The expenditure returns of the Ministry for the year 2025 as at October 2025 stood at *nineteen billion, ninety-seven million, nine hundred and fifty-four thousand, six hundred and thirty-two Ghana cedis (GH¢19,097,954,632)*

Table 3: Releases and Expenditure for the year 2025 as at October, 2025

ITEM	2025 APPROVED BUDGET (GH¢) (A)	2025 RELEASED BUDGET(GH ¢) (B)	ACTUAL EXPENDITU RE (GH¢) (C)	VARIANCE (B-C) (GH¢) (E)
COMPENSATION	27,952,680,274	16,800,263,279	16,799,062,604	1,200,675
<i>GoG</i>	27,149,518,449	16,647,803,249	16,647,803,249	-
<i>IGF</i>	803,161,825	152,460,030	151,259,355	1,200,675
GOODS AND SERVICES	2,790,096,518	2,307,580,440	2,288,233,180	19,347,260
<i>GoG</i>	1,123,519,342	414,314,577	410,420,896	3,893,681
<i>IGF</i>	1,401,310,976	1,789,091,744	1,779,278,429	9,813,315
<i>Foreign Loans and Grants</i>	265,266,200	104,174,119	98,533,855	5,640,264
CAPEX	1,029,687,590	22,658,848	10,658,848	12,000,000
<i>GOG</i>	120,000,000	12,000,000	-	12,000,000
<i>IGF</i>	780,329,569	10,658,848	10,658,848	-
<i>Foreign Loans and Grants</i>	129,358,021	-		-
Total	31,772,464,382	19,130,502,567	19,097,954,632 (99.83%)	32,547,935 (0.17%)

Source: Ministry's Presentation

2025 Programme Performance

Revitalising School Governance Structures

The Ministry of Education improved stakeholder involvement in the management of schools by ensuring that Parent Teacher Associations (PTA) were fully functioning in all pre-tertiary institutions. This step restored the involvement of parents as key players in the management of schools and fostered closer collaboration between the community

and school management. It is envisaged that this revived PTA activity will enhance accountability and help ensure that schools are more responsive and supportive.

Enhancing Professional Standards for Teachers

The National Teaching Council continued to work towards the professionalisation of teachers. In the period under review, the Council inducted newly qualified teachers and

renewed 137,695 licences for in-service teachers, bringing the total number of licensed teachers to 313,049. This rigorous licensing regime reinforces adherence to professional standards and promotes quality teaching.

It also ensured that the Ghana Teacher Licensure Examination (GTLE) was administered to a total of 42,538 candidates to ascertain whether aspiring teachers possess the necessary competencies to provide quality instruction.

Enhancing Education Quality Assurance

The National School Inspectorate Authority stepped up its quality assurance activities to improve accountability in pre-tertiary education. In particular, under the Ghana Accountability for Learning Outcomes Project (GALOP), the National Schools Inspectorate Authority (NaSIA) inspected 1,000 basic schools. These inspections provided data-driven insight to inform improvement at the school management level and promoted targeted interventions necessary for improved learning outcomes.

Expanding Literacy Outreach and Access

Literacy opportunities were extended to underserved communities by the Ghana Library Authority through 486 Mobile Library Van outreach activities. These provided books and reading resources to children in remote and deprived communities, thus helping to

nurture foundational literacy skills and engender a culture of reading.

Digital Content to Enhance Reading and Creative Writing

The Ghana Book Development Council implemented programmes aimed at developing the reading habit and creative writing among children, reaching 3,411 beneficiaries. The Council also produced and uploaded 15 educational videos onto digital platforms, thereby expanding access to reading and learning materials beyond the traditional classroom setting, in support of learners.

Basic Education Support, Equity Measures and Social Interventions

Reducing Financial Barriers to Access

To enhance equity in basic education, the Ministry continued major social intervention programmes such as the Capitation Grant, Feeding Grants for pupils in Special Schools, and payment of Basic Education Certificate Examination (BECE) registration fees for public Junior High School (JHS) candidates.

In 2025, the Ministry paid GH¢122.8 million to WAEC to cover the registration fees of BECE candidates from public schools numbering 471,586. In addition, funds for Capitation and Feeding Grants were released covering all three terms of the 2024/2025 academic year, while arrangements were being made for the 2025/2026 academic year.

Supporting Girls' Education and Wellbeing

The Government distributed 6,607,095 packs of sanitary pads to girls in public basic and senior high schools to address menstrual hygiene challenges and reduce absenteeism among female learners. Procurement of additional supplies for the 2025/2026 academic year commenced to sustain this gender equity intervention.

School Improvement Interventions under GALOP

Through the Ghana Accountability for Learning Outcomes Project (GALOP), a total of 10,579 low-performing basic schools received Learning Grants to enhance management at school level and improve teaching and learning outcomes. These grants support targeted interventions aimed at raising academic performance.

Expanding Basic Education Infrastructure

The Ministry completed 15 basic school infrastructure projects under Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund), Ghana Accountability for Learning Outcomes Project (GALOP) and the Arab Bank for Economic Development (BADEA). These investments help reduce congestion in classrooms, leading to expanded access to quality learning facilities, especially in underserved communities.

Improving Access and Infrastructure for Secondary Education

Ensuring Sustainability of the Free SHS Programme

In an attempt to ensure a sustainable funding for the Free Senior High School (SHS) policy and the Ghana Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) programmes, the Government uncapped the Ghana Education Trust Fund in 2025. This ensured stable financing for the effective implementation of the Free SHS programme in the 2024/2025 academic year.

The total number of students placed in senior high schools, senior high technical schools, and STEM schools under the Computerised School Selection and Placement System who would benefit from these programs are 511,100 for the 2025/2026 academic year.

Scaling Up Access through Private SHS Participation

To ease the pressure on the public SHSs and pave the way for a gradual phasing out of the double-track system, the Ministry piloted the expansion of the Free SHS policy to 70 private senior high schools. This expands opportunities while leveraging private sector contributions to national education delivery.

Infrastructure Expansion for Senior High Schools

In 2025, the Ministry completed and handed over 10 senior high school infrastructure projects funded through

GETFund. These projects would expand capacity and improve the learning environment in Senior High Schools nationwide.

Scaling up Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET)

Increasing Access to TVET

The Ministry recorded considerable growth in the enrolment of students into TVET, with an increase from 47,318 students in the 2021/2022 academic year over the years to reach 183,133 in 2024/2025. This expansion reflects the Government's commitment to providing the practical skills necessary for industrialisation and reducing youth unemployment.

Creating a Stand-alone TVET Fund

The Government developed a strategic plan for the creation of a specific TVET Fund, which is intended to achieve sustainable financing of technical and vocational education. This fund would also lead to quality training, improved facilities, and innovative technology in the TVET sector.

Developing Regional TVET Centers of Excellence

In 2025, construction works on new Regional TVET Centers of Excellence, including the Salaga Centre, commenced with funding from GETFund. Funding has also been secured from the German government for work to begin at the Kumasi Centre. These are designed to

offer world-class training to equip learners with industry-relevant skills.

Implementing the TVET Voucher Project

Under the Ghana TVET Voucher Project, 10,739 master craft persons, apprentices, and workers received vouchers for Competency-Based Training at accredited training providers. This initiative seeks to build the practical skills of beneficiaries necessary to improve employability and productivity.

Complementary and Second-Chance Education Initiatives

The Complementary Education Agency increased learning opportunities among marginalised groups through foundational, functional and remedial education interventions. It enrolled a total of 10,050 out-of-school children into Complementary Basic Education in 402 learning centres and provided them with foundational literacy and numeracy instruction, preparing them for reintegration into formal schooling. It also enrolled 10,000 youth and adults in the Functional Literacy Education Programme in 400 classes. Monitoring was done regularly to ensure participants acquired competencies in literacy and numeracy relevant for socio-economic development. Complementing the above, the Remedial Education Programme supported 250 learners, enabling 236 to sit for the BECE and facilitating the placement of 205 into further education programmes, demonstrating the effectiveness of the programme in

providing second-chance learning opportunities.

Enhancing Tertiary Education Access and Financial Support

The Ministry advanced equitable access to tertiary education through the continued implementation of the *No Fees Stress Policy*, which waived academic user fees for first-year students and eased financial pressures on learners, particularly those from disadvantaged backgrounds. Complementing this initiative, the Students Loan Trust Fund processed over 200,000 applications, validating 153,602 and disbursing loans to 151,671 students, with an additional 27,074 validated applications pending disbursement. These interventions underscore the Government’s commitment to reducing financial barriers and expanding opportunities for tertiary education participation. Taken together, these efforts form part of the Ministry’s broader agenda to strengthen access, improve quality and promote equity

across the education sector, reflecting sustained progress toward building a resilient and inclusive education system.

The Ministry of Education recorded significant strides at all levels of Ghana’s education system. In strengthening access, improving quality and increasing equity, the Ministry did this through reforms, targeted programmes for support, expansion of infrastructure and improvement in governance.

ALLOCATION FOR THE YEAR 2026

A total amount of *Thirty-nine billion, two hundred and thirty-three million, seven hundred and ninety-five thousand, twenty-two Ghana cedis (GH¢39,233,795,022)* has been allocated to the Ministry of Education, its Departments and Agencies to implement its programmes and activities for the year 2026. The breakdown of the allocation by cost centres and funding sources is provided for in Table 4.

Table 4: 2026 Budgetary Allocations

ECONOMIC CLASSIFICATION	2025 APPROVED BUDGET (GH¢) SOURCE OF FUNDING			TOTAL (GH¢)
	GOG (GH¢)	IGF (GH¢)	DONOR PARTNERS (GH¢)	
COMPENSATION	32,353,110,395	505,873,559	-	32,858,983,954
GOODS & SERVICES	1,388,602,750	1,945,799,399	108,388,650	3,442,790,799
CAPEX	20,000,000	1,234,216,268	1,677,804,000	2,932,020,268
TOTAL	33,761,713,145 86.05%	3,685,889,227 9.39%	1,786,192,650 4.55%	39,233,795,022 100%

Source: 2026 Budget and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana

Table: Breakdown of 2026 Budgetary Allocation by Programmes

S/N	PROGRAMME	ALLOCATION
1	MANAGEMENT AND ADMINISTRATION	13,719,624,013
2	BASIC EDUCATION	9,533,585,726
3	SECOND CYCLE EDUCATION	5,237,931,355
4	NON-FORMAL EDUCATION	179,441,489
5	INCLUSIVE AND SPECIAL EDUCATION	52,853,909
6	TERTIARY EDUCATION	10,510,358,530
	TOTAL	39,233,795,022

Source: 2026 Programme Based Budget Estimates for 2026, Ministry of Education

OUTLOOK FOR 2026

This section provides highlights of the programmes and activities the Ministry of Education seeks to undertake in 2026 towards achieving its goal of establishing an educational system intended to produce well-balanced individuals for the total development and the democratic advancement of Ghana.

Basic Education Intervention

In 2026, the Ministry intends to enhance the infrastructure of public basic schools. It is also intended that the Ministry will provide textbooks to the public basic schools in the country. This basic education intervention initiative will involve the construction of 200 No. Kindergarten schools, 200 No. Primary Schools, 200 No. Junior High Schools, 400 No. Teachers' Bungalows and 400 No. Sanitary Facilities.

Ghana Secondary Improvement Programme

The Ministry also informed the Committee that it will implement the Ghana Secondary Improvement Programme; a World Bank funded programme aimed at ending the Double-Track System in Senior High Schools within two years; 2026 and 2027. The programme will involve increasing capacity in selected Category A schools, upgrading of 10 Category B schools and upgrading of 30 Category C through the provision of dormitories, classrooms, libraries, science and ICT laboratories. Through the programme, the Ministry will also complete 30 Community-Day Senior High Schools (E-Blocks) in urban and peri-urban areas.

Establishment of tertiary institutions

The Committee was informed of the Ministry's policy initiative towards the expanding access to higher education in

2026. The Government will establish two (2) new Technical Universities. The intended locations are Jasikan and Techiman. The Catholic University of Science and Technology in Damongo will be established in partnership with the Catholic Church. In furtherance of access to higher education, the Ministry will establish two public universities in Kintampo and Dambai, the University of Engineering and Agricultural Sciences at Bunso with satellite campuses at Donkorkrom, Kenyase and Acherensua. The Ministry will also establish the National Defence University for the training in defence and security-related fields.

The Ministry aims at bridging the gender gap in ICT education. To achieve this, the Ministry will provide 10 Girls' Schools across the regions with new ICT laboratories in 2026.

School sports development

In cognisance of the need to provide holistic development through sports and education, the Ministry will establish a National School Sports Authority in 2026 to promote and coordinate sports and physical education across schools.

Continued interventions

The Ministry indicated to the Committee that it will continue the implementation of several initiatives. The implementation of capitation grants, feeding grants, free SHS/TVET, no fees for first-year Tertiary Students, and free sanitary pads to girls, among others.

Curriculum review

The Ministry also indicated to the Committee that plans were advanced to review the curriculum for basic school to include ethics and integrity and electronics, coding and Artificial Intelligence. The Committee provided its support for the review as it will help train students who can compete in the contemporary world

Observations and Recommendations

During its meeting with the Ministry of Education, relevant agencies and civil society organisations, the Committee identified some issues that required emphasis and, where appropriate, proposed recommendations to address them

Staffing and Logistical constraints

The Committee found that most agencies under the Ministry of Education are logistically constrained. The logistics lacking include office space, basic office equipment such as computers and printers, vehicles and motorcycles were unavailable. The National Schools Inspectorate Authority (NaSIA), the Complementary Education Agency (CEA), and the Ghana Library Authority mainly lacked a lot of logistics.

It was also noted that some agencies had inadequate human resources to effectively carry out their mandate. Some of these agencies include Centre for National Distance Learning and Open Schooling, Ghana Commission for UNESCO, National Council for

Curriculum and Assessment (NaCCA), the Ghana Library Authority and the West Africa Examination Council (WAEC).

Schools under trees

The Committee upon reviewing the causes of schools under trees found that most schools faced disasters such as storms which remove the roofs of school buildings causing schools to use the leaves and shade of trees as shelter. To resolve this problem, the Committee suggested that an emergency line should be added to the GETFund formula to cater for the emergencies that destroy school infrastructure.

Challenges with the Public Procurement (Amendment) Act, 2025 (Act 1139)

The Public Procurement (Amendment) Act, 2025 (Act 1139) has introduced in section 24A, the requirement of securing a mandatory commitment authorisation from the Ministry of Finance prior to the procurement of relevant items. While the objective is commendable as part of broader efforts to strengthen fiscal discipline and curb the accumulation of arrears, the measure has had unintended consequences for the Ministry of Education and its agencies.

The requirement for mandatory commitment authorisation has resulted in significant delays in obtaining approvals. Combined with the absence of operational flexibility, these delays have restricted institutions' ability to act promptly and fulfil their mandates effectively. The cumulative effect has

been a slowdown in programme implementation and service delivery across the sector.

In view of these challenges, the Committee recommends a revision of Act 1139 to remove the mandatory commitment authorisation provision and introduce a more flexible framework. Such an amendment would help address the operational difficulties currently faced by the Ministry and its agencies while maintaining the broader objective of fiscal responsibility.

Inadequate Financing

The Committee observed a worrying trend in the financing of education in Ghana. The allocations approved by Parliament to the Ministry are usually inadequate. More worrisome is that large portions of these allocations go into payment of compensation of employees. As at October, 2025, out of the total revised budgetary release of GH¢16,800,263,279 for Compensations, the Ministry had expended an amount of GH¢16,799,062,604, representing 99.9 per cent, with a remaining amount of GH¢1,200,675, representing 0.07 per cent. This, the Committee observed, as inadequate to finance payment of compensation of employees of the Ministry for November and December 2025.

The Committee further observed that releases are frequently delayed at the Controller and Accountant-General's Department.

In light of this, the Committee recommends engaging the Ministry of

Finance to address the financing challenges facing the Ministry of Education and to improve the predictability and timeliness of releases.

TVET Education

The Committee, in its engagement with Africa Education Watch (EDUWATCH), a civil society organisation, identified several challenges and opportunities within the TVET sub-sector. It was noted that significant quality gaps persist in training delivery, largely due to inadequate equipment and practical resources, limited access to career guidance, and weak Workplace Experience Learning arrangements.

To address these concerns, the Committee recommends that the Ministry establish Career Guidance and Counselling units in all TVET institutions, ensure a clear separation between the financing of Free TVET and Free SHS, and prioritise the provision of reliable internet services to Technical and Vocational Institutes. The Committee also supports the proposal to allocate 2.5 per cent of petroleum revenues to the financing of TVET.

No Fees Stress Policy

The Committee raised concerns regarding the reimbursement of fees for first-year tertiary students under the No Fees Stress Policy. The Committee was of the view that funds should be disbursed before the commencement of the academic year to ease the financial burden on students and institutions.

The Ministry explained that the misalignment between the academic calendar and the fiscal year makes it difficult to release funds before schools reopen. In response, the Committee proposed that the Ministry consider a one-year double-tranche disbursement arrangement, under which funds would be released in two tranches across consecutive fiscal years. This approach is intended to ensure timely and predictable support for beneficiaries.

Challenges with Legal frameworks

The Committee observed that several agencies under the Ministry require updated or enabling legal instruments to regulate their operations effectively. The Ghana Book Development Council and the Centre for National Distance Learning and Open Schooling have no Act establishing them. The Ghana Library Authority continues to operate under the Ghana Library Authority Act, 1970 (Act 327), as amended in 1998 (Act 562), which is now outdated. In addition, the Ghana Commission for UNESCO lacks a Legislative Instrument to support its work.

These gaps have limited the ability of the affected agencies to function efficiently and fulfil their mandates. The Committee therefore urged the Ministry to prioritise the development and revision of the necessary legal frameworks to ensure that these agencies operate with clear and adequate statutory backing.

Conclusion

The 2026 Budget Estimates for the Ministry of Education represent a critical investment in the country's long-term human capital development. The achievements recorded across all levels of the education sector in the 2025 financial year demonstrate clear progress in expanding access, strengthening quality, and promoting equity. These outcomes reflect the Ministry's effective implementation of key policies and its commitment to addressing systemic challenges.

Approval of the proposed 2026 budget is therefore essential to sustain ongoing reforms, complete priority infrastructure projects, support flagship interventions, and enhance the delivery of education services nationwide.

The Committee accordingly recommends to the House to adopt its report and approve the sum of Thirty-nine billion, two hundred and thirty-three million, seven hundred and ninety-five thousand, twenty-two Ghana cedis (GH¢39,233,795,022) as the 2026 Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Education to enable it consolidate its gains and advance the national objective of safeguarding Ghana's long-term socio-economic development through a well-educated and empowered population.

Respectfully submitted.

5:35 p.m.

The Speaker: Hon Chairman, in the last paragraph, we will delete “and approve” in view of what we stated

earlier. So, it will be “the Committee accordingly recommends to the House to adopt its report on the allocation of the sum of GH¢39 billion...” and it flows to the end. That should be the additional amendment to the Report.

Question proposed.

Mr Mustapha Ussif (NPP—Yagaba-Kubori): Thank you so much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Report of the Committee on Education for the approval of GH¢39,233,795,022 for the Ministry of Education for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Speaker, let me use this opportunity to thank the Minister, his Deputy and all heads of agencies who took the Committee through the various activities for the 2025 Budget. Their cooperation helped us to understand the achievements made by the Ministry, and also the difficulties they faced during the year. The Ministry made some progress in the 2025 Budget year. For example, the no-fee stress policy. Over 200,000 applicants successfully applied for the no-fee stress policy, and out of these 200,000, 178,000 were validated, and about 151,000 received support from this No-Fee Stress Policy.

Mr Speaker, the major concern for Committee Members has to do with releases. I have been a Minister before, and when the Budget is presented, the Ministry engages the Ministry of Finance on the various priority areas that the Ministry wants to undertake in the Budget year. And when they agree, the

Ministry of Finance comes to the House to seek approval. Mr Speaker, what baffles Members is that after all these approvals have been granted, when it comes to releases to the various Ministries, because of the decision that we took in this House, which is the PFM Act that we reviewed, it is difficult for the various Ministries to get their releases. For example, Mr Speaker, if we look at the goods and services, for the year 2025, the Ministry of Education was appropriated GH¢32 billion and out of this 32 billion, capital expenditure was GH¢1 billion, and the releases for the capital expenditure were GH¢22 million out of 1 billion. Even the GH¢22 million, only 10 million has been released, which is the actual payment.

So, this is very serious, and Mr Speaker, it is not only to the Ministry of Education, I was on the Committee for Lands and Natural Resources, and that was the same challenges that the Ministry faced. So, I want to appeal to you, that if it is possible, for us to direct the Minister for Finance to come to this House. Why should Ministries go through government policies, seek approval of Parliament—I have no challenge with giving our mandate to the Minister for Finance. If the policy direction has to do with starting new projects that are not budgeted for, then there should not be any challenges. But when this is budgeted for and approved by this House, and one has to go and seek commencement certificates, which will take a bureaucratic process at the Ministry of Finance, before these releases are made. Mr Speaker, on this Side, we do not have a challenge. We know that this particular policy is going

to retard progress, which will lead to the defeat of the NDC come 2028, and we will be very happy to see that.

But we want to ensure that before they leave, there is progress. There should be some legacies in the various ministries.

Mr Speaker, another thing that was also of major concern to the Committee Members is the allocation of the GH¢295 million for the sanitary pad distribution to schoolgirls. This is a very laudable policy that all Members support. But our position is that this money could be allocated to set up factories to produce locally manufactured pads because we cannot continue allocating GH¢290 million year on year. Instead of setting up factories to ensure that we can create jobs at the same time, achieve the objective of getting pads to our girls in the various schools.

Mr Speaker, notwithstanding all these challenges, I want to urge all Members of this august House to approve the sum of GH¢39 billion to the Ministry of Education for the year ending 31st December 2026.

The Speaker: Hon Members, I am told there is no agreement or understanding on the number of people to contribute, so I will use my discretion. Are you going to guide us on that?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we want to pray that we take one more on each Side, then we will take Leadership. Leaders can yield to the Members.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we may not always have to take the Leaders. Sometimes, the Leaders may have to give the opportunity to others behind them. We want to hear the voice of everybody. So, when it is always one on each Side, then Leadership, no. Now, we will leave out the Leaders and deal with the backbenchers.

Yes, Minority Chief Whip.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: We can always rely on your wise counsel. So, there had been other Motions that we had done one speaker on each Side. With this, clearly, we can see the interest is high. So, we will defer to the Speaker. He, himself, can exercise his discretion. Maybe three on each Side, and then those who are not willing to speak on that Side can yield to us.

Mr Speaker, we are in your hands.

The Speaker: I would have loved it to be that number, but in view of the magnitude of the challenge to my right, I will be seen to be unfair. If not, I would have allowed many more to come from my left, since my right is ably represented by the Chair and Ministers. But if we do that, because their number is so huge, a lot of them will remain “mumu”—[Laughter]—throughout the four years. And they will have problems in their constituencies. So, I will give them enough opportunity.

So, we will take three on each Side, but five minutes each. Now, when your senior is on his feet—He is your senior because he is a Minister, even though you arrived at the same time.

Yes, please.

Mr Felix Kwakye Ofosu (NDC—Abura-Asebu-Kwamankese): Thank you very much, Rt Hon Speaker, for this opportunity to add my voice to the request by the Minister for Education for Parliament to approve the estimates and the amounts allocated to a sector in the Budget.

Mr Speaker, supporting the Minister is absolutely the right thing to do. In view of the magnitude of the work that he has undertaken in education over the last 11 months or so. When the Mahama administration took over power, the education sector was severely challenged and constrained. We had a situation where basic education had been almost neglected.

5:45 p.m.

Mr Speaker, for many academic terms or academic years, basic textbooks were not available to pupils in basic education. We had a situation where, despite Government's claims at the time that they were focusing on Senior High school education, significant problems remained. Feeding had virtually become impossible at Senior High School level. There was overcrowding. The academic calendar was plagued with inconsistency and an erratic situation. One could not tell when school was going to be open. Even the publication of the academic calendar became a huge challenge. We had an obnoxious double-track under which students went to school for a short while and stayed home for longer periods. There were the issues with

feeding, where the quality of food was poor and most often unavailable. At the tertiary level, there were serious challenges. So, the work of the Mahama administration was cut out for it in the sector of education.

Since the beginning of this year, we have seen tremendous improvements. We have seen that, at the very least, the problems that we saw with feeding at Senior High School level have been overcome. Under the leadership of President Mahama and through the hard work of the Minister for Education, Mr Haruna Iddrisu, close to GH¢1.5 billion has been released to finance the feeding of students in Senior High School, which is something the previous Government was unable to do.

In addition to this, very measurable interventions have been introduced to ensure that the problems plaguing basic education are addressed. Now Capitation Grants is paid on time. Moneys for school feeding are paid promptly. Because of that, the problems that we saw in the past are no longer the case. Provision has been made in this Budget for the printing of millions of textbooks for students at all levels of education, from basic to senior high school. One of the most far-reaching interventions in tertiary education is currently being undertaken by this Government. About 151,000 first-year students benefited from the No-Fee Stress Policy over the past academic year, and a similar number is set to receive similar interventions when the academic year opens. So, there is cause to be excited about the future of education in Ghana, and I pray this

House to give bipartisan support to the approval of these estimates in order that the agenda to build an education system that will stand the test of time and produce graduates that will be globally competitive, is realised.

Mr Speaker, this also shows that real tangible results are not achieved through mere slogans, that it is well and good to shout slogans, but if those slogans are not backed with concrete action, very little can be achieved. We cannot be shouting Free SHS when we cannot feed the students who are overflowing in the Senior High Schools. Even the issue of desks, chairs and tables, for students to sit on was a major problem. At the last reckoning before we came to power, there was a gap of over two million. In other words, about two million desks were required in Ghanaian schools to make up for the number that was optimal. I am aware of a programme which is highlighted in this Budget to distribute two million school desks to Ghanaian schools. In fact, it has already begun. Only last Tuesday, the Labone Senior High School, which is not too far from here, received over 3,000 desks. Indeed, over the last weekend, I presented close to 600 desks to the Abakrampa Senior High School donated by the GETFund. This was out of a request of 1,000 desks that they made. Their promptness—

Mr Speaker, the school requested for 1,000 desks, and within a matter of a month or two, GETFund responded through the Ministry of Education by donating 600 desks to the school that had been deprived for years. Mr Speaker, this

is the school that deserved the presentation because for many years, they have suffered the ignominy of not having desks for their students to sit on.

So, a lot is happening in education, which is resolving the fundamental problems that the poor policy implementation that the Government that just left power, supervised and created. I fully endorse the programmes contained in the 2026 Budget as far as the education sector is concerned, and I call on my Colleagues to band together with us to ensure that we approve these Estimates because the future is exceedingly bright for Ghanaian education. I thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity.

The Speaker: Yes, those in the Committee on Education? Yes, Rev Fordjour?

Rev John Ntim Fordjour (NPP — Assin South): Mr Speaker, I rise to support the Motion under discussion, and to indicate that one of the most critical sectors we have in every economy and in our country is the education sector. If we get the education sector wrong, and the rest of the sectors will be challenged in the long term. One sector among a few other sectors that should have been the priority of this Government, but sadly have been jettisoned to the background is education. If we appoint a very experienced Minister as Mr Haruna Iddrisu, deny him the resources and the budgetary releases to be able to function, the result is what we are seeing, a woeful decline in education outcomes. The House should turn with me to page four

of the Report, to crave your indulgence to effect a correction on Table 7.2, the third column should not be ‘2025 revised budgets’, but it should be ‘released budget’— *[Interruption]*—Alright, as corrected. Out of the GHC31.7 billion allocated to the Ministry of Education for the year 2025, rather in a very disappointing outturn, only GHC19.1 billion was released. Mr Speaker, a total of GHC12 billion are in arrears, and have not been released. How do we expect the education sector to function? It is ailing; it is dysfunctional. With 12 billion deficits, we only put the Minister in a handicapped position. The Hon Minister of State for Government Communications is indicating that his Constituency alone has benefited from 600 desks, just one man. He went and distributed that instead of releasing the money to the Ministry of Education to ensure equitable distribution of furniture, of education material, he holds back the releases and individuals— 600 desks to one Constituency. Ask the Backbench, Mr Edem Agbana; ask the rest of the Backbench. How many desks were they able to send to their schools? None.

Mr Speaker, when we look at the nature of education, it must be a worry. In the year 2015, only two per cent of our pupils in Primary 2 could read, by the Early Grade Reading Assessment (EGRA). We managed to invest heavily into the education sector from all levels, particularly foundational level. We took it to minimum 38 per cent by 2023. Do we want to go back to the era where only two per cent of peoples were reading? On the West African Senior School Certificate Examination (WASSCE)

outcomes, when we talk about the quality of education, we have world-class indicators, undisputed, that we use to measure education outcomes, to know how well our education is doing.

When we have bequeathed to them a WASSCE pass rate in English, Core Mathematics, Integrated Science and Social Studies, just as we said.

5:55 p.m.

In 2023, 73 per cent of our WASSCE candidates passed in English, Integrated Science; 66.82 per cent, Mathematics; 62.3 per cent, Social Studies; 76.7 per cent, passed from A1 to C6. Under their watch, they have taken Mathematics to 48.73 per cent. Mr Speaker, the dangerous thing about this result is that more than half of our children who sat for WASSCE will be denied the opportunity to enter any tertiary institution. Over 52 per cent of our learners will have to sit home. Their parents will have to pay several thousands of cedis for resits. Because they are not releasing money to the Ministry of Education to undertake—

They are talking about feeding, but they promised headmasters that if they vote for them, they will send money directly to them so that they feed the students. President Mahama promised that so that they will go and buy *apɔnkye* and do *apɔnkye nkrakra* for our students, only for them to come to power, they released for just a few months, and the releases stopped, then they reverted to buffer stock for some time. Now as we speak, another directive went that

because the suppliers of buffer stock are owed in areas, the Government can no longer go to them to supply food. So, the headmasters should now go and face suppliers and credit more food so that our students can have something to eat.

Mr Speaker, I have taken the pain to visit some of the schools, and if we see the kind of food our students are eating, it is terrible. Why? Because they are refusing to release GH¢12 billion to the Minister. How do they expect Hon Haruna Iddrisu to maintain a decent feeding system when GH¢12 billion is in arrears?

Mr Speaker, on double track, they promised that when they come into power, immediately, they will end double track. The moment they got into power, they said they are deferring to three years. Hon Kwakye Ofori should tell us which additional space they have created in our secondary schools. He was talking about overcrowding. He should point to us even a single additional space they have created within this period. Release money to the Minister. GH¢12 billion in arrears is unacceptable. I do not think that the Rt Hon Speaker himself would be excited about this. Mr Speaker is a heavy continental advocate for education. He will not countenance GH¢12 billion in arrears. It is an ailing sector. They need resources to drive outcomes.

Now, if we take out Ghana Accountability for Learning Outcomes Project (GALOP) which is a donor-funded programme transforming over 10,000 least performing schools, what is

left of our education sector is commitment from the Government. So, we urging this Government that best course of action is for the GH¢39 billion that is allocated in this budget, while we even think that it is inadequate, is to ensure a 100 per cent release to the Minister to ensure that we have commensurate outcomes.

A few years ago, our students from Methodist Girls' High School, Mamfe and Prempeh College could go to the United States of America and compete in robotics and Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) and become first, beating their compatriots from Singapore, Australia and Canada. Today, what is the story? All the STEM schools that were under construction, the 11 that we were able to commission, the rest that are left are still as it is. What we see is re-launch upon re-launch. The sad thing is that after the Minister has most enthusiastically re-launched certain programmes, the funding that must go with it is locked up in the bosom of Hon Ampem and his boss. Mr Speaker, let the Ministry of Finance release funds. Education must not be locked up at the Ministry of Finance; it must be released to the Ministry of Education.

I know the competence of Hon Haruna Iddrisu; it is never in doubt. Even at the age of 39, we know the wonders he did at the Ministry of Communication. But why is the education sector ailing now? Because GH¢12 billion is in arrears.

But once we look at the finances, we must also turn our attention to the relevance of our education system. When we talk about having a serious look at the various factors that are accounting for this, we were expecting a very patriotic approach. But what we see is government machinery released, and all we hear is, “because”, and a blame game given to the teachers, that teachers abetted WASSCE candidates in the past, and that is the reason why we have stellar performances of our children, that is most regrettable. The same teachers we have three years ago are the same teachers.

We must put on record that the biggest partners of our education success story have been our teachers. They supported the creditable implementation of Free S.H.S. They ensured the holistic development of every child that passed through our public education system. So, if today, they are even failing to release their allowances to them, and they are deferring – this will be the first year that teachers' allowances are being deferred. So, if they are refusing to pay our teachers, they should not blame this rather appalling performance on the teacher. If the teacher is supported, he will deliver instruction. If the students are also supported and prepared adequately, they will face the examination with confidence. They will get back to the days when the three people who became the topmost performers in the whole of West Africa, beating Nigeria, Gambia, Sierra Leone, Liberia, were Ghanaians. Today, only 48 per cent of them are passing Mathematics.

Could it be that they are putting a natural ceiling to the number of people that must access their no-stress fee? So that if they restrict the number of people who will be able to pass to go to tertiary, then they will have space enough to cater for them. If that is not the case, their data of financial performance does not support it. Because if their history is GH¢12 billion in arrears, then anybody will easily believe – I might doubt – that you want more of our students to fail so that less will make it to the tertiary, so that the burden of their own promise, No-Stress Fee, will be abysmal.

Mr Speaker, we want to indicate that we are ever ready to support them to get back our ailing education sector outcomes back on track. We are ready to support them; Ghana is all we have. Our students are brilliant, our teachers are dedicated, and our Minister is competent. The only thing left is the budgetary releases.

Mr Eric Edem Agbana (NDC — Ketu North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Committee's Report on the budget.

A budget is more than a fiscal outline of expenditure and expected revenue. It is also a mirror of our national priorities. Indeed, when we take a look at the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy and the budgetary allocation to the Ministry of Education, one does not need a soothsayer to predict that indeed President John Dramani Mahama is the president who cares about our educational sector and is committed to improving the quality of education.

Mr Speaker, when we look at the budgetary allocation to the Ministry, it provides answers to all the three-core metrics that are used universally in judging a country's educational system. The first one is accessibility. Mr Speaker, in this budget, Government has provided for the construction of 200 new primary schools, 200 new junior high schools, 400 teachers' bungalows, and also 200 new kindergarten schools.

It is important to expand access to education. When we talk about access and expansion of accessibility, President Mahama and Hon Haruna Iddrisu have demonstrated that indeed, beyond words, we are committed to expanding access. That is why the Budget has made adequate allocation for the construction of these new schools to provide accessibility for, especially, people in the rural communities.

Mr Speaker, the second metric is affordability. Mr Speaker, the previous government indeed touted Free S.H.S. as their biggest achievement. At a point in time, even when we complain of headache, they will tell us that their solution is Free S.H.S. When we complained about the poor nature of roads in our constituencies, they responded that they were implementing Free SHS. When market women were complaining about the high cost of doing business, their response was Free S.H.S.

6:05 p.m.

But indeed, when you check their response or the actual performance of the previous regime, with regard to Free

SHS, it was nothing but an abysmal performance.

Mr Speaker, they can be akin to parents who gave birth without making adequate preparation to take care of their children. And indeed, at a point in time, common feeding in our Senior High Schools (SHS) was a big challenge. But under this Government, we have dedicated source of funding for the Free SHS Programme.

Mr Speaker, today, our brothers and sisters, and our children in the Senior High Schools are complaining that they are being overfed. And some of them are complaining that, indeed, the food that they are feeding on today is more than they expected. Today, in this Budget, GH¢4.2 billion has been allocated to the Free SHS Programme, and our brothers and sisters in Senior High Schools will not face those challenges. The question is, if they say that we are not committing much to education, what was their record in terms of funding the Free SHS Programme that they tout? A shambolic record by all standards.

Mr Speaker, the third area or metric is quality. Under Mr Haruna Iddrisu, we have seen improvement in the quality of education. And in terms of improvement, Mr Speaker, it is not only about the WASSCE results that they want us to talk about today, because we have been told that the WASSCE results will be fully discussed in this House. But we are talking about training and capacity building for teachers. We are talking about the provision of teaching and learning materials to students across our

schools. We are talking about the fact that today, when you visit public schools, especially the tertiary institutions, persons living with disability are going to benefit from free tertiary education. What more can we ask for than this? Today, if you are a Ghanaian living with disability, the cost of education, funding of the school fees can no longer become a barrier for you. Mr Speaker, this must be commended.

Again, Mr Speaker, the No Fees Stress Policy. As a Member of Parliament from a constituency that can be considered very rural, there are many people from my constituency who got admissions to tertiary institutions, but because of the high cost of education at that level, they were unable to pursue tertiary education. Today, under President Mahama and Mr Haruna Iddrisu, these students in public schools have the opportunity to go to school without paying the academic facility user fees.

Mr Speaker, this is a true investment in our children, a true investment in education. When you look at the Budget, yes, it is true, that when you look at the entire education ministry, we can be Oliver Twist and ask for more because the challenges are more. But even with the little that the Minister was given in the year 2025, we can all trace the outcome of the Government's performance in education.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, I would want to say that I find it surprising that today, our Colleagues on the other Side are talking about the Government's

commitment to funding education, when indeed their scorecard is here with us. When they talk about the performance of students at WASSCE, instead of buying textbooks, they were buying past questions. And the Hon Reverend, who was the Deputy Minister, is complaining. Instead of buying textbooks, they were only interested in buying past questions. And indeed, on record, he and his Minister were only interested in buying past questions for our children instead of supplying them with textbooks.

Mr Speaker, again, when the NPP was in power, apart from the shortage of food in our senior high schools, the few schools that had the opportunity to get food, we all heard the reports of maggots-infested food being supplied to them. But you do not hear that today in our senior high schools. Clearly, President John Dramani Mahama and Mr Haruna Iddrisu are taking time to invest properly in our education.

Mr Speaker, looking at the outlook for 2026, one other thing that excites me is the fact that the Government intends to build three new public universities. Today, we want to ensure that Ghanaians, all over, do not face any barrier in their access to tertiary education. And it is important that the Government be supported to implement this Budget so that the three new universities — we are told one will be in Oti Region, one will be in the Bono East Region, and one will be in, I think, the North East Region and Ahafo Region. This must be supported.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, there is also something very exciting in the Budget. It is a fact that the Ministry is

planning to upgrade some Category C and B schools into Category A. When you go to the whole North East Region, as we speak today, there is no single Category A school, and so for the Ministry to take it upon itself to invest in upgrading senior high schools from Category C, B, to Category A, and 30 schools will be benefiting from this project, this is commendable. President Mahama and Mr Haruna Iddrisu must be commended. Mr Speaker, I pray for a bipartisan support for the adoption of this Report.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (NPP — Offinso North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the adoption of the Report of the Ministry of Education on the 2026 Annual Budget Estimates. Mr Speaker, before I go on, I would like us to go to paragraph 8.8.1, the Ministry recorded considerable growth in enrolment of students in Tertiary and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) with an increase from 47,000 students in 2021/2022 academic year. Over the years to reach, it is not 183; if you look at the 2024/2025 academic year, it is rather 69,000 students, so that needs to be corrected.

Also, in paragraph 8.8.3, the Ministry is yet to start the construction of these TVET centres. This also needs to be corrected. Even though one, that was supposed to be in the Ashanti Region at Manso Abore, has been relocated to Salaga, that is fine with us. The Ministry will also have to re-correct that as well.

Mr Speaker, everybody believes in education. All of us are here in this hallowed Chamber because of education. It is quite unfortunate that our Hon Member just talked about instead of buying textbooks, we bought past questions. Mr Speaker, I believe in evidence-based practice and the data do not support it. The question is, what happened? What really happened that we have less than 50 per cent of our students passing mathematics? Do you know why, Mr Speaker? The Ministry promised to spend almost GH¢564.6 million on textbooks. Unfortunately, none has been spent in the year 2025.

Mr Speaker, if you go to the NPP's performance in 2024, the NPP spent GH¢33.6 billion on education as compared to 19 point something —

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe — *rose* —

The Speaker: Just a minute. Actually, I wanted the debate to flow, no interruption. Chairman?

Mr Nortsu-Kotoe: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I just want to clear an issue he has just mentioned, that the Ministry said they were going to spend about GH¢500 million on textbooks. It is in the GETFund Formula for 2025, not in the Ministry's Budget. Thank you, sir.

Dr Asamoah: Mr Speaker, I would like to refer to the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, paragraph 380 which states:

“Mr Speaker, we have also allocated an amount of GH¢564.6 million for

comprehensive provision of curricula-based textbooks covering the following:

- i. four (4) sets of KG books and workbooks for about 2.8 million learners;
- ii. four (4) sets of primary textbooks for 800,000 learners; and
- iii. iii. nine (9) sets of JHS 3 textbooks for 540,000 learners.”

Mr Speaker, unfortunately, when you come to the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy,

6:15 p.m.

These numbers have been lifted, put in here, and unfortunately also has reduced even that of primary to one million. So, it is no wonder we are seeing what we are seeing. The evidence does not support what the Ministry is saying, because the investment that is supposed to go into education is not going.

Mr Speaker, for the first time, motivational allowance for teachers is not being paid. I had the time to go through the budgetary allocation for every single agency within the Ministry of Education, and compared the 2025 Budget to that of 2026. Unfortunately, I realised that people were paid to stay in offices, doing nothing, because nothing was given for CAPEX, neither has anything being given for goods and services. That means there is no reason to expect anything better in the results of our students who wrote the WASSCE, because it is the same performance. In

fact, if we look at this year, the number of students whose results have been withheld is so high. So, the fact that people were properly invigilated or they were not allowed to cheat is untenable. In fact, it even goes to confirm that probably there was more cheating in these exams than has been done in the past, if we are looking at the data. But we have been told that WAEC is going to meet the Committee, and then we can have a better interrogation into this matter.

Mr Speaker, when we go further, we realise that the Ministry's commitment, as far as basic education is concerned, cannot be assured. Why? Because, the textbook that was supposed to have been printed in 2025 is the same thing that has been lifted and placed in 2026 Budget. So, where is the trust and the credibility here if we keep repeating the same thing?

Mr Speaker, one thing that has been put in this 2026 Budget that is going to kill the private sector is the insistence that the formal Assembly Press should be mandated to print these textbooks. Whether they have the capacity, I do not have a problem, but we are in a competitive country where we expect the private sector to create jobs. Unfortunately, this Budget is going to kill the private sector. About GH¢564 million is being given to one company. Where is the fairness here? Where is the transparency? It has to be competitive. We should allow the private sector to be able to participate so that they can create more jobs. We want jobs for our youth. Already, people have been sacked at the beginning of 2025, while we are trying to

kill the private sector that they cannot create jobs. If this is made competitive, then, of course, we will be able to print these textbooks and improve on performance.

Mr Speaker, one other reason why we realise that the performance of our students was very poor is the fact that the Minister for Education, on the 25th of June, stood in this House and stated categorically that we are going to employ 50,000 instructors to support education. Unfortunately, nothing happened. So, if we intend to support education and to improve on the human capital of this country, then we have to walk the talk. We cannot just be putting figures for nothing, but rather we should make sure that everything that we put in for education—That is the base of our development and everything we do—We expect that when this Budget is approved for the Ministry, it will be released for the them to work.

Another important thing is the fact that most agencies across all the ministries we have met, do not have the opportunity to utilise their allocation for CAPEX or goods and services because of commitment authorisation. In passing the Annual Estimates, our Friends on the other Side, the Majority kept shouting *Hear! Hear!* Now they are all crying. We need to review this so that this country can move forward. The NPP is ready to come back in four years, but we want to make sure that we keep moving as a country so that when we come, we can continue.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Hon Members, I proceed to put the question. We have had enough on education.

Hon Minister, do you have something to say?

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, let me thank Hon Members for the issues raised, and to assure my Colleagues on the other Side.

I heard my Hon Colleague talk about printing of textbooks. We are not wasteful. We are reviewing curriculum from kindergarten to Junior High School, and therefore it was not prudent to be paying to print books while you are reviewing curriculum. However, the GETFund, sufficiently spent on a number of the textbooks.

Mr Speaker, we have not departed from the pledge we made in our manifesto to give funding to the Conference of Heads of Secondary Schools (CHASS), and the GES to fund school feeding. So far, GH¢1.1 billion was directly released to CHASS and the GES for the procurement of food, and students are enjoying better food than it was. In many instances, they had to postpone the reopening of schools because they had no food to supply to the secondary schools. That has not been the case under President Mahama.

Mr Speaker, while thanking Members, let me assure them that we are working to end double track systems. A number of schools, including Wa Secondary School, will be upgraded to category “A” schools. We have received

funding of US\$180 million from the World Bank to convert a number of category “C” schools to “B”, 10 category “B” schools to “A”, and expand infrastructure in a number of the category “A” schools. With quality improvement, we will be able to improve what they left behind.

Mr Speaker, I do not intend to make comments uninformed on the outcome of an examination, but to emphasise that strict invigilation, strict monitoring and supervision contributed to some discipline in the conduct of the WASSCE. But without prejudice to the WAEC Examiner’s Report, I will not go further on this matter.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude by saying that Otumfuo Osei Tutu II, the Asantehene, at the congregation of the Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology reminded Government about the teaching hospital at the Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology. It is a pledge H. E. President Mahama will walk in 2026 and make sure that it becomes functional into 2026. We will complete the teaching hospital, equip it with over US\$38 million and pay the outstanding US\$46 million owed the contractor to be able to complete the work.

Mr Speaker, as was observed by the Hon Agbana, a number of public universities will be established in the course of the year. The University of Engineering and Agriculture at Bunso, will take off. Our Colleague is looking for a university in the Mampong area in Obuasi that is being reviewed. Jasikan,

Damongo and Dambai will also benefit from higher institutions of learning. The President has dedicated US\$30 million of the award he got from China into the establishment of a science and technology university in Damongo. So once again, Mr Speaker, let me assure our Colleagues that even though the Ministry did not get direct adequate funding, Free Senior High School was adequately funded from the GETFund.

Mr Speaker, finally, I have seen my Colleague, Hon Vincent Ekow Assafuah, misleading the public on the free Sanitary Pad programme. I personally shared the contract award letter with him because I am a consummate, transparent person. He keeps telling the public that sanitary pads were bought for GH¢45. That is untrue today; that will be untrue tomorrow. Mr Speaker, we procured 12 million.

Mr Assafuah —*rose*—

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: And I personally walked to him—If he would, he should display his WhatsApp, I shared an award letter of GH¢19 to GH¢21 as a unit price of a sanitary pad with him, he has that evidence and still went telling the public that they were procured at GH¢45. I respected and shared that with him—

The Speaker: Hon Minister, you mentioned his name, and he is on his feet. Let us listen to him.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity.

I thought at this juncture I have been able to put these matters into proper perspective, especially because every document that I have referred to are his document. There has not been any document, not even a single document, that I have referred to, as it were, which document is not coming from the Ministry. Every document that I have stated, every document that I have made reference to is from 2025 and 2026.

Mr Speaker, it is true that indeed in the 2025 Budget, the Ministry of Education stated that they have supplied 6.6 million pieces of sanitary pads. These are numbers that are not coming from me. It is also true that in the 2026 Budget, he stated that they are going to use GH¢292 million to purchase sanitary pads. This is also a document from him.

6:25 p.m.

It is not a document coming from me. So, the calculations that were made are calculations based on their own documents. I have not conjured even a single document from anywhere.

Mr Speaker, it is also important for me to state that no document has been shared from him to me. I have written a Right to Information (RTI), and three months down the lane —

The Speaker: Hon Member, I gave you the opportunity, so when I am drawing your attention, please listen. You raised a point of order. The point of order was based on the fact that he mentioned your name, and he mentioned your name with respect to one item, which he said he sent to your *WhatsApp*,

which was the reason you raised the point of order. Now, you are re-arguing your case. All that you are saying, you have submitted them before this House, it is in the *Official Report*, but respond to the specific matter he raised on your name; that is all.

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, it is indeed true that an assistant of his, when he called, said that a letter was being sent to my phone. I checked the letter, and indeed, the amount that was on that letter that was sent to me was about GHC23. These are numbers that they themselves have already said here on the floor of Parliament.

The Speaker: You said GHC23?

Mr Assafuah: Mr Speaker, around GHC 23, for one sanitary pad. And I am also suggesting that these are figures I have already said, that even if it is GHC23, there is still overspending. It is still a *chobo* activity, because when you go to the market, and you are buying one sanitary pad, you will get GHC15, and if they are buying 12.2 million sanitary pads at GHC23, that cannot be the case.

So, I have not changed any document; whatever he is saying is what I am speaking to.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Hon Member, you just reminded me. I think due to my ignorance about the meaning of *chobo*, you got away with it the other day. After the session, I was educated by so many people that *chobo* is actually an unparliamentary word, because the meaning they told me had to do with

dishonesty or corruption. I did not understand it at that time, and I permitted it. Your Colleagues have confirmed it here. So, are you saying they are also lying to me? Please, let us not deceive people. Actually, I did not understand what the word *chobo* meant. By our Standing Orders, you are imputing improper motives. So, by our Standing Orders, that is unparliamentary. I did not understand it, so I allowed it. So, I do not want you to continue to use it again, because it is an unparliamentary word.

Hon Minister, you may conclude.

Mr Haruna Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, as I indicated, GETFund, because it has been uncapped, has been able to perform its new responsibility of financing Free Senior High School, and they will complete work on Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology. This year, GHC4.2 billion has been allocated to fund the Free Senior High School. We are also allocating, when the formula gets here, GHC100 million to be dedicated to providing all learners with special needs free education under President Mahama's reset to expand access to inclusive quality education.

I thank you, and I thank Hon Members.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved:

That this honourable House approves the sum of GHC39,233,795,022.00 for the services of the Ministry of Education for the year ending 31st December 2026.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I humbly say that the *Order Paper* is actually *Order Paper Addendum*.

The Speaker: Exactly what I said. Initially, I referred to the *Order Paper*, but I corrected myself and said *Order Paper Addendum*.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I pray that we go back to the original *Order Paper* and take the Motion numbered 29.

The Speaker: Hon Members, the Motion numbered 29 on the original *Order Paper*.

Yes, Hon Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, may I bring this to the attention of our Hon Majority Chief Whip, that it is for a very good reason that our servicemen are here, and there has been a lot of consultation in that regard. We love our servicemen.

Mr Speaker, I thought there was a decision of the House to take that particular item. We do not want our servicemen to be waiting for far too long.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Chief Whip, that was the message I also got; that we will move to those items.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I pray that we go to *Order Paper Addendum 2* and lay the item numbered 1(b).

The Speaker: Hon Members, kindly refer to *Order Paper Addendum 2*, Presentation of Papers —[*Interruption*]

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the item numbered 1(d)(i) and (ii).

The Speaker: Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we are aligned.

The Speaker: Hon Members, the item numbered 1(d)(i) and (ii). It can be taken together by the Chairman of the Committee.

PAPERS

By the Chairman of the Committee

- i. Report of the Committee on Defence and Interior on the Contract Agreement between Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Defence) and Airbus Helicopter (SAS), France, for an amount of one hundred and twenty-five million, nine hundred and sixty-five thousand, nine hundred and seventy-four euros (€125,965,974.00) for the supply of One (1) H160 and Three (3) H175 Helicopters for the Ghana Air Force.
- ii. Report of the Committee on Defence and Interior on the Sale and Purchase Contract Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented

by the Ministry of Defence) and Dassault Aviation, France, for an amount of sixty million, six hundred and eighty thousand United States dollars (US\$60,680,000.00) for the acquisition of One (1) Falcon 6X for the Ghana Air Force.

6:35 p.m.

The Speaker: Which item are we to take?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may we humbly take the Motions numbered 17 and 20 together?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the Motion numbered 17 that he mentioned is supposed to be a procedural Motion, so I am wondering why he has added the other one. Why is he taking the two procedural Motions together? He should explain to the House.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, it is just an indication that when we take the procedural, we will take the substantive Motion in 20. So, let us take the 17.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, he is a master of procedure, but he appears to be fatigued. Let us take Motion numbered 17, then the House will decide on the other procedural Motion before we go to the substantive. We cannot take the two substantive Motions together. I know he is tired; he is clearly tired.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I am not tired at all. It is just an indication.

The Speaker: Yes, Minister for Finance.

Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson: Mr Speaker, the Motion numbered 17 is a procedural Motion, same as Motion numbered 20. We have to take them together because the Committee's Report combined the two. So, we are suggesting that if we are to take procedural Motion 17, we should accordingly take procedural Motion 20. Then we will now come and take the substantive Motions 18 and 21. I so submit, Mr Speaker.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, that is a better explanation. Because the report is for the two items, that is why he wants to take the two. Now, we are with them. We, the Minority, pay particular attention to details.

Mr Speaker, we are watching them with an eagle eye.

The Speaker: You cannot stop him from playing his role. So, if he says he is watching you with an eagle eye, you should take it seriously. Please, we are to take the two procedural Motions together. Items numbered 17 and 20.

MOTIONS

Suspension of Order 104(1)

Chairman of the Committee (Mr James Agalga): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 104(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that a motion

shall not be debated until at least two sitting days have elapsed after the notice to move the motion is given, the Motion for the adoption of the Report of [10] the Committee on Defence and Interior on the Contract Agreement between Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Defence) and Airbus Helicopter (SAS), France, for an amount of One Hundred and Twenty-Five Million, Nine Hundred and Sixty-Five Thousand, Nine Hundred and Seventy Four Euros (€125,965,974.00) for the supply of One (1) H160 and Three (3) H175 Helicopters for the Ghana Air Force may be moved today.

AND

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 104(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that a Motion shall not be debated until at least two sitting days have elapsed after the notice to move the motion is given, the motion for the adoption of the Report of the Committee on Defence and Interior on the Sale and Purchase Contract Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Defence) and Dassault Aviation, France, for an amount of sixty million, six hundred and eighty thousand United States dollars (US\$60,680,000.00) for the acquisition of One (1) Falcon 6X for the Ghana Air Force.

Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem: Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

The Speaker: We now move to the substantive Motions numbered 18 and 21.

**Contract Agreements between
GoG and Airbus Helicopter and
between GoG and Dassault Aviation
for the Supply of Aircrafts**

Chairman of the Committee (Mr James Agalga): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That this honourable House adopts the Report of the Committee on Defence and Interior on the Contract Agreement between Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Defence) and Airbus Helicopter (SAS), France, for an amount of one hundred and twenty-five million, nine hundred and sixty-five thousand, nine hundred and seventy-four euros (€125,965,974.00) for the supply of One (1) H160 and Three (3) H175 Helicopters for the Ghana Air Force.

AND

That this honourable House adopts the Report of the Committee on Defence and Interior on the Sale and Purchase Contract Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Defence) and Dassault Aviation, France, for an amount of sixty million, six hundred

and eighty thousand United States dollars (US\$60,680,000.00) for the acquisition of One (1) Falcon 6X for the Ghana Air Force.

6:45 p.m.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr James Agalga): Mr Chairman, beg to second the Motion and in so doing present the Report of your Committee on Defence and Interior on these subjects. In doing so, I would pray that the *Hansard* captures the Report in full while I touch on the salient points.

The Speaker: Hon Member, I think the Report is available. Hon Members have gone through it and you know the subject matter we are dealing with. Unless there is good reason, we want you to go to the recommendations and the conclusion so that we can move on. Is that the sense of the House?

Yes, so please, Chairman, you may do so.

Mr Agalga: Very well, Mr Speaker, I am most grateful.

Introduction

The Contract Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Defence) And Airbus Helicopter (SAS), France for an amount of one hundred and twenty-five million, nine hundred and sixty-five thousand, nine hundred and seventy-four euros (€125,965,974.00) for the supply of One H160, and Three H175 Helicopters for the Ghana Airforce; and

Sale and Purchase Contract Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Defence) and Dassault Aviation, France, for an amount of sixty million, six hundred and eighty thousand United States dollars (US\$ 60,680,000.00) for the Acquisition of One (1) Falcon 6X for the Ghana Airforce was presented to Parliament by the Deputy Minister for Defence, Mr Enerst Brogya Genfi on Wednesday, 3rd December, 2025.

The Rt Hon Speaker referred the Contract Agreement to the Committee on Defence and Interior for consideration and report in accordance with Article 181(5) of the Constitution and Standing Order 247.

Deliberations

Pursuant to the referral, the Committee met with the Acting Hon Minister for Defence, Dr Cassiel Ato Forson, military officers from the Ghana Armed Forces and officials from the Ministry of Finance and considered the referral.

The Committee is grateful to the Acting Minister for Defence and officials from the Ghana Armed Forces and the Ministry of Finance for attending upon it and assisting in the deliberations.

Reference Documents

The Committee referred to the following additional documents during its deliberations:

- i. The 1992 Constitution of Ghana;

- ii. The Standing Orders of Parliament of Ghana; and
- iii. The Contract Agreement for the Acquisition of Four (4) Helicopters and one Aircraft together with Associated Support and Services for the Ghana Air Force
- iv. Sale and Purchase Contract Between Dassault Aviation and the Government of the Republic of Ghana

Background

The Ghana Air Force (GHAF), as a key arm of the Ghana Armed Forces (GAF), is mandated to conduct aerial warfare, provide air mobility, and deliver offensive air support during joint operations. However, the evolving nature of global, regional and domestic security threats demands new strategic approaches and enhanced operational capacity within the GHAF. The Armed Forces continue to play a central role in addressing security threats across national, regional and global levels. Emerging challenges such as terrorism, violent extremism, illegal mining, drug trafficking, human smuggling and maritime crimes have reshaped the security landscape, requiring the military to adapt and expand its capabilities.

Article 210 of the 1992 Constitution establishes the Ghana Armed Forces and mandates them to defend Ghana's territorial integrity and vital national interests.

In addition to external defence, the GAF plays a crucial role in maintaining internal security and contributing to regional and international peace operations. These responsibilities have been executed despite significant resource limitations. In line with its mission "to deliver air power to meet national security objectives," the GHAF must realign and upgrade its capabilities to respond effectively to contemporary security threats.

National security increasingly depends on the GHAF's ability to maintain air superiority. The GHAF has therefore proposed the acquisition of modern air platforms to enhance its operational readiness. Recent accident investigation reports also highlight the need for modern aircraft equipped with advanced safety and mission systems. Most existing GHAF aircraft are ageing, unreliable, and experience prolonged downtimes due to severe technical faults.

The current state of key GHAF aircraft is as follows:

- Falcon 900EX Easy: In service since 2010, it has undergone extensive inspection, revealing major defects such as corrosion and fuel leakage. With the model no longer in production, sourcing parts poses major challenges.
- Mi-17 Helicopters: All six units are unserviceable due to overdue overhauls and major component failures, severely impacting operational readiness.

- Z-9EH Helicopters: All four units are unserviceable, with one lost to an accident in August 2025. The fleet lacks critical modern systems such as TAWS, EGPWS and advanced navigation, and is overdue for mandatory overhaul.
- Casa C295M: Of the three aircraft on inventory, only one is currently serviceable. Though useful for tactical lift operations, the type is not suitable for medium-to-long-range executive travel.

Given the deteriorating condition of the current fleet and the urgent operational needs of the GHAF, the State must procure five new air platforms: one (1) HI 60, three (3) H175 helicopters and one (1) Dassault Falcon 6X, together with the required support systems and services to restore and enhance air operational capability.

Justification for The Agreement

Article 210 of the 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana mandates that the Ghana Armed Forces is combat-ready at all times, in terms of its personnel and also its equipment. A considerable portion of the Ghana Armed Air Forces fleet has reached advanced age, with many platforms currently grounded due to extensive maintenance Challenges.

In this regard, it is necessary that the State adequately equips the Ghana Armed Forces from time to time with modern and sophisticated equipment to make it fit for its internal and external responsibilities.

Additionally, the acquisition of new aircraft forms part of the broader retooling and comprehensive modernisation agenda for the Ghana Air Force in particular, to ensure safety, efficiency, and strategic mobility for both National leadership and military operations. While upfront cost may be significant, modern aircraft reduce long-term maintenance expenses compared to our ageing fleet.

Observations

The Committee, having carefully examined the Agreement, made the following observations:

Design of the Aircraft

The Committee noted that the proposed four (4) Aircraft and one (1) executive jet, together with Associated Support and services, were obtained from Airbus Helicopters (SAS) and Dassault Aviation, with key requirements which included the cost of aircraft, reliability, operational efficiency, safety and the desired technical specification.

The Committee further observed that the proposed helicopters and jets are designed for versatility, offering superior performance in executive and troop transport, logistics support and humanitarian operations. Additionally, these aircraft have extended range, payload capacity and modern avionics, which gives them an edge over the previous generation, which would enable rapid deployment in support of GAF's counterterrorism, border and maritime security operations, as well as executive travels.

The Committee recommends that the Ministry of Defence, in collaboration with the Ghana Armed Forces, expedite the procurement and deployment of the proposed helicopters and jets to enhance operational readiness. The view is that given their advanced design, extended range, superior payload capacity and modern avionics, prioritising their acquisition will significantly strengthen the nation's counterterrorism, border and maritime security capabilities.

The Committee further advises that adequate funding be allocated not only for procurement, but also for pilot training, maintenance support systems and associated infrastructure to ensure the aircraft delivers optimal performance and long-term value in both security and executive operations.

Stakeholder Engagements

The Committee was informed that extensive stakeholder consultations were undertaken with the Ministry of Finance, the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice, and the Ghana Air Force. Additionally, internal engagements were held with relevant services within the Ghana Armed Forces, as well as the Office of the President. These consultations were aimed at ensuring legal clarity, financial feasibility, operational suitability, and alignment with national security priorities prior to the proposed acquisition.

The Committee recommends that the Government continue to strengthen inter-agency coordination throughout the procurement and implementation process

to ensure transparency, cost effectiveness, and operational efficiency. The Committee further urges that all technical, financial and legal inputs gathered through the consultations be fully incorporated into the final procurement arrangements to guarantee value for money and seamless integration of the aircraft into the Ghana Air Force's operational framework.

Financial Impact Analyses

The Committee further noted that the long-term economic benefits of procuring the new aircraft fleet outweigh the associated costs. It was evident that continued reliance on the ageing Mi-17 helicopter fleet and the Falcon 900EX aircraft has become financially unsustainable and operationally inefficient for the Ghana Air Force. Over a projected 15-year service life, the total lifecycle cost of the proposed new fleet is estimated to be 30–40 per cent lower than the cost of maintaining and operating the existing ageing aircraft. The Committee also observed that the current practice of leasing aircraft from external providers not only exerts pressure on the nation's limited foreign exchange resources but also exposes sensitive state movements and security-related operations to third parties, posing potential risks.

The Committee recommends that the Government prioritise the acquisition of the new aircraft fleet to ensure long-term cost savings, improved operational efficiency and enhanced national security. The Committee further urges that the Ghana Air Force be supported with the requisite funding and

maintenance infrastructure to maximise the lifespan and performance of the new aircraft. Additionally, efforts should be made to eliminate reliance on leased aircraft to safeguard sensitive state operations and preserve national security interests.

Funding Source

The Minister for Finance informed the Committee that a budgetary provision had been made to support the drawdown for the purchase of aircraft under the Government of Ghana-funded helicopter acquisition project.

The Minister informed the Committee that the Government is expected to have the full complement of helicopters by the first quarter of 2029, as per the agreement. The Committee also noted that the proposed multipurpose/multirole helicopters require a production lead time of approximately three years before delivery can be made.

In view of this, the Committee was informed that payments for the four helicopters have been structured to be made from the Government of Ghana's resources over a four-year period. The payment schedule begins in December 2025 with an initial instalment of €62.5 million, followed by subsequent payments in May 2026, March 2027, and December 2028.

The Minister further clarified that all four helicopters under the programme will be fully financed by the Government of Ghana. As such, the transaction is not expected to attract tax liabilities.

However, should any tax-related matters arise, they will be addressed in accordance with Article 174 of the 1992 Constitution.

The Committee noted that overall, the funding arrangement appears to rely on the efficient reallocation and management of existing budgetary resources to honour payment timelines without requiring supplementary budget approval.

The Committee urges the Minister for Finance to formally document the budgetary allocations to finance the aircraft, ensuring that the amount involved is reflected in the fiscal framework to be submitted to Parliament.

Conclusion

The Committee arrived at the conclusion that the acquisition of the four (4) Helicopters and one (1) Aircraft together with Associated support and services for the Ghana Air Force will undoubtedly retool and ensure safety, efficiency, and strategic mobility for the country. The Committee, by consensus, recommend to the House to adopt its report and approve the:

1. Contract Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Defence) And Airbus Helicopter (SAS), France for an amount of one hundred and twenty-five million, nine hundred and sixty- five thousand, nine hundred and seventy-four euros

(€125,965,974.00) for the supply of One H160, and Three H175 Helicopters for the Ghana Airforce; and

2. Sale and Purchase Contract Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Defence) and Dassault Aviation, France, for an amount of sixty million, six hundred and eighty thousand United States dollars (US\$60,680,000.00) for the Acquisition of one (1) Falcon 6X for the Ghana Air Force.

Respectfully submitted.

Question proposed.

Ranking Member of the Committee (Rev John Ntim Fordjour): Mr Speaker, I rise to support the Motion and in so doing to indicate the urgent need for which this whole country will have to stand united with the Ghana Armed Forces and support the efforts of applying some of our modest resources as a State to enhance the air capabilities of our Ghana Armed Forces. Mr Speaker, this is a need that is not a need of today. Indeed, it is a need of yesterday, and it is indeed of yesteryears. When this part of the House on countless occasions attempted to bring our Colleagues in the National Democratic Congress (NDC) along for us to take a proper look at investing into our Ghana Armed Forces, it became a taboo. It became a taboo and propaganda was waged by NDC Members of Parliament (MPs). It became a taboo in this country for one to

even suggest a befitting platform for our Air Force. Mr Speaker, enough of the politics. I believe that this is a new dawn, and a time that has come that a Minority Side of Parliament is doing the patriotic thing of supporting what is good for the State and what is good for the Ghana Armed Forces. This, the *Hansard* must capture.

Mr Speaker, we recall, in this House way back in 2008, the legacy of the New Patriotic Party (NPP) and the commitment of the NPP in retooling our Ghana Armed Forces. When President Kufuor saw the need to be able to equip our Air Force with modernised fleets and even for a long-haul aircraft, wider body aircraft and for a short-haul aircraft to be procured, a similar agreement was submitted before this very House. The same agreement was approved, subsequent to that US\$38 million was paid as part payment for the acquisition of two aircrafts, a Falcon and a wider body aircraft. Because the Government of the day lost power in 2008, the new government took over and failed to see through to that commitment and as a matter of fact only committed to one, which is a Falcon, the Falcon which we are talking about today. If the Government, the then opposition at the time, had been committed as this Side is, we would have had two aircrafts, one long-haul and one short-haul and today there would not be a need to have the conversation we are going to have.

Mr Speaker, this House again is not opposed. Even before the sad 6th August 2025 disaster, which was a national tragedy, we had advanced the argument

that the fleet of the Ghana Armed Forces are ageing, there is a need for us to revamp them and replace them. Let us invest in it.

6:55 p.m.

We had Members of Parliament from the NDC sitting on various platforms, sending and signalling their warning and caution that even if the Falcon we are talking about, which is an aircraft belonging to the Military, and is the executive platform for travels by the President – my good Brother Hon Ablakwa said that even if one engine is faulty, the remaining engines are fit to fly the President. But today we will support him so that we will buy a befitting aircraft that he will accompany the President to fly on. In a most patriotic way, we will put his safety and the safety of the President in priority so that he can safely travel and conduct business on behalf of the State and return safely.

But, Mr Speaker, we are concerned about safety. In terms of safety, we want to put it on record that this Agreement is taking into consideration key recommendations made by the helicopter crash report, which experts advised and recommended that in any event that this State is going to invest into our Air Force, we take into consideration modern avionic features. We ensured by due diligence that the four helicopters that are going to be procured from Airbus meet the requirements by Captain Fordjour and his team.

Mr Speaker, we also did further checks and ascertained that indeed the performance guarantee that is required to

ensure the sustenance of these aircrafts are not in doubt. But we would want to urge the Acting Minister for Defence, who must soon give way for a substantive Minister for Defence, to be particular about every agreement that we have insisted upon. Because this agreement, as we have it, was negotiated and scrutinised in the best interest of the Ghanaian taxpayer by the Committee on Defence and Interior.

Mr Speaker, it is interesting to know that we are going to have our pilots who are going to be assigned to the various platforms for training and to ensure that as formidable and competent as they are, they also refresh their competencies with these key and specific platforms.

The Falcon is not new to this country because the current Falcon 900EX which we have, which in the words of our friends from the NDC is in pristine condition, and in their words a few months ago, was one of the best in Africa requiring no replacement. It is the same and similar Falcon contained in this Agreement.

Mr Speaker, we support this in no doubt. But one would have expected that if a time had come for us to purchase aircraft for the Air Force, we would purchase a long-haul aircraft. An aircraft that can carry a minimum of about 40 to 70 passengers so that when the President is travelling, his key Ministers, aides and accompanying investors will be able to all find space on the same aircraft. But they criticised a short-haul aircraft and they are going to purchase a short-haul aircraft.

Mr Speaker, when we come to the Budget Statement and Economic Policy as was presented by my good friend and neighbour, Dr Cassiel Ato Forson, page 136, paragraph 1091, in the words of the Minister for Finance, and I quote:

“Mr Speaker, the Ghana Air Force will be retooled. Beginning 2026, the Government of Ghana will begin the procurement processes for the acquisition of four modern helicopters, one long-range and one medium-range aircrafts.”

Mr Speaker, what is contained in this agreement is the short-range. We want to hold the Minister to account that his words are documented in the Budget and captured in the *Hansard*. We would ensure that we exercise oversight to ensure that the commitment made to purchase one long-haul aircraft and one short-haul aircraft are not jettisoned.

Mr Speaker, is it not surprising that our Side today are not opposing two aircraft purchases? Is it not patriotic that an opposition is supporting the purchase of four helicopters and two aircrafts? It is because the safety of our men in uniform is very important. The safety of our President is key to this State. They did politics with Presidential aircraft and the fleet of the Air Force. But we, in Twi say that *obi fom kɔm a, yen fom ndwa* to wit, if they were wrong and unpatriotic yesterday, we in opposition today, will take the moral high ground. We will do what is right for our men and our State.

But they must ensure that as they go ahead in the 2026 Budget, maybe by the Mid-Year Budget Review, they need to

create space to accommodate the long-haul. Because that was the vision of President John Agyekum Kufuor way back in 2008. It is not a new vision; it is a vision that they took over and jettisoned. President Kufuor envisioned and signed an agreement for one short-haul aircraft and one long-haul aircraft. For eight years, they resisted us. They made it a taboo to even discuss it, but today, we are supporting them. Let us do what is right for our country.

In so doing, I have a recommendation, Mr Speaker, that considering the vast opportunities we have in the Air Force sector, particularly in safeguarding our extractive assets, we have Tullow Oil, Ente Nazionale Idrocarburi (ENI), Floating Production Storage and Offloading (FPSOs), we have our gold and many of the oil deposits and assets. These are paying huge sums of dollars, millions of them every month to foreign aviation companies.

If we resource our Air Force, they are more than enough and they are more competent. They have more gravitas to be able to undertake these services to generate Internally Generated Funds (IGF). This IGF, if we take it away from the foreign aviation companies, will even pay for the aircraft by itself. They have demonstrated it before. They were able to deploy a similar arrangement to purchase two ships, which are paying for themselves.

So, we must encourage the Minister on the best course of action, in addition to what we are supporting, so that from the purse of the public today we are using

to acquire these aircraft— Let us encourage such innovative arrangements, so that we can buy as many as 10 aircraft, or even more, to augment on the assets of our Air Force, such that we continue to hold high the flag and continue to remain one of the most formidable in the sub-region.

But to conclude, Mr Speaker, I want to commend the Chief of Defence Staff and the Military high command for the innovation that they have put into the management of the Military, in enhancing their air capabilities. They have invented homemade drones, which will come and add up to our helicopters and the Falcon we are going to purchase to beef up our air capabilities.

That invention and innovation is worth commending. But to signal, Mr Speaker, never again must politicians politicise retooling of the Ghana Armed Forces. Never again must politicians play the ostrich and oppose what is right for our country and wait for disaster to strike before we accept the technical reports given by the same soldiers four, five or three years ago indicating ageing fleets.

They said no, the fleets were not ageing, they were new. Today, they are saying that the fleets are ageing. There is so much more that for security sensitivities, I will not mention here, but when the Committee of the Whole is given that opportunity by the Speaker, a lot of things must be said so that our Colleagues on the other Side will repent from their sins of politicising retooling of the Ghana Armed Forces.

7:05p.m

This agreement must be a turnaround, and it must be a cure to the disease of the politicians that never again must we politicise the safety of our soldiers; never again must we politicise the safety of our President. But we are happy, in three years, it is expected that the Falcon will arrive, and around the same time. It is expected that the four helicopters will also arrive to enhance the battle readiness of our Armed Forces, and by which time, our Colleagues will be on this Side, and we will be on the right-hand Side of the Speaker. We will ensure we continue the investments into the security sector.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, we unreservedly support the retooling of our Ghana Armed Forces.

I thank you.

Question put and Motions agreed to.

Resolved:

That this honourable House adopt the Report of the Committee on Defence and Interior on the Contract Agreement between Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Defence) and Airbus Helicopter (SAS), France, for an amount of One Hundred and Twenty-Five Million, Nine Hundred and Sixty-Five Thousand, Nine Hundred and Seventy-Four Euros €125,965,974.00 for the supply of One (1) H160 and Three (3) H175 Helicopters for the Ghana Air Force.

AND

That this Honourable House adopts the Report of the Committee on Defence and Interior on the Sale and Purchase Contract Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Defence) and Dassault Aviation, France, for an amount of sixty million, six hundred and eighty thousand United States dollars (US\$60,680,000.00) for the acquisition of One (1) Falcon 6X for the Ghana Air Force.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we have made tremendous progress in our democratic development. Some time ago, it was not easy to have access to the Ghana Armed Forces, to access the armoury and equipment they were purchasing. I am happy to hear from both of you, both Sides of the House, that now that access is available and you have been able to go through it to make sure that what is being acquired is in the national interest, we will try to progress on this and to make sure that there are no dark corners anywhere in our governance system and that we have civilian control of the security forces in the country; that is what democracy is about. When you hide anything, it tends to haunt you. When you throw light on it, then you diffuse it. So, I want to thank the Members of the Committee and Hon Members for doing a good job, and also add my voice in thanking the Ghana Armed Forces for opening up to the scrutiny of Parliament.

We thank you all.

May we now take Resolutions 19 and 22, moved together by the Minister for Defence.

RESOLUTIONS

Contract Agreement between GoG and Airbus Helicopter for the Supply of One H160 and Three H175

Ag Minister for Defence (Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson) (MP): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

BY THE PROVISIONS of Article 181(5) of the Constitution, the terms and conditions of any international business or economic transaction to which the Government of Ghana is a party shall not come into operation unless the said terms and conditions have been laid before Parliament and approved by Parliament by a Resolution supported by the votes of a majority of all Members of Parliament

PURSUANT to the provisions of the said Article 181(5) of the Constitution, and at the request of the Government of Ghana acting through the Minister responsible for Defence, there has been laid before Parliament, the terms and conditions of a Contract Agreement between Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Defence) and Airbus Helicopter (SAS), France, for an amount of one hundred and twenty-five million, nine hundred and sixty-five thousand, nine hundred and seventy-four euros €125,965,974.00 for the

supply of One (1) H160 and Three (3) H175 Helicopters for the Ghana Air Force.

Contract Agreement between the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Defence) and Dassault Aviation, France

Ag Minister for Defence (Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson) (MP): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

BY THE PROVISIONS of Article 181(5) of the Constitution, the terms and conditions of any international business or economic transaction to which the Government of Ghana is a party shall not come into operation unless the said terms and conditions have been laid before Parliament and approved by Parliament by a Resolution supported by the votes of a majority of all Members of Parliament.

PURSUANT to the provisions of the said Article 181(5) of the Constitution, and at the request of the Government of Ghana acting through the Minister responsible for Defence, there has been laid before Parliament the terms and conditions of a Contract Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Defence) and Dassault Aviation, France, for an amount of sixty million, six hundred and eighty thousand United States dollars (US\$60,680,000.00) for the acquisition of One (1) Falcon 6X for the Ghana Air Force.

Chairman of the Committee (Mr James Agalga): Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion for the adoption of the two resolutions

Question put and Motion agreed to

Resolved accordingly.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I humbly want to bring this to the notice of the Majority Leadership that at Conclave, we agreed that because tomorrow is a Farmers' Day and Saturday is the funeral of our late Colleague, we had agreed to close at 5 p.m. We have gone on to work for an extra two hours. It is now 7 p.m. I would want to plead with our Colleagues that we call it a night and draw the curtains, and then we can continue on Tuesday. Clearly, Colleagues are exhausted.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I was hoping that we could have taken a couple more of the Reports, but I can appreciate the sentiments of my Brother. It has been a long day; in fact, he and I have not stepped out. We have just been here. So, we agree that we have had a long day.

The Speaker: Are you sure you have not stepped out?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I speak in context. *[Laughter]*

So, we would bring the curtains down on today's Business. We have done more than five hours. So, we are entirely in your hands in this matter.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 7:14 p.m. till Tuesday, 9th December, 2025, at 12:00 p.m.

Editor's Note

This Official Report was corrected by the House on 18th December, 2025.